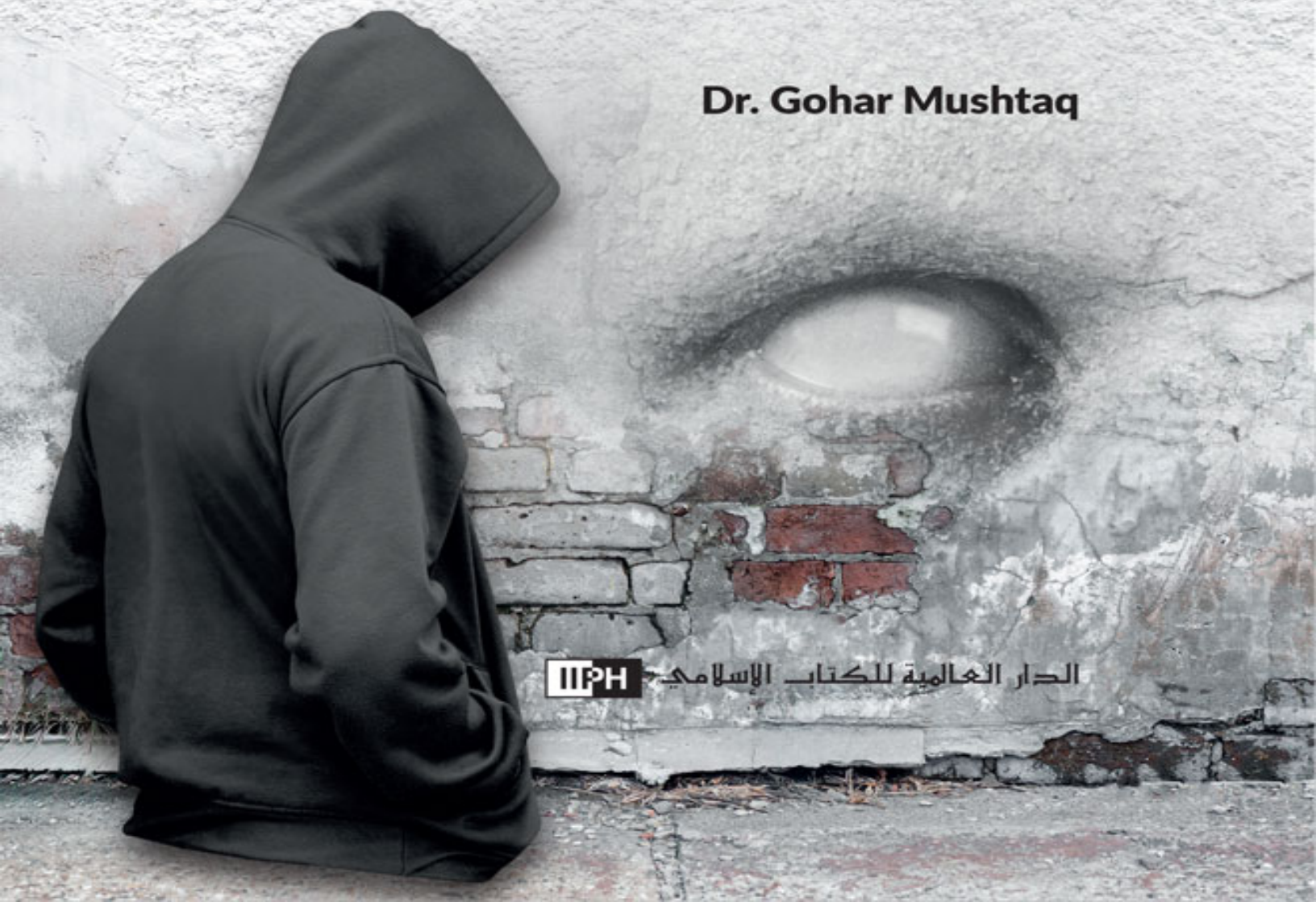
MUSLIM YOUTH IN THE AGE OF DAJJÂL

شباب المسلمين في عهد الدجّال

Dr. Gohar Mushtaq



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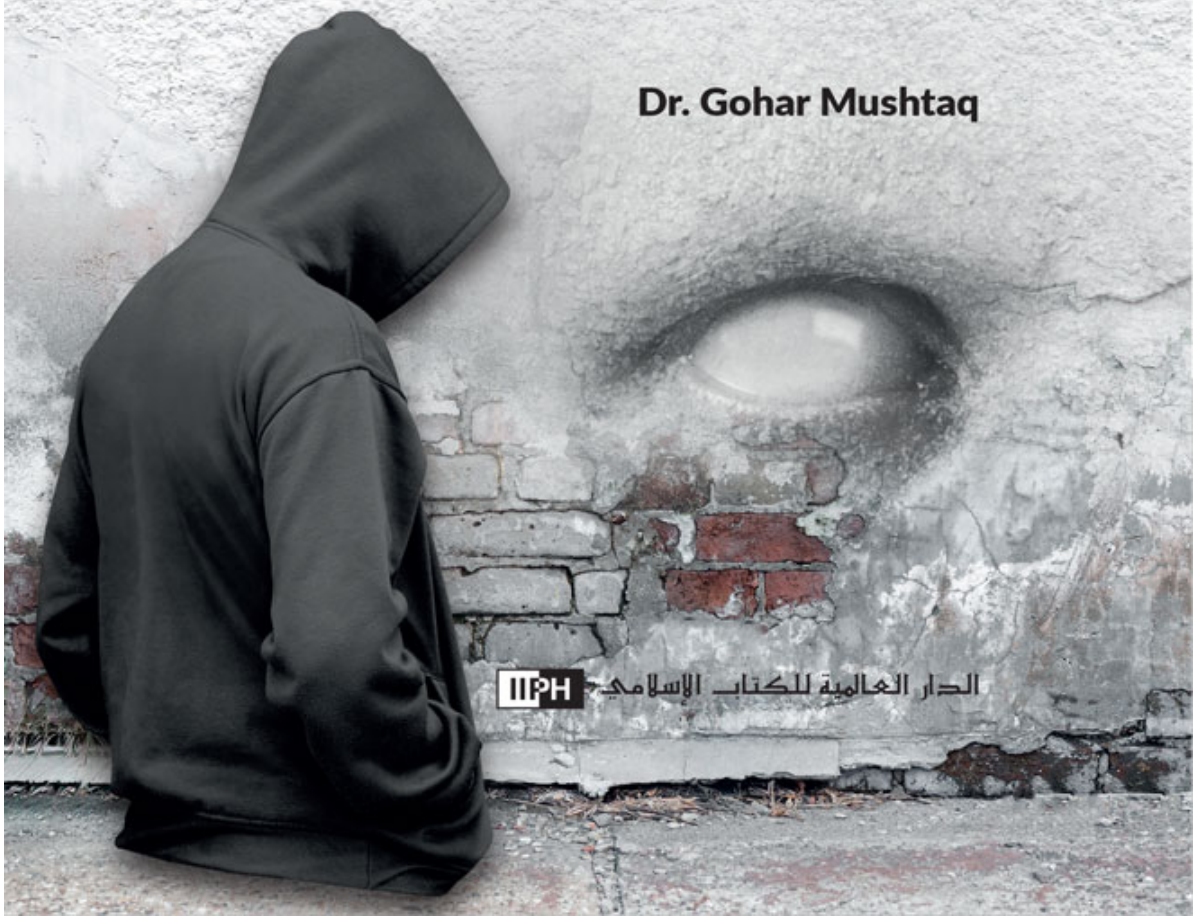

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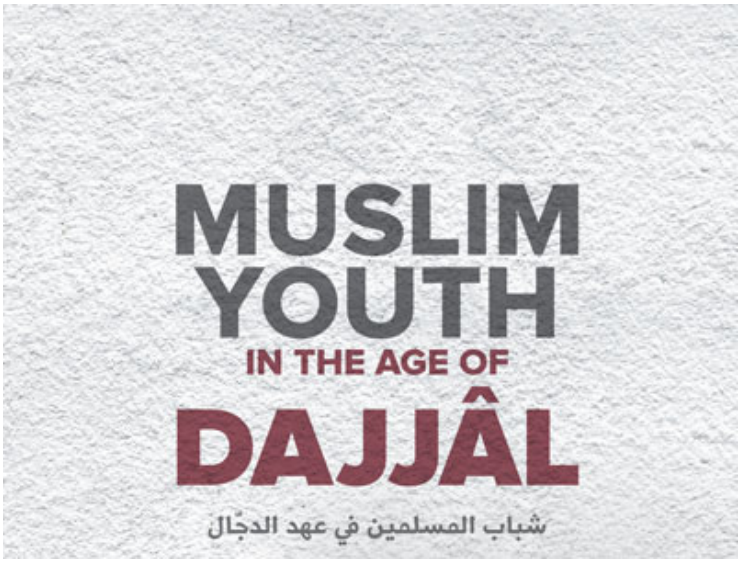
IN THE NAME OF

ALLAH

THE ALL-COMPASSIONATE, ALL-MERCIFUL



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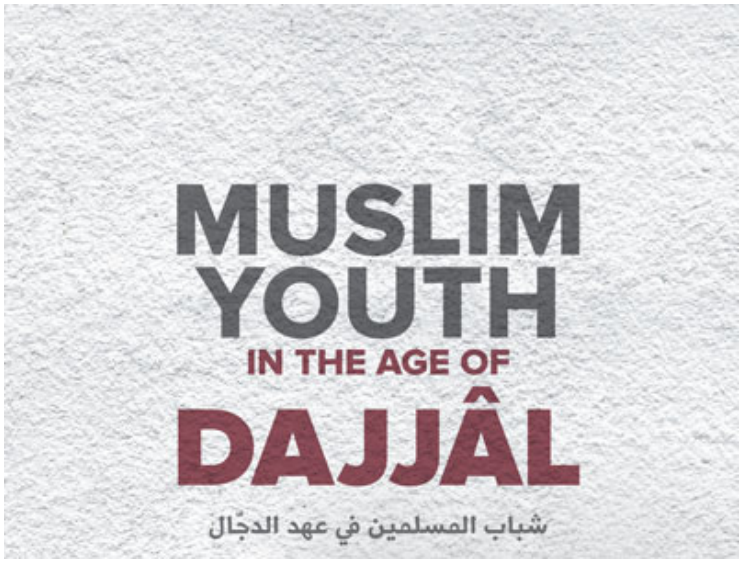

Dr. Gohar Mushtaq

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Pronunciation and Transliteration Chart

Arabic script	Pronunciation	Transliterated form
أ	short ‘a’, as in *cat*	a
آ — ى	longer ‘a’, as in *cab* (not as in *cake*)	â
ب	/b/ as in *bell*, *rubber* and *tab*	b
ت	/t/ as in *tap*, *mustard* and *sit*	t
ة	takes the sound of the preceding diacritical mark sometimes ending in h (when in pausal form): ah, ih or ooh; or atu(n), ati(n) or ata(n) when uninterrupted	h or t (when followed by another Arabic word)
ث	/th/ as in *thing*, *maths* and *wealth*	th
ج	/j/ as in *jam*, *ajar* and *age*	j
ح	a ‘harsher’ sound than the English initial /h/, and may occur medially and in word-final position as well	ḥ
خ	as in *Bach* (in German); may occur initially and medially as well	kh

د	/d/ as in *do*, *muddy* and *red*	d
ذ	as in *this*, *father* and *smooth*	dh
ر	/r/ as in *raw*, *arid* and *war*; may also be a rolled ‘r’, as pronounced in Spanish	r
ز	/z/ as in *zoo*, *easy* and *gaze*	z
س	/s/ as in *so*, *messy* and *grass*	s
ش	as in *ship*, *ashes* and *rush*	sh
ص	no close equivalent in English, but may be approximated by pronouncing it as /sw/ or /s/ farther back in the mouth	ṣ
ض	no close equivalent in English, but may be approximated by pronouncing it as /d/ farther back in the mouth	ḍ
ط	no close equivalent in English, but may be approximated by pronouncing it as /t/ farther back in the mouth	ṭ
ظ	no close equivalent in English, but may be approximated by pronouncing ‘the’ farther back in the mouth	<u>dh</u>
ع	no close equivalent in English: a guttural sound in the back of the throat	‘
غ	no close equivalent in English, but may be closely approximated by pronouncing it like the French /r/ in ‘rouge’	gh
ف	/f/ as in *fill*, *effort* and *muff*	f

ق	no close equivalent in English, but may be approximated by pronouncing it as /k/ farther back in the mouth	q
ك	/k/ as in *king*, *buckle* and *tack*	k
ل	/l/ as in *lap*, *halo*; in the word Allah, it becomes velarized as in *ball*	l
م	/m/ as in *men*, *simple* and *ram*	m
ن	/n/ as in *net*, *ant* and *can*	n
هـ - ه - ه	/h/ as in *hat*; unlike /h/ in English, in Arabic /h/ is pronounced in medial and word-final positions as well	h
و	as in *wet* and *away*	w
و	long ‘u’, as in *boot* and *too*	oo
ي	as in *yard* and *mayo*	y
ي	long ‘e’, as in *eat*, *beef* and *see*	ee
ء	glottal stop: may be closely approximated by pronouncing it like ‘t’ in the Cockney English pronunciation of *butter*: *bu’er*, or the stop sound in *uh-oh!*	(omitted in initial position)

Diphthongs

Arabic script	Pronunciation	Transliterated form
أو، ◌َ و	long ‘o’, as in *owe*, *boat* and *go*	au, aw
أي، ◌َ ي	long ‘a’, as in *aid*, *rain* and *say*	ay, ai, ei

Diacritical marks (*tashkeel*)

Name of mark	Pronunciation	Transliterated form
◌َ fatḥah	very short ‘a’ or schwa (unstressed vowel)	a
◌ِ kasrah	shorter version of ee or schwa (unstressed vowel)	i
◌ُ ḍammah	shorter version of oo	u
◌ّ shaddah	a doubled consonant is stressed in the word, and the length of the sound is also doubled	double letter
◌ْ sukoon	no vowel sound between consonants or at the end of a word	absence of vowel

Honorific phrases

(the Exalted)	used after the mention of God/Allah to express: *Glorified and Exalted is He*
(bpuh)	*Blessings and peace be upon him*; used after mention of the Prophet Muhammad
(pbuh)	*Peace be upon him*; used after mention of any prophet or after mention of Angel Gabriel
(May Allah be pleased with him)	used after mention of a male Companion of the Prophet
(May Allah be pleased with her)	used after mention of a female Companion of the Prophet
(May Allah be pleased with both of them)	used after mention of two Companions of the Prophet
(May Allah be pleased with all of them)	used after mention of three or more Companions of the Prophet

Hadith grade terms

Sound:	*ṣaḥeeḥ*
Reliable:	*ḥasan*
Weak:	*ḍa'eef*
Odd:	*ghareeb*
Authentic:	includes sound, reliable, or any grade in between
Acceptable:	*sakat 'anhu;* the grader of the hadith did not comment on it, meaning that he found nothing unacceptable in it

About the Word '*Lord*'

The word lord in English has several related meanings. The original meaning is 'master' or 'ruler', and in this sense it is often used to refer to human beings: 'the lord of the mansion' or 'Lord So-and-So' (in the United Kingdom, for example). The word *Lord* with a capital L is used in the lexicon of Islam to refer to the One and Only God –Allah. In Islam, there is no ambiguity about the meaning of this word. While it is true that one may occasionally use the word *lord* (whether capitalized or not) to refer to a human being, in Islamic discourse the reference of this term is always clear from the context. Whereas for Christians, Hindus and other polytheists, the word *Lord* with a capital L may refer to Allah, to Jesus or to some imagined deity, for Muslims, there can be no plurality of meaning. Allah alone is the Lord, and the Lord is Allah – not Jesus, not Rama, not any other being.

The Editor

Publisher's Note

All praises and thanks belong to Allah alone, the One, the Almighty, and All-Merciful. Blessings and peace be upon Prophet Muhammad (bpuh), the last of His messengers and prophets, and upon his family, his Companions, and all those who follow in his footsteps until the end of time.

Muslim youth are the future of the Muslim community. Unfortunately, in the present era, most of them blindly follow in the footsteps of the West. *Muslim Youth in the Age of Dajjâl* is a wake-up call for all the young, energetic, and enthusiastic members of the Ummah. Through this book, Dr. Gohar Mushtaq has endeavoured to rekindle the passion for Islam in the Muslim youth by identifying the agents of Dajjâl and the web of deception they are weaving to mislead them.

He eloquently unveils the tactics of the 'one-eyed' mass media and the way its agents, namely the television, computer, Internet, cable, satellite dish, video cameras, social media, chatting, and texting, are rigorously working to prepare the stage for the coming of the 'great deceiver'. This book not only discusses the various problems faced by the Muslim youth in these trying times but also suggests viable solutions to overcome them. Penned in the light of the Qur'an and Sunnah, it is a guide for the young generation to help them find the right path amidst the myriads of deviations that threaten to usurp their identity.

May Allah accept the efforts of all those who contributed to the production of this book, and may it be acceptable to Him, *âmeen*.

Muhammad Abdul Mohsin Al-Tuwaijri

Managing Director
International Islamic Publishing House
Riyadh, Saudi Arabia

About the Author

Dr. Gohar Mushtaq received his Bachelor of Science degree from York College, The City University, New York in 1995 where he was the Valedictorian of his graduating class. Specializing in the field of biophysical chemistry, Dr. Mushtaq went on to receive his M.S. and Ph.D. degrees from Rutgers University along with an award for 'Graduate Teaching Excellence'.

From his childhood, he received thorough Islamic education from his father. Later on, he studied classical Islamic sciences from various Islamic teachers including Sheikh Abdur Rehman Kaashmiri (Brooklyn, New York), Sheikh Dr. Ismael Mehmood al-Azharee (New Jersey), Mufti Abdur Rehman ibn Yusuf (UK), and Imam Tarek Chebbi al-Tunisi (Florida).

Dr. Mushtaq frequently delivers Friday sermons and lectures at various mosques and Islamic centres in the areas of New York, New Jersey, and Connecticut. He contributes magazine articles in English to *AlJumuah* and *The Islamic Voice* and magazine articles in Urdu to *Batool.* He is the author of the following books:

- *The Intelligent Heart, The Pure Heart: An Insight into the Heart based on the Qur'an, Sunnah and Modern Science* (London: Ta-Ha Publishers)

- *Islam: Its Beauty & Wisdom* (Maryland, USA: Amana Publications)
- *The Music Made Me Do It – An In-Depth Study of Music through Islam and Science* (Riyadh: IIPH)
- *The Hijab: Liberation or Oppression? A Detailed Discussion in the Light of Scientific Research* (Riyadh: IIPH)
- *Growing a Beard: In the Light of the Qur'an, Sunnah, and Modern Science* (Riyadh: IIPH)
- *Muslim Youth in the Age of Dajjâl* (Riyadh: IIPH)

Introduction

Youth are the backbone of every society. If they have a strong character and are goal-oriented, they formulate a strong foundation for their society. Our future is built around the youth of today. Nations rise at the shoulders of their enthusiastic youth. What we teach and how we treat our young generations today will have a great impact on our tomorrow. Unfortunately, we find that many Muslim youth today are following the exact footsteps of Western non-Muslim youth, spending their time and creative energies in vain pursuits like playing video games, surfing the Internet, watching movies, wasting their time on social media, and smoking, to name just a few. Our Muslim youth have immense potential that is bursting forth with energy, but it needs to be channelled in the right direction.

This is the age of great confusion for Muslim youth because it is the age of Dajjâl (the Antichrist).[1] Thanks to the brainwashing by today's mass media, even the most patient and sensible Muslim youth are confused. We know from the teachings of our beloved Prophet Muhammad (*ṣalla Allâhu 'alayhi wa sallam* – blessings and peace be upon him) that the final attack of Dajjâl will be on the Muslim family system, including the Muslim youth. The purpose of writing this book is to save the Muslim family system, which is under direct attack in this age of Dajjâl. The aim of this book is to

discuss the problems faced by Muslim youth in the age of Dajjâl and the solutions to those problems.

It should be noted that this book does not intend to negate the importance of Muslim elders; its purpose is to emphasize the importance of the Muslim youth for they are our future. This book is written not just for the young but also the elderly as they are a major factor in how our youth behave in the future. Muslim youth need guidance, patience, knowledge, and experience from their Muslim parents, teachers, and religious leaders. I have presented the latest scientific research in this book in order to expose the trials and tribulations faced by our Muslim youth. I have done this because our youth are living in a rational age and, due to their lack of faith, they question their parents whenever they are prohibited from something. Our modern-day Muslim youth understand the language of science and so this is the language in which this book is written, while maintaining the superiority of the Qur'an and Sunnah (the practice and collected sayings of Prophet Muhammad [bpuh]) above everything else.

When someone asked the late Islamic scholar Shaykh Muhammad ibn Ṣâliḥ al-'Uthaymeen about how to seek Islamic knowledge and call others to Islam, he responded as follows:

> At this opportunity, I would like to encourage students of knowledge to gain some knowledge that pertains to logical proofs [scientific proofs]. Why? Because of their weak faith, people today are more easily convinced by what is palpable and tangible than by Islamic proofs. I call upon my brothers among students of knowledge to study logical proofs, to study the rationale behind certain legislations and beliefs. If anyone wants to correct me on this point, he needs to refer to the writings of Shaykh Al-Islam Ibn Taymiyyah, particularly those writings wherein he refuted philosophers, logicians, and others of their like. If

students today were to refer to his work, they would find that he spoke by the Islamic proof and by the proof of sound [scientific] reasoning.[2]

I would like to express my special thanks to Engineer Zahid Mahmood for his patience in reading the manuscript of my book and his deep and insightful comments about it. My indebtedness and gratitude must also be expressed to Brother Jamal Malik for his valuable suggestions. I owe a debt of gratitude to my parents, my wife, and the 'Muslim youth in my home' (my children) for encouraging me during the production of this work.

Dr. Gohar Mushtaq

California, USA

Chapter 1: Muslim Youth in the Age of Dajjâl

There is no doubt that Dajjâl is a human being who will possess certain supernatural powers and appear towards the end of time. Various hadiths (statements or actions) of Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) mention the many signs of Dajjâl's coming, which are essentially the signs of the end of time. Many of these signs have already occurred which is why it would not be inappropriate to call this modern age the 'age of Dajjâl'. The difficult tests and evils that come with the arrival of Dajjâl will be the greatest tribulation for humanity.

'Imrân ibn Ḥuṣayn (*raḍiya Allâhu 'anhu* – may Allah [*Subḥânahu wa ta'âlâ* – Glorified and Exalted is He] be pleased with him) reported that he heard Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) say:

«مَا بَيْنَ خَلْقِ آدَمَ إِلَى قِيَامِ السَّاعَةِ، أَمْرٌ أَكْبَرُ مِنَ الدَّجَّالِ.»

«From Adam's birth till the advent of the Day of Judgement, there will be no *fitnah* (trial or tribulation) greater than that of Dajjâl.» (Muslim)[3,4]

Al-Maseeḥ ad-Dajjâl refers to 'the deceiving Messiah', the great deceiver, whose arrival near the end of time is prophesized in various

authentic hadiths of Prophet Muhammad (bpuh). Ibn ‘Umar (may Allah be pleased with both of them) narrated:

قَامَ رَسُولُ اللهِ صَلَّى اللهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ فِي النَّاسِ فَأَثْنَى عَلَى اللهِ بِمَا هُوَ أَهْلُهُ ثُمَّ ذَكَرَ الدَّجَّالَ فَقَالَ: « إِنِّي لَأُنْذِرُكُمُوهُ، وَمَا مِنْ نَبِيٍّ إِلَّا أَنْذَرَهُ قَوْمَهُ، لَقَدْ أَنْذَرَ نُوحٌ قَوْمَهُ، وَلَكِنِّي أَقُولُ لَكُمْ فِيهِ قَوْلًا لَمْ يَقُلْهُ نَبِيٌّ لِقَوْمِهِ: تَعْلَمُونَ أَنَّهُ أَعْوَرُ، وَأَنَّ اللهَ لَيْسَ بِأَعْوَرَ.»

«Allah’s Messenger (bpuh) stood amongst the people. He glorified and praised Allah as He deserves. Then, mentioning Dajjâl, he said: I warn you about him (Dajjâl), and every prophet warned his nation about him. No doubt, Noah (*‘alayhi as-salâm* – peace be upon him) warned his nation about him. However, I tell you about him something which no prophet has informed his nation before me. You should know that he is one-eyed, and Allah is not one-eyed.» (Bukhari)[5]

In another hadith, the same message is relayed as follows:

«Allah is not one-eyed; Dajjâl is blind in the right eye, and his eye looks like a protruding grape.» (Bukhari)[6]

Prophet Muhammad’s Companions (*raḍiya Allâhu ‘anhum* – may Allah be pleased with all of them) were always very conscious of the coming of Dajjâl as they expected it to happen in their lifetime. When Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) met Ibn Ṣayyâd (who was blind in one eye and a disbeliever until that time) and asked him some questions, ‘Umar ibn al-Khaṭṭâb (may Allah be pleased with him) became upset at his replies.

«He said to Allah’s Messenger (bpuh): O Allah’s Messenger! Allow me to chop off his head.

The Prophet (bpuh) said: If he is him (Dajjâl), you cannot overpower him; if he is not him, you are not going to benefit by murdering him.» (Bukhari)[7]

Agents of Dajjâl in the age of Dajjâl

Sadly, we notice today that Muslims have become totally heedless about the coming of Dajjâl, so much so that if we say that we are living in the age of Dajjâl, some say, “No, we still have time.” If this is not the age of Dajjâl (when more than fourteen centuries have passed since the time of the Prophet’s Companions) then what else is this age? Today, the agents of Dajjâl have penetrated the household of every Muslim in the form of television, computer, Internet, cable, satellite dish, video cameras, social media, chatting, and texting, to name just a few. The agents of Dajjâl are preparing the stage for the coming of the ‘great deceiver’. In fact, the stage is well-prepared for the coming of Dajjâl; it is only a matter of time before Dajjâl will appear on this stage in human form. We should not be surprised at the heedlessness of present-day Muslims about the coming of Dajjâl and the negligence of Muslim parents about the agents of Dajjâl in their homes. This negligence was prophesized in the hadith of our beloved Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) as one of the signs of the age of Dajjâl. Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) said:

«لَا يَخْرُجُ الدَّجَّالُ حَتَّى يَذْهَلَ النَّاسُ عَنْ ذِكْرِهِ، وَحَتَّى تَتْرُكَ الْأَئِمَّةُ ذِكْرَهُ عَلَى المَنَابِرِ.»

«Dajjâl will not appear until people become negligent in talking about him and the imams (leaders) abandon talking about him on the pulpits (in their Friday sermons).» (Recorded by Aḥmad, Ibn Ḥajar, and Mâlik, and authenticated by al-Haythami)[8]

The final attack of Dajjâl will be on the Muslim family system. Men alone cannot make a family; it is the women and children that constitute the fundamental building blocks of this system. It is important to be aware, in the light of this, that Dajjâl will lure women into his web of deception. It

was reported in a hadith narrated by Ibn ‘Umar (may Allah be pleased with both of them) that the last attack of Dajjâl will be on Muslim women:

«يَنْزِلُ الدَّجَّالُ فِي هَذِهِ السَّبَخَةِ بِمَرِّقَنَاةَ، فَيَكُونُ أَكْثَرَ مَنْ يَخْرُجُ إِلَيْهِ النِّسَاءُ، حَتَّى إِنَّ الرَّجُلَ لَيَرْجِعُ إِلَى حَمِيمِهِ وَإِلَى أُمِّهِ وَابْنَتِهِ وَأُخْتِهِ وَعَمَّتِهِ، فَيُوثِقُهَا رِبَاطًا، مَخَافَةَ أَنْ تَخْرُجَ إِلَيْهِ.»

«Dajjâl will make a stop at a place called Marqanât. Upon hearing about his arrival, the last ones to rush towards him will be women, until a man has to return home to his mother, his daughter, his sister, and his aunt and tie them up strongly (restrain them) out of fear that they will go out to him (and get caught up in his evil or deception).» (Recorded by Aḥmad, aṭ-Ṭabarâni, and al-Haythami; its chain contains a weak narrator)[9]

In this hadith, our beloved Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) has forewarned the Muslims that one of the signs of the end of time is that the last people to follow Dajjâl will be women. His spell over women will be so impenetrable that «a man will have to return home to his mother, his daughter, his sister, and his aunt and tie them up strongly (restrain them) out of fear that they will go out to him (and get caught up in his evil or deception).»

This hadith is telling us that many Muslim women will be deceived by the ‘great deceiver’ because Dajjâl will seduce them with deceptive yet destructive words that will appear pleasing and positive to them.

Today, extreme feminists are using the seductive power of media and movies to persuade young women to abandon modesty and virginity. Some of them claim that there are no biological differences between men and women, and hence, we can create a unisex society – a society where gender roles are blurred between males and females and a society which does not take into consideration the nurturing role of a mother and the bread-winning role of a father.

In this time and age, the world media and United Nations have become the ‘United Nations against the Islamic family system’. Under the guise of “women’s liberation”, Dajjâl’s media is telling women that they cannot have an identity of their own or be ‘free’ if they are mothers or housewives; it is forcing them to choose between being a mother and homemaker, and on the other hand, leaving all that behind and choosing a career instead. Catchy slogans that are used to seduce women are, ‘Society cannot progress if we confine women within the boundaries of home’ and ‘Men and women are like the two wheels of a car, and a car cannot operate if one of its wheels is jammed’.

We have also been informed by our beloved Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) that Dajjâl will have no children of his own. This implies that the way of life promoted by Dajjâl will be an ‘anti-family lifestyle’. In a hadith narrated by Abu Sa‘eed al-Khudri, Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) said about Dajjâl:

«إِنَّهُ لَا يُولَدُ لَهُ.»

«He (Dajjâl) will not have any children.» (Muslim)[10]

One important characteristic of the age of Dajjâl is that it targets the youth of a society, and it does so because young people tend to gravitate towards sensuality. Dajjâl himself will be a young man, as mentioned in the following hadith of Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) narrated by an-Nawwâs ibn Sam‘ân:

«إِنَّهُ شَابٌّ قَطَطٌ عَيْنُهُ طَافِئَةٌ.»

«He (Dajjâl) will be a young man with twisted, cropped hair and a blind eye.» (Muslim)[11]

This could mean that Dajjâl will glorify and promote the youth-worshipping culture of today's world. In the age of Dajjâl, the youth will be desensitized to any sense of morality; they will be addicted to promiscuity and a materialistic lifestyle without being fully aware of it.

In this age of Dajjâl, Islam has been labelled as a 'religion of terror' by the Western media. It is becoming tougher and tougher to survive as a practicing Muslim in this age. Practicing Muslims are labelled as 'fundamentalists' and 'extremists'. The media promotes and admires the 'moderate Muslim' and 'moderate Islam'. This 'moderate Islam' is redefined in these modern times by modernist Muslim scholars. This 'moderate Islam' is the 'new and revised' edition of Islam and is very different from the Islam taught to us in the Qur'an and the Sunnah of our beloved Prophet Muhammad (bpuh). The reality is that the very concept of 'moderate Islam' is a tumour in the body of the Muslim community.

The Qur'an divides people into three types:

1. A true believer in the oneness of Allah;
2. A disbeliever in Allah and his Messenger Muhammad (bpuh) and;
3. A hypocrite whose heart has a disease and who will be thrown in the lowest part of hell.

The Qur'an does not make any distinction between a 'moderate Muslim' and an 'extremist Muslim'. The Qur'an tells us that if people are not true believers, they are either disbelievers or hypocrites. Likewise, there is no such thing as a non-practicing Muslim. In Islam, faith and good works go hand-in-hand. A mere verbal declaration of faith is not sufficient because belief in Allah makes obedience to Him obligatory. Being a Muslim necessitates conviction by the heart, declaration by the tongue, and implementation by the limbs.

Today, our Muslim youth are living in an age of Dajjâl where evil is rampant and the Muslim family system is in grave danger. Today's Muslim parents will commit a fatal error if they think that their children and youth will remain innocent and pure even after being provided with every means and vehicle to sin. A substantial number of youth spend the bulk of their media time in the absence of adults, as the authors of the Henry J. Kaiser Family Foundation report on kids and media assert:

> Parents frequently are not present when their children are engaged in media activities, so they may be unaware of how much of which media and what content their children consume under what conditions.[12]

As Muslim parents, we cannot expect purity of heart and mind if we let our youth spend their time surfing in the dark streets of the Internet. We cannot save our Muslim youth from engaging in cyber love affairs and becoming victims of cyber crimes if they are consistently occupied on social media. We cannot expect our daughters to observe hijab (veil) if they spend their time in front of webcams through which their bodies can be seen by inappropriate men on the Internet. The purpose of writing this book is to expose the real face of the media and the workings of the agents of Dajjâl to the Muslims so that they do not fall into these traps.

Different stages in the lives of human beings

Human life undergoes various stages between the cradle and the grave. This journey of human beings from the womb to the tomb encompasses infancy, childhood, youth, adulthood, and old age. The Qur'an mentions:

{And Allah created you; then He will take you in death. And among you is he who is reversed to the most decrepit [old] age so that he will not know,

after [having had] knowledge, a thing. Indeed, Allah is Knowing and Competent.} *(an-Naḥl 16: 70)*[13]

Contemporary Nigerian Islamic scholar Abu Bakr Maḥmood Jumi writes the following in his commentary on the Qur'an:

> According to certain Islamic scholars, human life can be divided into four stages after birth. The first stage starts from birth and extends up to the age of thirty-three. This is the period from childhood to youth during which our physical and mental capabilities increase every day. The second stage extends from age thirty-three to forty. This is the stage of adulthood when human abilities flourish further and reach their climax. The third stage is known as *kahoola* or middle age, which spans from age forty to sixty during which the mental and physical faculties start to decline at a steady pace. The fourth and last stage is the old age, extending from age sixty till death, when human body undergoes quick decline in its abilities and functions.[14]

Importance of the period of youth

The Qur'an and Hadith (the collected statements and actions of Prophet Muhammad [bpuh]) make special mention of young age. Youth is the period when human capabilities are at their peak, and it is easy to get attracted to the various temptations of Satan. The Qur'an regards this age as the age of strength:

{It is Allah Who created you in a state of weakness, then after weakness He gave you strength, then after strength, weakness and grey hair. He creates as He wills, and He is the All-Knowing, Omnipotent.} *(ar-Room 30: 54)*

The Prophet (bpuh) made special reference to this stage in a number of hadiths, which alludes to its sensitivity and importance. In one hadith

narrated by Abu Hurayrah, the Prophet (bpuh) specifically mentioned seven types of people who will be honoured and comforted under the shade of Allah's Throne on the Day of Judgement:

«سَبْعَةٌ يُظِلُّهُمُ اللهُ فِي ظِلِّهِ، يَوْمَ لَا ظِلَّ إِلَّا ظِلُّهُ :... وَشَابٌّ نَشَأَ فِي عِبَادَةِ اللهِ.»

«Seven types of people will be honoured and comforted under the shade of Allah's glorious Throne on the Day when there will be no shade except that… One of them is a young man (or woman) who grows up in devotion and commitment to the service of Allah.» (Bukhari and Muslim)[15]

This hadith informs us about the critical nature of the adolescent period which is flooded with temptations, and any young person who resists these temptations deserves to be specifically comforted on the Day of Judgement. Likewise, in another hadith, the Prophet (bpuh) made special mention of the age of youth:

«اغْتَنِمْ خَمْسًا قَبْلَ خَمْسٍ: شَبَابَكَ قَبْلَ هَرَمِكَ، وَصِحَّتَكَ قَبْلَ سَقَمِكَ، وَغِنَاكَ قَبْلَ فَقْرِكَ، وَفَرَاغَكَ قَبْلَ شُغْلِكَ، وَحَيَاتَكَ قَبْلَ مَوْتِكَ.»

«Take advantage of five things before five things: your youth before your old age, your health before your sickness, your wealth before your poverty, your free time before you become busy, and your life before your death.» (A sound hadith recorded by al-Ḥâkim)[16]

Youth is such an important time in one's life that on the Day of Judgement, a separate question will be asked regarding the way a person spent his or her years of youth. Did one spend one's youth doing acts of obedience to Allah or acts of disobedience to Him? 'Abdullâh ibn Mas'ood (may Allah be pleased with him) narrated that the Messenger of Allah (bpuh) said:

«The two feet of the son of Adam will not move from near his Lord on the Day of Judgement until he is asked about five (matters): his life and how he spent it; his youth and how he took care of it; his wealth, how he earned it, and where he spent it; and what he did with what he knew.» (A sound hadith recorded by at-Tirmidhi)[17]

Without a doubt, youth is often a time when people try to find new meaning in their lives. Western psychologists and sociologists have accentuated the importance of this critical period in human personality development. Joseph Chilton Pearce is an American intellectual, and his expertise is in child development. He writes the following about the developmental psychology of youth:

> Adolescents sense a secret, unique greatness in themselves that seeks expression. They gesture toward the heart when trying to express any of this, a significant clue to the whole affair… Feeling uniquely selected for some great task, some ultimate challenge, the young person looks for a vehicle that will express that specialness or a person who represents such a potential.[18]

In the same vein, Betty Staley, a psychologist and Waldorf teacher at Rudolf Steiner College (California), stresses the importance of the adolescents' search for an ideal. In her book *Between form and freedom*, she notes that as children reach the age of youth, they develop a concept of sacred idealism in themselves that forces them to look for someone to act as their model who they can then emulate. By following a role model, the youth feel that they can express their inner feelings of greatness.[19]

For this reason, youth can be considered the most important stage during which people search for meaning in their lives and, in the words of Pearce, they turn to their heart for guidance. The youth have an interesting relationship with their hearts, as current scientific research shows. There is

now scientific evidence that a considerable amount of heart rate variability occurs during the period of youth. A few years ago, medical doctors used to believe that our heart rate stays steady all the time (seventy-two beats per minute always). However, science has discovered within the last twenty years that heart rhythm variability occurs continuously in a person. Heart rate variability has been described as a measurement of change in the rate of heart at every beat. If we are connected to a heart rhythm monitor, we will see that variation in our heart rate occurs even when we are sitting idle and doing nothing. Researchers at the Institute of HeartMath have discovered that continuous variability (change) in the heart rate is one way in which the heart talks and gives messages to the brain in order to deal with different situations as we encounter them.[20]

Recent scientific studies have also demonstrated that young people have more heart rate variability, and as people get older, the continuous change in their heart rate declines.[21] This means that there is more talking between the heart and brain in young people as compared to older people. More conversation goes on between the heart and brain during youth. This suggests that young people can get more guidance from their heart. Since the matter of acceptance of Islam is a matter of the heart, this could possibly explain why the youth are more willing to accept a reality once they encounter it and why they are always so willing to change. It is then no surprise that almost all the people who accepted Islam and believed in the prophethood of Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) in the early Makkan period were young people.

Muslim elders are important too

It must be noted here that this book does not intend to negate the importance of our Muslim elders, as they are important too. The dynamism

and creative energies of youth should be accompanied by the wisdom and life experience of the elders; the two of them depend upon each other. The role of Muslim elders is needed to provide guidance and support to young Muslim men and women. After all, today's youth are tomorrow's elders, and the future of the Muslim community is based on them.

Readers must also note that the age range of youth is quite broad – from around age fifteen to age forty – meaning that the youth age comprises the teenage years after the age of puberty, young adulthood, and adulthood. In the light of this defined age range, Muslim youth comprise the majority of the Muslim population – making them that much more important. However, their importance does not mean we should ignore the significance of other members of the community. Islam teaches us to respect our elders, and a Muslim society is not based on an individualistic, self-centred type of community; it is based on mutual assistance. Muslim elders are an equally important part of the Muslim community because they are to be sought for guidance and relied upon to educate the youth of the future.

To further illustrate the importance of elders, it should be noted that Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) was bestowed with prophethood when he reached the age of forty. This is the age when a person attains full intellectual maturity (which many youth lack before reaching this age), as the Qur'an mentions:

{...Then when he reaches his prime and reaches the age of forty years, he says: O my Lord, inspire me to be constantly grateful for Your blessings that You have bestowed upon me and my parents, and to do righteous deeds with which You will be pleased; and establish righteousness among my offspring for me. Verily, I repent to You and verily I am one of those who submit to Allah [in Islam].} *(al-Aḥqâf 46: 15)*

Muslim youth must work hand-in-hand with their elders because the latter have a wealth of knowledge and experience that they do not have. If our young and elderly both follow the pure teachings of the Qur'an, Sunnah, and the lives of pious Islamic scholars of the past as their role models, our community will become a lighthouse for the rest of the world, and its elders will be honoured to have righteous successors in the form of Muslim youth, Allah willing.

The nurturing role of parents and society

According to Islam, two major factors influence the development of a human being's personality: hereditary and environmental. Children's parents and their environment are the two most important surrounding influences that shape their personality. The nurturing role of parents in the upbringing of children is so important that it is described in the following hadith narrated by Abu Hurayrah. The Prophet (bpuh) said:

«كُلُّ مَوْلُودٍ يُولَدُ عَلَى الْفِطْرَةِ، فَأَبَوَاهُ يُهَوِّدَانِهِ أَوْ يُنَصِّرَانِهِ أَوْ يُمَجِّسَانِهِ.»

«Every newborn is born on the nature of Islam. Then his parents turn him into a Jew or Christian or Magian.» (Bukhari, Muslim, and Mâlik)[22]

This hadith proves the influence of environment upon the development of a child. Similarly, in another hadith, the Prophet (bpuh) gave the parable of a possessor of musk perfume and a blacksmith to show how companionship influences a person's behaviour, character, and overall conduct:

«إِنَّمَا مَثَلُ الْجَلِيسِ الصَّالِحِ، وَالْجَلِيسِ السَّوْءِ، كَحَامِلِ المِسْكِ، وَنَافِخِ الْكِيرِ، فَحَامِلُ المِسْكِ: إِمَّا أَنْ يُحْذِيَكَ، وَإِمَّا أَنْ تَبْتَاعَ مِنْهُ، وَإِمَّا أَنْ تَجِدَ مِنْهُ رِيحًا طَيِّبَةً، وَنَافِخُ الْكِيرِ: إِمَّا أَنْ يُحْرِقَ ثِيَابَكَ، وَإِمَّا أَنْ تَجِدَ رِيحًا خَبِيثَةً.»

«The parable of a good friend and a bad friend is that of a carrier of musk and a blacksmith. The carrier of musk will give you some, or you will buy some, or you will notice a good smell; the blacksmith will either burn your clothes or you will notice a bad smell.» (Muslim)[23]

In this hadith, Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) is informing us in a metaphorical sense that good companionship leads a person's character to imbibe goodness, whereas bad companionship lures a person towards bad conduct.

Environment, therefore, really influences a person's overall personality development. Parents as well as environment profoundly contribute to an individual's psychological development and personality. Islam is very concerned about the different phases of human development, including infancy, childhood, and youth. Contemporary Muslim sociologist Malik Bennabi notes that merely unrefined people do not make up the society; it is the society that conditions the mental state of its people.[24]

Muslim parents are entrusted with the onerous task of bringing up younger generations and raising them to be good Muslims. Islam teaches parents to inculcate in their children not just an emotional attachment to Islam, but also an inspiration to be practicing Muslims. Some general suggestions to Muslim parents regarding the upbringing of their children and youth are as follows:

1. Teaching the concept of the oneness of Allah and correct Islamic creed to the children.
2. Inculcating belief in the unseen.
3. Teaching good etiquette to the youth.

4. Finding substitute activities for children and youth so that they spend less and less time watching television and surfing the Internet.

5. Arranging good and balanced Islamic and professional education.

6. Arranging marriage for the youth when they reach puberty and have completed their undergraduate education. (Muslim parents must not delay the marriages of young men and women because the graduate education of the youth can sometimes be dragged on to age thirty.)

7. Teaching modesty to the youth.

8. Fear of standing before Allah on the Day of Judgement is important to cultivate in the hearts of youth. This is the concept of afterlife in Islam.

Parents must remember that Muslim youth cannot act on these suggestions or any additional suggestions in this book without proper guidance from their parents and guardians. Muslim parents have to assume their job first and then expect a reflection of their own influence in their youth. Similarly, imams of mosques and professionals in charge of education must help steer the community's youth on the right path.

Most importantly, parents must remember that Islam treats every matter right at its roots. The best way to ensure that our youth become responsible and exemplary Muslims is to use the same approach as used by the Messenger of Allah (bpuh) in shaping the personality of his Companions. His teaching method was very eloquently explained by 'Abdullâh ibn Mas'ood (may Allah be pleased with him), a well-known Companion of Prophet Muhammad (bpuh). He said:

«فَتَعَلَّمْنَا الْإِيمَانَ قَبْلَ أَنْ نَتَعَلَّمَ الْقُرْآنَ، ثُمَّ تَعَلَّمْنَا الْقُرْآنَ...»

«We were taught (by the Prophet [bpuh]) faith first before we learned the Qur'an, and then we were taught the Qur'an...» (A sound hadith recorded

by Ibn Mâjah and aṭ-Ṭabari)[25]

If faith is nurtured in the hearts of the Muslim youth, they will always look to the Qur'an and Sunnah for guidance. Today, our youth are confused because there is a general lack of faith in our entire society. With no faith, these youth are only superficial Muslims instead of conscious Muslims. They are still in search of their identity. Some of them find their identity in the stars of Hollywood and Bollywood, while others find their role models in Olympic gold medallists. Yet others find their ideals in American Idol singers. This is because our youth see a conflict in their lives. Sometimes their homes are full of practicing Muslims, while their society is secularized. In other cases, the youth open their eyes in a completely secular family, but their society or environment is pious.

In this regard, Malik Bennabi gives the example of going to the Friday congregational prayers and his observations on this phenomenon as follows:

> One may observe, for example, the overwhelming influence the Islamic Truth still exerts on the people who attend the Friday congregational prayer and listen to the *khutbah* [sermon] of the imam in the mosque. In fact, the words of the imam would deeply shake the audience in such a manner that we very often witness in the mosque a man completely immersed in his tears…
>
> However, once the prayer is over and once he has returned to his worldly affairs, the Truth which has just shaken the man would rather, unfortunately, be left in the mosque…
>
> At present, the Muslim actually suffers from a dichotomy which separates his personality in two conflicting sides: one that inspires his behaviour inside the mosque, and another which shapes it in public life.[26]

Bennabi observes that the state of modern-day Muslims resembles to a large extent the 'Scottish shower', in which a shower of very hot water is immediately followed by immersion in ice-cold water. Muslims are exposed to the most contradictory and conflicting influences. When Muslim youth go to the mosque, their hearts and souls feel strengthened, but as soon as they step out of the mosque and come under the attack of the agents of Dajjâl and the media, restlessness and confusion immediately enter their souls.

Problems faced by Muslim youth in the age of Dajjâl

The subject of this book is Muslim youth and the problems they face. Why? The answer is that today the major portion of the Muslim population is the youth. Muslim youth are in a crisis today. There is a need to address the issues they are facing in this age of Dajjâl. A look at population studies will illustrate this point further. Conservative American political scientist Samuel Huntington states:

> The percentage of Christians in the world peaked at about 30% in the 1980s, levelled off, is now declining, and will probably approximate about 25% of the world's population by 2025. As a result of their extremely high rates of population growth, the proportion of Muslims in the world will continue to increase dramatically, amounting to 20% of the world's population about the turn of the century, surpassing the number of Christians some years later, and probably accounting for about 30% of the world's population by 2025.[27]

This is happening because America and Europe have rising populations of older people. Due to recent medical advances, the average lifespan has increased; however, diseases associated with old age, senility, and loss of

mobility and cognitive functions are still issues that result in older people being almost functionless in the last few years of their lives. Hence, in Western countries, the population is lopsided, with the elderly as the majority.

On the other hand, the population trend in the Islamic world is the opposite.[28] Worldwide, the Muslim population today is relatively young. This means that the majority of Muslims are in their teens and twenties in almost all Muslim countries and even in non-Muslim countries. The phenomenon of 'Muslim youth-bulge' reached its peak in 2000, when a high percentage (around 65 percent) of the population in heavily Muslim societies comprised youth and young adults.

Pew Research Center is an American think-tank based in Washington DC. It analyzes religious change and its impact on societies around the world. They researched demographics of Muslims around the world in different age groups. In a report titled "The Future of the Global Muslim Population" published by the Pew Research Center's forum on Religion and Public Life in January 2011, it was disclosed that one-quarter of the youth and young adult population of the world in 2010 were Muslims, and this percentage will jump to 29.1 percent by 2030. The authors of the report assert that:

> In 1990, more than two-thirds of the total population of Muslim-majority countries was under age 30. Today, people under 30 make up about 60% of the population of these countries… The global Muslim population will remain *comparatively* youthful for decades to come…[29]

> Indeed, by 2030, there will be more than 540 million Muslim youth and young adults (ages 15-29) around the world, representing nearly three-

in-ten (29.1%) of the projected total of 1.9 billion people in that age group, up from 25.8% in 2010 and 20.0% in 1990.[30]

Today and in the near future, the majority of Muslims will be youth and young adults. We, as the Muslim community, should seize the moment and use our Muslim youth for the cause of Allah to spread the message of Islam, just like our beloved Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) did in his time.

In this modern age, Muslim youth are facing many challenges. They include secular education, coeducation, the teenage liberation movement, and peer pressure, all of which rob them of their religious identity and chastity.

With the advent of modern technology, our youth are expected to maintain their purity of thought while they are bombarded with media and music containing nudity, where every inch of the female body is displayed to seduce its viewers. Today, nudity of both men and women is used in print and electronic advertising to promote and sell products. We see ads of male and female models blown up all over buildings featuring almost-naked men or almost-nude women.

Muslim boys and girls suffer immense pressure due to the widespread presence of plug-in drugs like television, Internet (and social media), smartphones, mp3 players, video games, and many others. On top of all this, Muslim parents in many Muslim countries unnecessarily delay the marriages of their children. This opens the doors to courtship before marriage as well as premarital relationships, which are encouraged by festivals like Valentine's Day. Then there is the issue of smoking among the Muslim youth, as a result of which some end up taking drugs and narcotics.

The list of problems facing our Muslim youth is quite long. In the next few chapters, we will discuss some of these issues and their solutions.

Chapter 2: Muslim Youth – In the Light of the Qur'an and Sunnah

The Qur'an informs us that in any given society, it is the young people who raise their voices against the deviant traditions. They are the first ones to respond to any call of truth, and they have the potential to change the future of a society with their courage and passion. For the sake of upholding the truth, they are the ones who stand fast and suffer long. Usually, they are neither intimidated by opposition nor seduced by incentives. When young people are convinced that something is right, they usually do not care at all about the odds against them or the kinds of hardships they will suffer if they accept the truth. This is the beauty of young age.

Youth mentioned in the Qur'an and Sunnah

Prophet Ibrâheem (pbuh)

Prophet Ibrâheem (pbuh) believed in the oneness of Allah since his youth. The Qur'an mentions that while the inhabitants of the city were away to see a carnival, Prophet Ibrâheem smashed all the idols of his city and put the axe in the hands of the biggest idol (so that people would question it). When the people of the city returned and looked at the plight of their gods, they were furious and said to each other:

{They said: Who has done this to our gods? He must surely be one of the wrongdoers! They said: We heard a young man speaking ill of them; he is called Ibrâheem.} *(al-Anbiyâ' 21: 59-60)*

Later on, the people of the city tried Prophet Ibrâheem (pbuh) in the royal court of the tyrant king who claimed lordship for himself. Young Ibrâheem had an argument with the king, and he proved to him the falsehood of his argument. However, the king refused to accept the truth and ordered his followers to throw Prophet Ibrâheem into the fire. Allah commanded the fire not to harm Prophet Ibrâheem, and he was saved.

Afterwards, Prophet Ibrâheem, along with his wife Sârah and his young nephew Looṭ, who would also later become a prophet (peace be upon all of them), left the city and migrated to the blessed land.

Prophet Ismâ'eel (pbuh)

Prophet Ibrâheem (pbuh) migrated from his birthplace to the blessed land. His wife Sârah was unable to conceive children. He took Sârah's maidservant Hâjar as a second wife; she bore him a son named Ismâ'eel (pbuh). The Qur'an informs us that when Prophet Ismâ'eel reached his youth, Allah commanded Prophet Ibrâheem to sacrifice his son. This incident was a clear trial for Prophet Ibrâheem, since he was being asked to

offer his only son as a sacrifice to Allah. However, when Prophet Ibrâheem told his son about this command, the young Muslim did not hesitate for a moment and told his father to do what Allah had commanded him to do. This same Muslim youth later became Prophet Ismâ‘eel, the great grandfather of Prophet Muhammad (bpuh):

{Then when [the son] reached the age where he could help him in his endeavours, Ibrâheem said: O my son, I see in my dream that I must sacrifice you. What do you think? [The son] said: O my father, do as you are commanded. You will find me, if Allah so wills, among the steadfast.} *(aṣ-Ṣâffât 37: 102)*

Prophet Yoosuf (pbuh)

The story of Prophet Yoosuf (pbuh) is related in the Qur’an, and it is often referred to as the best of stories. After being deceived by his brothers and sold to the caravan, Prophet Yoosuf (pbuh) ended up in the castle of the governor of Egypt al-‘Azeez. At this point, he had reached the age of youth about which the Qur’an mentions:

{When Yoosuf reached his prime, We gave him wisdom and knowledge. Thus do We reward those who do good.} *(Yoosuf 12: 22)*

Prophet Yoosuf was surrounded by all kinds of temptations, which can be immensely distracting to a youth. He is certainly a role model for Muslim youth of all times. Among all the temptations, the greatest for young males is the temptation of sexual desire. Prophet Yoosuf has been described in the Qur’an as an exemplary youth with formidable character who resisted being seduced by one of the most beautiful women of his time. He controlled his sexual desire out of fear of Allah and was successful in

refusing the offer of al-‘Azeez’s wife to live with her. He was a young man at that time, as the Qur’an clearly specifies:

{Women in the city said: The wife of al-‘Azeez is trying to seduce her slave, for she is passionately in love with him. Indeed, we think she is clearly in error.} *(Yoosuf 12: 30)*

Prophet Moosâ (pbuh) and his disciple Yoosha‘

Similarly, the Qur’an explains that when Prophet Moosâ (pbuh) came to his people after receiving prophethood from Allah, only the youth amongst them believed in him:

{But no one believed in Moosâ except some of the youth among his people, despite their fear that Pharaoh and his chiefs might persecute them...} *(Yoonus 10: 83)*

The youth who believed in Prophet Moosâ were the cream of their society with very strong faith. When Prophet Moosâ advised them to be steadfast in the path of Allah, they prayed to Allah as the Qur’an praises them:

{They said: In Allah we put our trust. Our Lord, do not make us subject to the persecution of the wrongdoing people. And deliver us by your mercy from the disbelieving people.} *(Yoonus 10: 85-86)*

Among the youth around Prophet Moosâ was Yoosha‘, who became a prophet after his death. Yoosha‘ is a Muslim youth who is described in the Qur’an without being named directly. However, his name appears in the

hadiths of Prophet Muhammad (bpuh). Yoosha‘ was regarded by some classical scholars as the successor to Prophet Moosâ.[31]

The Qur’an mentions Yoosha‘ without naming him while narrating the conquest of Canaan, as one of the two pious men on whom Allah had bestowed His grace:

{They said: O Moosâ, in this land are a ferocious people; we will never enter it until they leave it, then if they leave, we will enter it. Two men among those who feared Allah, and whom Allah had blessed, said: Enter through the gate! Once you enter it, you will surely be victorious. And in Allah put your trust, if you are [truly] believers.} *(al-Mâ’idah 5: 22-23)*

According to many commentators of the Qur’an, Yoosha‘ was the accompanying youth and servant of Prophet Moosâ before he met the knowledgeable servant of Allah (named Khiḍr by some commentators):

{When they had travelled further on, Moosâ said to his servant: Bring us our morning meal; truly this journey of ours has exhausted us.} *(al-Kahf 18: 62)*

Yoosha‘ is also mentioned in a hadith narrated by Abu Hurayrah (may Allah be pleased with him) in which Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) said:

«إِنَّ الشَّمْسَ لَمْ تُحْبَسْ عَلَى بَشَرٍ إِلَّا لِيُوشَعَ لَيَالِيَ سَارَ إِلَى بَيْتِ المَقْدِسِ.»

«Surely, the sun has never been stopped from setting down for a human being except for Yoosha‘ when he was marching to Bayt al-Maqdis.» (An authentic hadith recorded by Aḥmad)[32]

This incident is explained further in another authentic hadith in which it has been narrated that Prophet Yoosha‘ went for jihad (struggle or striving [in Allah’s cause]) and approached a town after he had prayed the late-afternoon prayer.

«فَقَالَ لِلشَّمْسِ: إِنَّكِ مَأْمُورَةٌ وَأَنَا مَأْمُورٌ اللهُمَّ احْبِسْهَا عَلَيْنَا، فَحُبِسَتْ حَتَّى فَتَحَ اللهُ عَلَيْهِ.»

«He said to the sun: You are receiving orders, and I am receiving orders. O Allah, hold it back for a while.

Allah held it back till they conquered the town.» (Bukhari)[33]

Maryam, the mother of Prophet ‘Eesâ

Maryam, the mother of Prophet ‘Eesâ (pbuh), is another pious youth mentioned in the Qur’an. Maryam’s mother was childless, and when she grew old, she prayed to Allah to grant her a child whom she would dedicate to Allah’s service. When Maryam’s mother gave birth to Maryam, she was initially disappointed that the child was a girl. She was expecting a male child whom she could devote to religious services and for Allah’s worship, free from all worldly work and obligations. However, she still offered her in Allah’s service, and He accepted Maryam’s mother’s supplication regarding her daughter:

{Her Lord graciously accepted her and caused her to grow in a good manner, and entrusted her to the care of Zakariyâ...} *(Âl ‘Imrân 3: 37)*

Prophet Zakariyâ became the caregiver of young Maryam. As Maryam’s guardian, Prophet Zakariyâ noticed the piety of this exemplary Muslim youth. He also noticed her miracles, as the Qur’an mentions:

{...Every time Zakariyâ entered the chamber to see her, he found some provisions with her. He said: O Maryam, where has this come from? She said: From Allah; for Allah grants provision without measure to whom He will.} *(Âl ‘Imrân 3: 37)*

Maryam is a perfect example of a pious youth. She was still young when she was given glad tidings by the angels:

{And [remember] when the angels said: O Maryam! Allah has chosen you and purified you – chosen you above the women of all nations [of her own time].} *(Âl 'Imrân 3: 42)*

Sleepers of the cave

The story of the sleepers of the cave has been narrated in Soorat al-Kahf (*kahf* means cave). The Qur'an clearly states that the sleepers of the cave were a few young men who believed in the oneness of Allah. Their narrative begins in the Qur'an with the following words:

{When the young men took refuge in the cave, they said: Our Lord, bestow upon us mercy from Yourself, and guide us through our ordeal. Then We caused them to fall into a deep sleep in the cave for many years.} *(al-Kahf 18: 10-11)*

The young men referred to in these verses lived either in the town of Ephesus in Turkey or Amman in Jordan. Allah knows best their actual location. This group of young believers stood firm against the pressure from their people to worship others besides Allah. They fled the persecution of the tyrant king and his corrupt people, and took refuge in a cave. After they hid themselves in the cave, they fell asleep for a long time. When they woke up, they thought that they had slept for only a day or so, and they sent one of them back to the city to buy food. His use of old silver coins exposed the presence of these youths to the people of the town. Soon after this finding, the people of the cave died, and the people of their town built a mosque at the site of their burial (the cave).

A young boy and the makers of the ditch

In Soorat al-Burooj, a reference has been made to *Aṣ-ḥâb al-Ukhdood* or the Companions (Makers) of the Ditch – the people who made a pit of fire and threw the believers into it:

{Cursed be the makers of the trench who lit a blazing fire in it, for they sat beside it, to witness what they did to the believers. Their only grievance against them was that they believed in Allah, the Almighty, the Praiseworthy.} *(al-Burooj 85: 4-8)*

The central character of this story is a young boy who believed in the oneness of Allah, the Almighty. This youth was blessed with various miracles and divine protection against the plotting of an evil idol-worshipping king and his sorcerer. This story is described in detail in authentic hadiths of Prophet Muhammad (bpuh):

«كَانَ مَلِكٌ فِيمَنْ كَانَ قَبْلَكُمْ، وَكَانَ لَهُ سَاحِرٌ، فَلَمَّا كَبِرَ، قَالَ لِلْمَلِكِ: إِنِّي قَدْ كَبِرْتُ، فَابْعَثْ إِلَيَّ غُلَامًا أُعَلِّمْهُ السِّحْرَ، فَبَعَثَ إِلَيْهِ غُلَامًا يُعَلِّمُهُ، فَكَانَ فِي طَرِيقِهِ، إِذَا سَلَكَ رَاهِبٌ فَقَعَدَ إِلَيْهِ وَسَمِعَ كَلَامَهُ، فَأَعْجَبَهُ فَكَانَ إِذَا أَتَى السَّاحِرَ مَرَّ بِالرَّاهِبِ وَقَعَدَ إِلَيْهِ، فَإِذَا أَتَى السَّاحِرَ ضَرَبَهُ، فَشَكَا ذَلِكَ إِلَى الرَّاهِبِ، فَقَالَ: إِذَا خَشِيتَ السَّاحِرَ، فَقُلْ: حَبَسَنِي أَهْلِي، وَإِذَا خَشِيتَ أَهْلَكَ فَقُلْ: حَبَسَنِي السَّاحِرُ، فَبَيْنَمَا هُوَ كَذَلِكَ إِذْ أَتَى عَلَى دَابَّةٍ عَظِيمَةٍ قَدْ حَبَسَتِ النَّاسَ، فَقَالَ: الْيَوْمَ أَعْلَمُ آلسَّاحِرُ أَفْضَلُ أَمِ الرَّاهِبُ أَفْضَلُ؟ فَأَخَذَ حَجَرًا، فَقَالَ: اللهُمَّ إِنْ كَانَ أَمْرُ الرَّاهِبِ أَحَبَّ إِلَيْكَ مِنْ أَمْرِ السَّاحِرِ فَاقْتُلْ هَذِهِ الدَّابَّةَ، حَتَّى يَمْضِيَ النَّاسُ، فَرَمَاهَا فَقَتَلَهَا، وَمَضَى النَّاسُ، فَأَتَى الرَّاهِبَ فَأَخْبَرَهُ، فَقَالَ لَهُ الرَّاهِبُ: أَيْ بُنَيَّ أَنْتَ الْيَوْمَ أَفْضَلُ مِنِّي، قَدْ بَلَغَ مِنْ أَمْرِكَ مَا أَرَى، وَإِنَّكَ سَتُبْتَلَى، فَإِنِ ابْتُلِيتَ فَلَا تَدُلَّ عَلَيَّ، وَكَانَ الْغُلَامُ يُبْرِئُ الْأَكْمَهَ وَالْأَبْرَصَ، وَيُدَاوِي النَّاسَ مِنْ سَائِرِ الْأَدْوَاءِ، فَسَمِعَ جَلِيسٌ لِلْمَلِكِ كَانَ قَدْ عَمِيَ، فَأَتَاهُ بِهَدَايَا كَثِيرَةٍ، فَقَالَ: مَا هَاهُنَا لَكَ أَجْمَعُ، إِنْ أَنْتَ شَفَيْتَنِي، فَقَالَ: إِنِّي لَا أَشْفِي أَحَدًا إِنَّمَا يَشْفِي اللهُ، فَإِنْ أَنْتَ آمَنْتَ بِاللهِ دَعَوْتُ اللهَ فَشَفَاكَ، فَآمَنَ بِاللهِ فَشَفَاهُ اللهُ، فَأَتَى المَلِكَ فَجَلَسَ إِلَيْهِ كَمَا كَانَ يَجْلِسُ، فَقَالَ لَهُ المَلِكُ: مَنْ رَدَّ عَلَيْكَ بَصَرَكَ؟ قَالَ: رَبِّي، قَالَ: وَلَكَ رَبٌّ غَيْرِي؟ قَالَ: رَبِّي وَرَبُّكَ اللهُ، فَأَخَذَهُ فَلَمْ يَزَلْ يُعَذِّبُهُ حَتَّى دَلَّ عَلَى الْغُلَامِ، فَجِيءَ بِالْغُلَامِ، فَقَالَ لَهُ المَلِكُ: أَيْ

بُنَيَّ قَدْ بَلَغَ مِنْ سِحْرِكَ مَا تُبْرِئُ الْأَكْمَهَ وَالْأَبْرَصَ، وَتَفْعَلُ وَتَفْعَلُ، فَقَالَ: إِنِّي لَا أَشْفِي أَحَدًا، إِنَّمَا يَشْفِي اللهُ، فَأَخَذَهُ فَلَمْ يَزَلْ يُعَذِّبُهُ حَتَّى دَلَّ عَلَى الرَّاهِبِ، فَجِيءَ بِالرَّاهِبِ، فَقِيلَ لَهُ: ارْجِعْ عَنْ دِينِكَ، فَأَبَى، فَدَعَا بِالمِنْشَارِ، فَوَضَعَ المِنْشَارَ فِي مَفْرِقِ رَأْسِهِ، فَشَقَّهُ حَتَّى وَقَعَ شِقَّاهُ، ثُمَّ جِيءَ بِجَلِيسِ المَلِكِ فَقِيلَ لَهُ: ارْجِعْ عَنْ دِينِكَ، فَأَبَى فَوَضَعَ المِنْشَارَ فِي مَفْرِقِ رَأْسِهِ، فَشَقَّهُ بِهِ حَتَّى وَقَعَ شِقَّاهُ، ثُمَّ جِيءَ بِالْغُلَامِ فَقِيلَ لَهُ ارْجِعْ عَنْ دِينِكَ، فَأَبَى فَدَفَعَهُ إِلَى نَفَرٍ مِنْ أَصْحَابِهِ، فَقَالَ: اذْهَبُوا بِهِ إِلَى جَبَلِ كَذَا وَكَذَا، فَاصْعَدُوا بِهِ الْجَبَلَ، فَإِذَا بَلَغْتُمْ ذُرْوَتَهُ، فَإِنْ رَجَعَ عَنْ دِينِهِ، وَإِلَّا فَاطْرَحُوهُ، فَذَهَبُوا بِهِ فَصَعِدُوا بِهِ الْجَبَلَ، فَقَالَ: اللهُمَّ اكْفِنِيهِمْ بِمَا شِئْتَ، فَرَجَفَ بِهِمِ الْجَبَلُ فَسَقَطُوا، وَجَاءَ يَمْشِي إِلَى المَلِكِ، فَقَالَ لَهُ المَلِكُ: مَا فَعَلَ أَصْحَابُكَ؟ قَالَ: كَفَانِيهِمُ اللهُ، فَدَفَعَهُ إِلَى نَفَرٍ مِنْ أَصْحَابِهِ، فَقَالَ: اذْهَبُوا بِهِ فَاحْمِلُوهُ فِي قُرْقُورٍ، فَتَوَسَّطُوا بِهِ الْبَحْرَ، فَإِنْ رَجَعَ عَنْ دِينِهِ وَإِلَّا فَاقْذِفُوهُ، فَذَهَبُوا بِهِ، فَقَالَ: اللهُمَّ اكْفِنِيهِمْ بِمَا شِئْتَ، فَانْكَفَأَتْ بِهِمِ السَّفِينَةُ فَغَرِقُوا، وَجَاءَ يَمْشِي إِلَى المَلِكِ، فَقَالَ لَهُ المَلِكُ: مَا فَعَلَ أَصْحَابُكَ؟ قَالَ: كَفَانِيهِمُ اللهُ، فَقَالَ لِلْمَلِكِ: إِنَّكَ لَسْتَ بِقَاتِلِي حَتَّى تَفْعَلَ مَا آمُرُكَ بِهِ، قَالَ: وَمَا هُوَ؟ قَالَ: تَجْمَعُ النَّاسَ فِي صَعِيدٍ وَاحِدٍ، وَتَصْلُبُنِي عَلَى جِذْعٍ، ثُمَّ خُذْ سَهْمًا مِنْ كِنَانَتِي، ثُمَّ ضَعِ السَّهْمَ فِي كَبِدِ الْقَوْسِ، ثُمَّ قُلْ: بِاسْمِ اللهِ رَبِّ الْغُلَامِ، ثُمَّ ارْمِنِي، فَإِنَّكَ إِذَا فَعَلْتَ ذَلِكَ قَتَلْتَنِي، فَجَمَعَ النَّاسَ فِي صَعِيدٍ وَاحِدٍ، وَصَلَبَهُ عَلَى جِذْعٍ، ثُمَّ أَخَذَ سَهْمًا مِنْ كِنَانَتِهِ، ثُمَّ وَضَعَ السَّهْمَ فِي كَبْدِ الْقَوْسِ، ثُمَّ قَالَ: بِاسْمِ اللهِ، رَبِّ الْغُلَامِ، ثُمَّ رَمَاهُ فَوَقَعَ السَّهْمُ فِي صُدْغِهِ، فَوَضَعَ يَدَهُ فِي صُدْغِهِ فِي مَوْضِعِ السَّهْمِ فَمَاتَ، فَقَالَ النَّاسُ: آمَنَّا بِرَبِّ الْغُلَامِ، آمَنَّا بِرَبِّ الْغُلَامِ، آمَنَّا بِرَبِّ الْغُلَامِ، فَأُتِيَ المَلِكُ فَقِيلَ لَهُ: أَرَأَيْتَ مَا كُنْتَ تَحْذَرُ؟ قَدْ وَاللهِ نَزَلَ بِكَ حَذَرُكَ، قَدْ آمَنَ النَّاسُ، فَأَمَرَ بِالْأُخْدُودِ فِي أَفْوَاهِ السِّكَكِ، فَخُدَّتْ وَأَضْرَمَ النِّيرَانَ، وَقَالَ: مَنْ لَمْ يَرْجِعْ عَنْ دِينِهِ فَأَحْمُوهُ فِيهَا، أَوْ قِيلَ لَهُ: اقْتَحِمْ، فَفَعَلُوا حَتَّى جَاءَتِ امْرَأَةٌ وَمَعَهَا صَبِيٌّ لَهَا فَتَقَاعَسَتْ أَنْ تَقَعَ فِيهَا، فَقَالَ لَهَا الْغُلَامُ: يَا أُمَّهْ اصْبِرِي فَإِنَّكِ عَلَى الْحَقِّ.»

«There was once a king who had a court magician who had grown old. The old sorcerer wanted to pick the most intelligent boy in the kingdom to transfer his knowledge to before his death. The boy who became the sorcerer's student would pass by a monk on his way to the castle every day. Soon, he began learning from that monk, who taught him that Allah alone deserves to be worshipped.

One day, a huge beast blocked the road.

The boy picked up a stone and said: O Allah, if the monk's affair is dearer to You than the magician's affair, make this animal die so that people are

able to move about freely.

He threw that stone towards the beast and killed it.

The boy then went to the monk and informed him of what he had done.

The monk said to him: My son, today you have become better than me. Your affair has come to a stage (of high faith and piety) where I find that you would soon be put to a trial.

The boy began to treat the blind and cure people suffering from leprosy and other illnesses.

When the king heard about him, he summoned the boy to his palace and told him to return to his religion. When the boy refused, the king sent the boy with his soldiers to throw him from the top of the hill, but Allah saved the boy. As the story goes, when all attempts of the king failed, the boy said to him: You will not be able to kill me until you do what I ask you to do.

The king said: What is that?

He said: Gather people in a plain and tie me to the trunk (of a tree). Then take hold of an arrow from the quiver and say: In the name of Allah, the Lord of the worlds; then shoot the arrow and if you do that, you would be able to kill me.

He (the king) called the people in an open plain and tied him (the boy) to the tree trunk. He took hold of an arrow from his quiver, placed the arrow in the bow, and said: In the name of Allah, the Lord of the boy.

The king then shot the arrow, and it hit the boy's temple. The boy placed his hands upon the temple where the arrow had hit him, and he died.

People said: We affirm our faith in the Lord of this boy.

The courtiers came to the king, and it was said to him: Do you see that Allah has actually done what you aimed at averting? People have affirmed their faith in the Lord.

The king commanded for ditches to be dug at important points in the path. When these ditches were dug, and fire was lit in them, it was said (to the people): He who would not turn back from his (boy's) religion would be thrown in the fire, or it would be said to them to jump in that. (People courted death but did not renounce religion) till a woman came with her child; she felt hesitant about jumping into the fire, and the child said to her: O mother, endure (this ordeal) for it is the truth.» (Muslim)[34]

A young Muslim man in the court of Dajjâl

Those who gave victory to the religion of Allah in the early period of Islam were young men and women. It has happened before, and it will happen again. What I mean is that the people who will again give victory to Islam under the leadership of Prophet 'Eesâ (pbuh) in the fight against the armies of Dajjâl will also be young. As described in the hadiths, among those fighting Dajjâl, the best martyr in the sight of Allah will be a young Muslim in the prime of his youth, who will challenge Dajjâl. Although Dajjâl will kill this young Muslim, he will not be able to kill anyone afterwards. The killing of this young Muslim man will prove to be a death sentence for Dajjâl. Soon thereafter, Prophet 'Eesâ will descend from the heavens and kill Dajjâl, who will be trying to flee from him.

It is mentioned in the hadiths that this young man will display an unparalleled sense of courage in the face of the tribulations of Dajjâl. This

young man will sacrifice his life at the hands of Dajjâl, but will speak the truth and expose Dajjâl's real face in front of his followers. It is reported in the hadith about Dajjâl that the Prophet (bpuh) said:

«ثُمَّ يَدْعُو رَجُلًا مُمْتَلِئًا شَبَابًا، فَيَضْرِبُهُ بِالسَّيْفِ فَيَقْطَعُهُ جَزْلَتَيْنِ رَمْيَةَ الْغَرَضِ، ثُمَّ يَدْعُوهُ فَيُقْبِلُ وَيَتَهَلَّلُ وَجْهُهُ، يَضْحَكُ.»

«Then he (Dajjâl) will call a man (who is) in the full bloom of his youth. He will cut him with a sword into two pieces and throw away the pieces. He will then call him, and he will respond with his face beaming with joy and smiling.» (Muslim)[35]

This incident has been described in more detail in another hadith. Abu Sa'eed al-Khudri reported:

«The Prophet (bpuh) said: Dajjâl will emerge. One of the believers will go towards him, and some sentries of Dajjâl will challenge him.

They will say to him: Where are you going?

He will say: I am going to visit this one who has emerged.

They will say: Do you not believe in our lord?

He will say: Our Lord is not hidden.

They will say: Kill him!

Then they will say to one another: Did your lord not forbid you to kill anyone without his permission?

They will take him to Dajjâl. When the believer sees him, he will say: O people! This is Dajjâl whom the Messenger of Allah (bpuh) referred to!

Dajjâl will command for him to be stretched out and will say: Take him and beat him on the face.

His back and chest will be made wider by beating. Dajjâl will ask: Do you not believe in me?

He will respond: You are the false Messiah!

Dajjâl will command for him to be sawn with a saw from the middle of his head until he is split down to his feet. Then Dajjâl will walk between the two halves and say to him: Get up – and he will stand up straight. Then he will ask him: Do you believe in me?

He will say: My insight about you has only increased.

Then he will say: O people! I am the last person towards whom he will act like this.

Dajjâl will seize him to slaughter him, but Allah will turn his entire neck into brass, and he will be unable to do it. He will take hold of his hands and feet and throw him, and people will imagine that he has thrown him into the fire, but he will have thrown him into the garden.

The Messenger of Allah (bpuh) said: This is the person who has the greatest martyrdom before the Lord of the worlds.» (Muslim)[36]

Muslim youth around the Messenger of Allah (bpuh)

The leaders of Makkah happened to be the elders of the society, and they blatantly rejected the message of Prophet Muhammad (bpuh). They were not willing to accept any change. On the other hand, the young men and women of the Makkan society believed in the divine message brought by Prophet Muhammad (bpuh). They were the ones who were willing to challenge the status quo of the society. The sleepers of the cave were the youth of the society of their time and they too believed in the message of

the oneness of Allah. The Qur'an narrates the story of the sleepers of the cave and then comforts and reassures Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) that it is the youth of the society who are the first and foremost in accepting the message of truth:

{We recount to you their story truthfully: they were young men who believed in their Lord, and We increased them in guidance.} *(al-Kahf 18: 13)*

If we take a glance at the life of Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) during the Makkan phase of prophethood, we notice that except for his wife Khadeejah (*raḍiya Allâhu 'anhâ* – may Allah be pleased with her), who was fifteen years older than him, and later his wife Sawdah, none of Prophet Muhammad's earlier Companions were older than him. The people who stepped forward in the Makkan period of trials and tribulations were not the older people, but courageous young men and women. In a hadith narrated by Anas ibn Mâlik, it is stated:

«قَدِمَ النَّبِيُّ صَلَّى اللهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ وَلَيْسَ فِي أَصْحَابِهِ أَشْمَطُ غَيْرَ أَبِي بَكْرٍ، فَغَلَفَهَا بِالحِنَّاءِ، وَالكَتَمِ.»

«When the Prophet (bpuh) arrived (in Madinah), there was not a single Companion of the Prophet (bpuh) who had grey and black hair except Abu Bakr, and he dyed his hair with henna and *katam* (plants used for dyeing hair).» (Bukhari)[37]

Through another group of narrators, Anas ibn Mâlik (may Allah be pleased with him) said:

«قَدِمَ النَّبِيُّ صَلَّى اللهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ المَدِينَةَ فَكَانَ أَسَنَّ أَصْحَابِهِ أَبُو بَكْرٍ، فَغَلَفَهَا بِالحِنَّاءِ وَالكَتَمِ حَتَّى قَنَأَ لَوْنُهَا.»

«When the Prophet (bpuh) arrived at Madinah, the eldest amongst his Companions was Abu Bakr. He dyed his hair with henna and katam till it

became of dark red colour.» (Bukhari)[38]

After becoming the prophet and spreading the message of Islam in Makkah for thirteen years, when the Messenger of Allah (bpuh) migrated from Makkah and arrived in Madinah, only Abu Bakr (may Allah be pleased with him) had white hair among the Companions who had migrated. When the first revelation came down to the Prophet (bpuh) in Makkah, the majority of the Companions who embraced Islam were between their teens and early thirties. Only Abu Bakr aṣ-Ṣiddeeq's age was thirty-eight, making him two years younger than the Prophet (bpuh). Almost all the people who responded to Prophet Muhammad's first call of preaching were youth, and they were younger than Allah's Messenger (bpuh). These young Companions were the first ones to give victory to the religion of Islam. This is highlighted in the following table:

Table I: Ages of the Companions who Embraced Islam in the Early Makkan Period

Name of the Companion	Age at the Time of Embracing Islam in the Early Makkan Period
'Ali ibn Abi Ṭâlib	Less than 20 years old
'Abdullâh ibn Mas'ood	
Ja'far ibn Abi Ṭâlib	
Ṭalḥah ibn 'Ubaydullâh	
Az-Zubayr ibn 'Awwâm	
Muṣ'ab ibn 'Umayr	
Asmâ' bint Abu Bakr	
Bilâl ibn Rabâḥ	Ages between 20 and 30

Name of the Companion	Age at the Time of Embracing Islam in the Early Makkan Period
‘Abdur-Raḥmân ibn ‘Awf	
Zayd ibn Ḥârithah	
Ṣuhayb ar-Roomi	
Asmâ’ bint ‘Umays (wife of Ja‘far)	In their early thirties
Fâṭimah bint al-Khaṭṭâb (sister of ‘Umar ibn al-Khaṭṭâb)	
‘Umar ibn al-Khaṭṭâb	Ages in the range of 30-35
‘Uthmân ibn ‘Affân	
Lubâbah bint al-Ḥârith (Umm Faḍl)	
Umm Salamah (Mother of the Believers)	
Abu Bakr aṣ-Ṣiddeeq	38 years old

Likewise, after thirteen years of preaching the message of Islam in Makkah, Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) migrated with his followers to the city of Madinah (formerly Yathrib). As opposed to Makkah or Taif, Madinah proved to be a fertile ground for the foundation of the first Islamic state under the leadership of the Messenger of Allah (bpuh). This was largely because the elder leaders of the tribes in Makkah and Taif were still alive and they resisted the message of truth. On the other hand, the situation was quite different in Madinah. Five years before the migration of Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) to Madinah, Aws and Khazraj, the two major tribes of *Anṣâr* (helpers) in Madinah, had fought the famous battle of Bu‘âth, which

had wiped out most of the elders and leaders of both the tribes. This was a divine intervention and a blessing in disguise that served as a prelude to the Prophet's migration to Madinah. 'Â'ishah, the Mother of the Believers, said:

«كَانَ يَوْمُ بُعَاثٍ يَوْمًا قَدَّمَهُ اللهُ لِرَسُولِهِ صَلَّى اللهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ، فَقَدِمَ رَسُولُ اللهِ صَلَّى اللهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ وَقَدِ افْتَرَقَ مَلَؤُهُمْ، وَقُتِّلَتْ سَرَوَاتُهُمْ وَجُرِّحُوا، قَدَّمَهُ اللهُ لِرَسُولِهِ صَلَّى اللهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ فِي دُخُولِهِمْ فِي الإِسْلاَمِ.»

«The day of Bu'âth (the day of fighting between the two tribes of the Anṣâr: Aws and Khazraj) was brought about by Allah for the good of His Messenger (bpuh) so that when Allah's Messenger (bpuh) reached (Madinah), the tribes of Madinah were already divided, and their chiefs had been killed and wounded. Allah had brought about the battle for the good of His Messenger (bpuh) so that they (the Anṣâr) might embrace Islam.» (Bukhari)[39]

As a consequence, most of the people left in Madinah were young people, who were willing to accept change and embrace the message of Islam. The first Muslims of Madinah said to Prophet Muhammad (bpuh):

> When we left our people, discord and conflict and enmity divided them more than any other. Perhaps God will unite them through you, and if God unites them on you, then no other man will be honoured more than you.[40]

Among those young people in Madinah was Zayd ibn Thâbit (may Allah be pleased with him), who was six years old when his father died in the battle of Bu'âth. He was thirteen years old when he asked Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) for permission to participate in the Battle of Badr. Since Zayd was less than fifteen years old at that time, he was not allowed to do so and was subsequently sent back.

Due to his high aspirations, Zayd ibn Thâbit turned his attention to learning the Qur'an. The Messenger of Allah (bpuh) chose Zayd to write down the verses of the Qur'an and to collect and keep a record of them. When the Prophet (bpuh) died, Zayd was twenty-three years old. This youth was chosen by Abu Bakr (may Allah be pleased with him) to carry out the gigantic task of authenticating and collecting the written as well as oral Qur'anic verses into a single volume. This is mentioned in the following hadith:

قَالَ أَبُو بَكْرٍ: «وَإِنَّكَ رَجُلٌ شَابٌّ عَاقِلٌ، لاَ نَتَّهِمُكَ قَدْ كُنْتَ تَكْتُبُ الوَحْيَ لِرَسُولِ اللهِ صَلَّى اللهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ، فَتَتَبَّعِ القُرْآنَ، فَاجْمَعْهُ.»

«Abu Bakr said (to Zayd ibn Thâbit in the presence of 'Umar ibn al-Khaṭṭâb): You are a wise young man, and we do not have any suspicion about you; you used to write down the divine inspiration for Allah's Messenger (bpuh). Search for the fragmentary scripts of the Qur'an and collect them into one book.» (Bukhari)[41]

'Abdullâh ibn Mas'ood, who embraced Islam at the prime of his youth in Makkah, said the following about the men around the Messenger of Allah (bpuh) in Madinah:

«كُنَّا نَغْزُو مَعَ النَّبِيِّ صَلَّى اللهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ وَنَحْنُ شَبَابٌ.»

«We used to fight along with the Prophet (bpuh) when we were youths.» (A sound hadith recorded by Aḥmad)[42]

In the Battle of Badr, the two Companions of Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) who killed Abu Jahl, the worst enemy of Islam, were teenagers, both of them around seventeen years of age. These youth killed one of the most skilled warriors of the Quraysh and brought the good news of his death to our beloved Prophet (bpuh). This incident was narrated by 'Abdur-Raḥmân ibn 'Awf (may Allah be pleased with him):

«While I was standing in the ranks on the day of Badr, I looked to my right and my left; I saw two young boys from the Anṣâr, and I wished I was stronger than they were. One of them called me, saying: O uncle! Do you know Abu Jahl?

I said: Yes. What do you want from him, O nephew? He said: I have been informed that he insults the Messenger of Allah (bpuh). By Him in Whose Hands my soul is, if I were to see him, my body will not part from his body until one of us meets his fate.

I was astonished at this statement. Then the other boy called me saying the same as the other had said. After a while, I saw Abu Jahl walking amongst the people. I said to the boys: Look! This is the man you asked me about.

Both of them attacked him with their swords; they struck him to death and returned to Allah's Messenger (bpuh) to inform him about that. The Messenger of Allah (bpuh) asked: Which of you has killed him?

Each of them said: I have killed him.

The Prophet (bpuh) asked: Have you cleaned your swords?

They said: No.

He then looked at their swords and said: No doubt, you both have killed him, and the spoils of the deceased will be given to Mu'âdh ibn 'Amr ibn al-Jamuḥ.» (Bukhari, Muslim, al-Ḥâkim, and al-Bayhaqi)[43]

Anas ibn Mâlik (may Allah be pleased with him) was another youth of Madinah. He described the daily routine of seventy young men living in a shaded area very close to the Prophet's mosque. These youth used to sell firewood and water in order to purchase food for themselves as well as for other poor people in Madinah. Anas ibn Mâlik said:

عَنْ أَنَسِ بْنِ مَالِكٍ، قَالَ: «كَانَ شَبَابٌ مِنَ الْأَنْصَارِ سَبْعِينَ رَجُلًا يُسَمَّوْنَ الْقُرَّاءَ» قَالَ: «كَانُوا يَكُونُونَ فِي المَسْجِدِ فَإِذَا أَمْسَوْا انْتَحَوْا نَاحِيَةً مِنَ المَدِينَةِ، فَيَتَدَارَسُونَ وَيُصَلُّونَ يَحْسِبُ أَهْلُوهُمْ أَنَّهُمْ فِي المَسْجِدِ، وَيَحْسِبُ أَهْلُ المَسْجِدِ أَنَّهُمْ عِنْدَ أَهْلِيهِمْ، حَتَّى إِذَا كَانُوا فِي وَجْهِ الصُّبْحِ اسْتَعْذَبُوا مِنَ المَاءِ، وَاحْتَطَبُوا مِنَ الْحَطَبِ، فَجَاءُوا بِهِ فَأَسْنَدُوهُ إِلَى حُجْرَةِ رَسُولِ اللهِ صَلَّى اللهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ .»

«Anas ibn Mâlik said: Around seventy young men among the Anṣâr were called the reciters.

He also said: In the evenings, they would go to an area in Madinah and study and pray there. While they were in that place, their families would think that they were in the mosque and the people of the mosque would think that they were with their families. When dawn appeared, they would fetch water and firewood and take it to the Prophet's apartment.» (Recorded by al-Bayhaqi and Aḥmad with a sound chain of narration)[44]

Similarly, Mâlik ibn Ḥuwayrith al-Laythi described his visit to Madinah along with a group of youth of his tribe, all of whom came to embrace and learn Islam from Prophet Muhammad (bpuh). He said:

«We came to Allah's Messenger (bpuh) while we were youths of almost the same age. We stayed with him for twenty days and nights. The Prophet (bpuh) was compassionate and kind. When he assumed that we were yearning for our families, he asked about those we had left behind, and we told him. He said: Go back to your people and stay with them, teach them, command them (then he mentioned some things), and pray as you saw me pray. When it is time for prayer, someone among you should make the call to prayer and the eldest of you should lead the prayer.» (Bukhari and Muslim)[45]

Of course, the Prophet's elder Companions (may Allah be pleased with all of them) also played a leading role in spreading the message of Islam.

The elder Companions provided guidance and support to the Muslim youth of their society.

Another historical fact that is important to note is that none of the torch-bearers of the movement started by the Messenger of Allah (bpuh) held any high religious or political position. The youth around the Messenger of Allah (bpuh) did not have any vested interests in the social or political strata of the society that they otherwise would have been afraid to lose. It is for this reason that when Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) started spreading the message of Islam to his people, the near-sighted leaders of the Quraysh initially speculated that it was just a movement of a few rebellious youth in their society and very soon it would come to an end. After all, who had the strength to stand against the leaders of the Quraysh?

When the Messenger of Allah (bpuh) invited some of the Quraysh to dinner at his home to proclaim his message of Islam to them for the first time, around forty members of Banu Hâshim, a prominent tribe of Quraysh, attended. According to the Prophet's biographers:

«After they had eaten, the Messenger of Allah (bpuh) got up and addressed his tribe as follows: O sons of 'Abdul-Muṭṭalib, I do not know of any man in Arab history who served his people better than I have served you. I have brought to you the best of this world as well as the next. My Lord has commanded me to call you to Him. Who will stand by me on this matter?

All the guests and elders were unsympathetic and silent. Nobody said anything. At that moment, 'Ali ibn Abi Ṭâlib, who was a teenager (aged thirteen) at that time, stood up in front of the elders of Quraysh and said: Even though I am slim, even though I am only a youth, O Prophet of Allah, I shall be your helper in this cause of Islam.

The Banu Hâshim burst out laughing when they saw a young boy claiming to support the Messenger of Allah (bpuh).» (Recorded by al-Bayhaqi)

Through this laughter and ridicule, the elders of Quraysh were indirectly saying that this message – that Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) had brought and for which his young followers, like ‘Ali (may Allah be pleased with him), who responded to him, were fighting – was a lost cause. However, the coming events proved that Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) and the youth around him changed the world, and even today, we hear the rolling thunder of history in their footsteps.

Chapter 3: Muslim Youth and the One-Eyed Media

'Dajjâl' is an Arabic word that means 'the one who deceives' or 'the impostor'. The Arabic word *dajjel* means 'to deceive'. For instance, if there is a crack in the wall of a house and someone wallpapers it to hide it in order to sell the house, this means he or she has committed an act of dajjel or deception.

When Imam Mâlik was informed about a person who fabricated hadiths, he said about him:

إنما هو دَجَّالٌ مِن الدَّجاجِلَة.

> He is a deceiver [Dajjâl] from amongst the deceivers [*Dajjâjilah* – plural of Dajjâl].[46]

Imam al-Qurṭubi describes the meaning of Dajjâl as follows:

> Dajjel means to coat any metal with gold so that people construe that thing to be real gold. Since Dajjâl will present falsehood to people in such a deceptive way that people will feel as if it is the truth, he will be called Dajjâl.[47]

Deception or seduction is an essential component of the age of Dajjâl because, after all, Dajjâl is the great deceiver. In the modern age, falsehood is presented by the media and through electronics to Muslim youth in such a deceptive and seductive way that the majority of them become mesmerized by it, and slowly but surely, they lose their faith, shame, modesty, time, and honour.

Dajjâl sees the world with one eye. When we observe the world with one eye, we perceive a very superficial view. The presence of two eyes on the head, also known as 'binocular vision', allows for precise depth perception. The information our brain receives from both eyes is used to calculate depth in a visual scene.[48] We need both eyes for correct depth perception and correct gauging of distance – a blessing of Allah to humanity that the Qur'an notes:

{Have We not given him two eyes?} *(al-Balad 90: 8)*

Keeping aside the positive and constructive uses of electronics and machines, all these technological agents of Dajjâl possess and project a one-eyed view of the world. Some examples of one-eyed media include the television, computer (Internet), cinema (theatre), smartphone, camera (in cell phones too), video camera, iPod, iPad, satellite dish, cable, and video games, to name only a few. All these things are part of the one-eyed media, and, in fact, some media companies have even adopted the 'one eye' symbol as their company's logo. For instance, CBS Broadcasting, Inc. is a major US commercial broadcasting television network. Its logo is the image of a single eye, and for this reason, CBS media news network is also referred to as the 'Eye Network'. Similarly, Time Warner Cable is America's second-largest cable provider, which spun out of Time Warner in 2009 as an independent company. The logo of Time Warner Cable is also a single eye. This 'one eye' theme in media agency logos and brands represents the so-called 'all-seeing eye' of the media. All these deceptive

agents are creating the stage for the final coming of Dajjâl, who will be a person with supernatural powers, as prophesized in various hadiths of Prophet Muhammad (bpuh). Through their deceptive ways and manners, these proponents and promoters of the one-eyed view are preparing the society and the world for the coming of Dajjâl.

An important attribute of the agents of Dajjâl is that they depict everything to people as superficial and positive, because they are essentially 'one-eyed', providing an incorrect and incomplete perception to the viewers – a 'one-eyed' worldview. The youth are taught to satisfy the desires of their bodies – in fact, to worship their bodies. In this age of Dajjâl, it seems as if the 'eye' of materialism is wide open, whereas the 'eye' of spirituality is closed. Everything is portrayed to the youth as a pleasure to the eyes. The underlying message of every advertisement is centred on human flesh. Nothing pacifying the human soul is advertised in the media of Dajjâl. The media's influence on the behaviour of children and youth is undeniable. As a point of fact, the media in this age of Dajjâl is misleading our Muslim youth like lambs to the slaughter. Research in communication and social psychology bears testimony to the indelible influence of the media in changing people's attitudes, as we shall discuss below.

Muslim youth and the effects of television and computer on family life

Television was the first invention in the sphere of electronic visual media. Therefore, it was the first to influence the lifestyle of children and youth all over the globe. According to the Nielson Media Research Report on

television, children aged 2-5 years watch an average of 21.8 hours of television per week, whereas those aged 6-11 years watch 18.3 hours of television per week.[49]

The computer, owing to its interactive nature, has proven to be an even stronger medium than television due to its mesmerizing nature. While American youth born into the generation of television spend on average a total of seven years of their lives sitting in front of a television,[50] the situation becomes worse when we look at those born into the Internet generation of the nineties. Dr. Frank Biocca, Director of Media, Interface, and Network Design (M.I.N.D.) Labs at Michigan State University writes:

> Based on time spent with these other media over a lifetime, we can make a rough estimate that members of the Internet generation may spend as much as 20 years of their lives in front of, interacting with, and connected to this medium.[51]

American computer scientist and interface designer Alan Kay regards the computer as a 'meta-medium'. A 'meta-medium' has been defined as a medium that combines the experiences of the television, the book, the typewriter, the radio, and the video game console all in one platform.[52] According to the director of Saatchi & Saatchi Interactive, "...there's probably no other product or service that we can think of that is like it [Internet] in terms of capturing kids' interest."[53]

When the television set first came on the market, it was hard to envision that one day, television sets would be present in every home. Even in America, where television was invented, only 8 percent of families owned a television set in the 1950s. However, by 1957, about 78 percent of families owned one. In 1964, this percentage went up to 92 percent. Following the same trend, when computers were first owned by people in the 1980s, no

one had any idea that by the end of the century, in 2000, the computer and Internet would be available to and present in almost every home in the USA.[54]

Despite the Internet's superiority over television, the fact remains that television and Internet are becoming increasingly interrelated. According to study results released by MTV Networks International (MTVNI), a unit of Viacom Inc.:

> Though TV is important to youth in and of itself, it also is one of the most dominant ways of directing youth online, with both TV and online media becoming increasingly interrelated...[55]

When television, computers, and Internet were invented, no one could have imagined that these inventions would be so influential on the society that they would change our entire lifestyle. Muslims have been influenced by these inventions just like the people of any other religion. Sometimes Muslims miss congregational prayers in the mosques because their favourite television show or a certain all-day sports tournament is being broadcast at the same time as the night prayer. Some naïve Muslims will argue that there are many good programmes broadcast on television. This may be true, but right after the good programme, other forbidden programmes, such as music videos, dancing, dramas, and movies, with love affairs or violence as their central theme, are broadcast, which make you forget all about the good material that you may have learned before.

Nowadays, with the advent of the Internet, Muslim youth stay awake late at night, surfing the Web and chatting online, so much so that they miss their dawn prayers. Teenagers ignore or forget about their homework because they are busy texting their friends on their cell phones. For the youth to sit at the dinner table and engage in conversation with their parents and ask them questions has become a thing of the past. Everyone in the

family seems to be addicted to these technological 'plug-in drugs'. Nothing is as dangerous to the socialization of Muslim children and youth as television, computers, and other interactive media devices.

Table II: Statistics about Television and Internet Usage[56]

	Total Time Spent
American youth sitting in front of television	7 years
American youth sitting in front of the Internet	20 years
Children ages 2 to 5 watching television	21.8 hours per week
Children ages 6 to 11 watching television	18.3 hours per week
Households in which television is on most of the time even if no one is watching	40%
Families who watch television while eating their meals	60%
Families within which no conversation takes place while watching television programmes	78%
Youth who report having a favourite television channel that they always tune into	70% Germany 88% India 38% Japan

Social scientific studies reveal that television isolates and hinders the normal growth of relationships between family members. In one such study, 78 percent of informants revealed that no conversation takes place within their families while watching television programmes, except during commercial breaks. The conclusion of the report is as follows:

> The television atmosphere in most households is one of quiet absorption on the part of family members who are present... and the set does seem

> quite clearly to dominate family life when it is on.[57]

Statistics provided by the Henry J. Kaiser Family Foundation are even more startling, according to which:

> ...over 40% of our children say they live in households where "the TV is on most of the time even if no one is watching," and almost 60% say it is on during most meals.[58]

The arrival of television has negatively affected the level of social involvement from citizens as well. Robert Putnam, social historian from Harvard University, alludes to this phenomenon in his book *Bowling Alone: The Collapse and Revival of American Community*. He notes that people tended to have an individual mentality instead of collective thinking starting from the late 1960s and early 1970s. At this point, participation in churches decreased. The involvement of individuals in politics also declined. People in the society lessened social interaction among themselves consistently, and this trend increased significantly in the next two decades. According to Putnam, this decline in social interaction began with America's first television generation. In his words, "More television watching means less of virtually every form of civic participation and social involvement."[59]

Sadly enough, habitual viewing of television is more common among the youth who are glued to the television. Putnam continues, "Habituation to omnipresent television is much more pervasive among younger generations."[60]

It seems that televisions and computers transport their viewers' minds into another world, which decreases civic participation of and social interaction among the people. Social critic James Howard Kunstler summarizes this phenomenon succinctly:

> ...the television is the family's chief connection with the outside world. The physical envelope of the house itself no longer connects their lives to the outside in any active way; rather, it seals them off from it. The outside world has become an abstraction filtered through television, just as the weather is an abstraction filtered through air conditioning.[61]

Muslim youth are following in the footsteps of the youth of the rest of the world. After the arrival of television and computers in Muslim family homes, Muslim youth have become socially detached from the community. Being socially active humanizes children and young people alike, whereas always being in the company of machines mechanizes them, making them devoid of human emotions and feelings. Socialization can only be achieved with civic involvement. If we want to save our youth, we need them to be socially active, not in the virtual world of social media but in the real world of human beings.

Muslim youth and media addiction

One unique fact about the invention of television that distinguishes it from previous inventions is that no other invention prior to television had such a severe impact on children aged six years and younger. Groundbreaking inventions, such as the light bulb, the telephone, and the automobile, had a significant impact on the lives of adults but almost no effect on the daily routine of children.

Once television entered the scene, however, the whole lifestyle of children (and to some extent, teenagers) changed: their plays, their study schedules, their activities, and their sleeping habits – everything was affected. American intellectual Marie Winn wrote in her book *The Plug-In Drug* that due to the mesmerizing influence of television, children watching it are in a state that is neither sleep nor wakefulness.

It is a common parental observation that when children are viewing television and the phone is ringing next to them, they rarely answer it as they are unaware of their surroundings. Their facial expressions change and their lower jaw relaxes, opening their mouth in astonishment while their eyes are fixed on the television screen. Their tongue is speechless and their stomach is unaware of hunger; they do not like to get up and eat in order to avoid missing the programme they are watching. Only when the programme ends do they come out of this spell.[62]

Of course, teenagers and adolescents also experience similar effects in front of television, but not being as naïve and gullible as children, they have the ability to hide and, to some extent, lessen the influence that television has on them.

Parents often observe 'post-television crankiness' in their children and teenagers after the television programme or movie that they are watching ends, often resulting in sibling rivalries and bickering. Even adults feel a sort of emptiness right at the end of programmes or movies, and there could be a scientific basis for this behaviour. Marie Winn explains that this 'post-television crankiness' after television-viewing could be similar to the post-sleep irritability we observe in children. The reason for this irritability is that when they wake up from sleep, they have just entered from one conscious state of the brain (sleep) into another conscious state (wakefulness). If this theory is right, Winn raises an important question:

> What, then, is the child's state of consciousness while watching television? It is clearly not sleep. Is it something other than waking? We are all familiar with drug-induced states of consciousness.[63]

Here, Marie Winn has raised a very thought-provoking question. Scientific studies have shown that when the transition from sleep to wakefulness or from wakefulness to sleep happens, brain-wave patterns

change. This change is sometimes sufficient enough to induce seizures in children with seizure disorders and neurological impairments. It is clear that children are neither in a sleeping state nor entirely awake while watching television. Children appear dazed and confused sitting in front of a television set. They show lack of awareness of anything going on around them while the television is on, which clearly implies that they are not in a state of full wakefulness. This implies that television-viewing induces a third type of conscious state other than wakefulness and sleep, which is very similar to the state of consciousness induced by drugs and alcohol. This observation is further validated when a comparison is made between reading a book and watching television, as Winn states:

> To be sure, other experiences, notably reading, also provide a temporary respite from reality. But it's much easier to stop reading and return to reality than to stop watching television. The entry into another world offered by reading includes an easily accessible return ticket. The entry via television does not. In this way, television viewing, for those vulnerable to addiction, is more like drinking [alcohol] or taking drugs – once you start, it is hard to stop. Just as alcoholics are only vaguely aware of their addiction, feeling that they control their drinking more than they really do… many people overestimate their control over television watching.[64]

The same addiction happens to our youth, and even elders, who spend a lot of time daily visiting social media. Mirza Yawar Baig notes:

> Where does this [being on Facebook, Twitter, Instagram, TikTok, Snapchat, or other social media platforms] lead to? Addiction and intoxication. Addiction to seeing what others are doing and telling others what you are doing on a daily, hourly, minute by minute basis… You don't like the word 'intoxication'? Just don't log onto your Facebook or Twitter account for two days and monitor your heartbeat,

> blood pressure, tremor in your mouse, whatever and you will see what I mean.[65]

When young people and adults alike are using the Internet, they are often unaware of their surroundings – very much like the state of intoxication induced by alcohol or drugs. People who abuse drugs can sometimes overcome their drug addiction by replacing it with an addiction to the Internet.

This observation is supported by a scientific study conducted by scientists at Swansea University (UK) and University of Milan (Italy) on adults in UK. In this study, it was demonstrated that when heavy Internet users go offline, they experience withdrawal symptoms similar to those experienced by drug users.

The heavy Internet use volunteers in this study who were indicated as Internet addicts based on initial testing reported feelings of negative mood and increased anxiety after they stopped surfing the Internet. Such users reported suffering a 'comedown' which the researchers described was not much different from the feelings people experience after using the drug Ecstasy. The authors of this research conclude in their paper:

> The current study aimed to explore the potential differential impact of internet exposure on 'internet addicts' compared to those with little problematic usage. The results showed a striking negative impact of internet exposure on the positive mood of 'internet addicts'. This effect has been suggested in theoretical models of internet addiction… However, that internet addiction was strongly related to autistic traits is a novel finding, and may be similar in nature to previously established associations between social isolation and internet addiction.[66]

In an interview, one of the researchers of this study Phil Reed of Swansea University notes:

> We were actually expecting that people who used the Net a lot would display enhanced moods after use -- reflecting the positive reinforcing properties of the Net. So the key finding of an immediate increased negative mood, the withdrawal effect, was something of a surprise. But the more we looked into the literature, the more it seemed to fit the notion of an addictive disorder.[67]

In this regard, the defence statement given in a German court by Christian Grotheer, known as "Germany's first internet murderer" is very interesting. We will be discussing his case and its outcome later, but what is important to mention here is that he had a history of drug abuse in his earlier life. Then he became heavily involved in online chatting. The reason he gave to the judge for his turning to online chatting was that it "helped him recover from his addiction."[68]

The same feelings were reiterated by Montgomery when he told an ABC News correspondent that during his relationship with 'Jessi', the virtual sex made him "feel kind of dirty", but he was too deep into it to sever ties with her because he was addicted to the online relationship. Montgomery told the news correspondent, "If I was smart, I would've just ended it, but it was like a, a drug that I needed every day."[69]

In 2012, the Associated Press reported an incident that happened in Greeley, Colorado. A woman was so immersed in sharing pictures and videos and playing games on Facebook that her thirteen-month-old son died in the bathroom tub. District judge Thomas Quammen gave her a sentence of ten years in prison. According to the court documents, on September 20, 2010, thirty-four-year-old Shannon Johnson left her thirteen-month-old son in a bathtub to take a bath at 8:30 am. She then went to another room and

logged into her Facebook account to check videos, share pictures, check status updates, and play Café World. She was so occupied with her online experience that she did not realize how much time had elapsed. When she finally returned to the bathroom, she found her thirteen-month-old son lying dead, face down in the bathtub.

According to *The Greeley Tribune*, a local newspaper, District Judge Quammen read the ten-year prison sentence to Shannon and told her:

> You left this little boy in a bathtub so you could entertain yourself on the computer by playing games. And you left that thirteen-month-old human being, little Joseph, incredibly for those reasons.[70]

This is the addiction and intoxication of Internet use and websites such as Facebook. A mother – who was browsing Facebook – did not realize she needed to check on her son playing in the bathtub.

To sum up, electronic media has the power to intoxicate our children and youth. After they have been online or watching television for a significant period of time, they suffer from 'post-television crankiness' and 'post-computer irritability,' and sometimes even 'post-Internet absentmindedness'. People turn on their television set to watch a certain programme or go to certain websites on the Internet, but unbeknownst to them, they end up becoming addicted to it. Today, one of the major reasons why atrocities are being committed against Muslims all over the world and the blood of Muslims is cheaper than the people of any other nation is because our youth and elders are in a sleepwalking state. We need to wake up. The human heart finds peace only in the remembrance of Allah. The Qur'an mentions:

{...verily in the remembrance of Allah hearts find comfort.} *(ar-Ra'd 13: 28)*

The Qur'an is a divine light, and recitation of the Qur'an pacifies and soothes our souls. On the contrary, cathode rays coming out of electronic devices such as television, computers, and other media devices are artificial lights, which only create restlessness in the hearts of our youth. The best solution to our youth's addiction to electronic media is to simply limit their use of television, Internet, and video and computer games. Instead, Muslim youth should be encouraged to utilize their spare time to seek Islamic knowledge and get involved in community service for the benefit of the society.

Muslim youth and the advertising industry

Advertising is a form of communication for marketing, and its functions are to attract attention, stimulate interest, arouse desire, and secure action. Advertising, by its very nature, is formulated to influence people. Today, young people are the prime target of the capitalist advertising industry. These companies are aware that if they are successful in winning a young customer, it may result in a lifetime of loyalty to their product. Youth are the consumers of today as well as the future. Advertisement agencies know very well that young men and women easily accept new things. In addition, youth do not have as much knowledge and experience as their elders and, hence, they cannot test and analyze every advertised commodity. As a result, the youth are more influenced by advertising messages than mature adults or older people. On top of all this, due to peer pressure, young people are very quick to imitate their peers as well as their role models. Companies spend a major portion of their budget on advertising in order to sell their products to the youth.

Marketing experts have divided young people into subgroups in order to be more specific in their advertising:

- Tween marketing targets people aged 8-12;
- Teen marketing targets people in the age range 13-19;
- College marketing targets college-attending youth;
- Young adult marketing targets young, professional men and women who are 22 or older.

Viacom Brand Solutions International (VBSI) conducted another large study between January and August, 2008, on more than 25,000 respondents aged 16-46 from eighteen different countries, including Argentina, Australia, Brazil, China, Denmark, Germany, Holland, Italy, India, Japan, Mexico, New Zealand, Poland, Spain, Saudi Arabia, Sweden, UK, and USA. In this study, VBSI categorized young men and women into three groups based on their consumer behaviour. Youth aged 16-19 are in the 'discovery' stage; youth aged 20-24 are in the 'experimentation' stage; youth aged 25-34 years are in the 'golden' stage.

One of the findings of this study was that people aged 25-34 usually do not respond to the same marketing techniques as those who are 16-19 years (teens). It was also discovered in this study that teenagers are heavily focused on material gain and purchase the brands that define their identity. On the other hand, the 25 to 34 year-old 'golden' stage youth are more attracted to expensive and often luxurious brands of products to assert their identity. In this regard, Kevin Razvi, Former Executive Vice President and Managing Director of VBSI, notes:

> 25-to-34-year-olds are continuing to consume music, gaming and the internet and are enjoying the pursuits of their younger years while benefiting from a greater level of personal and financial freedom.[71]

Successful brand marketing companies use key interests and popular topics among the youth, such as music, fashion, video games, sports, and media, to provoke their interest. For instance, Jules Robinson, Senior Vice-President at Viacom Brand Solutions International, notes the impact of television marketing on the youth as follows:

> Despite the economic climate and challenging circumstances for advertisers, we still see a proven ability for TV advertising to reach the target youth audience in the most direct, impactful way.[72]

In their zeal to sell their goods, many advertisers adopt objectionable practices, which are devoid of any ethical sense or moral value. Subliminal messages, for example, are often used in advertisements in order to implant the advertised message in the viewers' subconscious. In fact, in advertising in general, as Denise Winn, a British journalist, editor, and author specializing in psychology and medicine, notes:

> ...it is not the overt message that is important, it is the hidden message, that stirs up largely unconscious guilt or insecurity which can be relieved by purchasing the product.[73]

Advertisers also use embedded marketing, which involves product placement – for example, a brand or product is placed in advertisements, music videos, movies, television shows, or news programmes without any context.

Today, the beardless culture is rampant among young Muslim men. Various factors are contributing to this trend among the Muslim youth, including feelings of inferiority to the Western clean-shaven culture and the glorification of clean-shaven celebrities and athletes on television, in movies, and on the news. However, the multi-billion dollar shaving products industry also has its share in promoting the clean-shave culture

among Muslim youth. For instance, in the September 27, 1989 issue of *Advertising Age* magazine, Gillette was ranked 59 out of 100 leading national advertisers in the USA because it had spent $160.5 million US dollars on advertising its products (most importantly, shaving blades and razors).[74] The report stated that one of the goals of advertisements promoting shaving products was to "win back younger customers."[75]

The advertisers always keep in mind the basic instincts of youth when they are formulating their advertisements. For instance:

> Let us take the example of a typical TV commercial of shaving products. The first scene of the commercial might show a young man shaving his beard, and the next scene shows the same clean-shaven man enjoying the company of a beautiful woman. Such a commercial gives the impression to its viewers that women love men with clean-shaven faces. Similarly, in print media advertisements – such as in magazines or billboards – a shaving company may display the image of a clean-shaven man hugging a young beautiful woman juxtaposed with a shaving product such as a razor or a shaving cream or an after-shave lotion.[76]

By using young, attractive women consistently in advertisements, marketers have completely skewed the criterion of female beauty in the eyes of both men and women. Many teenage girls and young women – Muslims and non-Muslims – are obsessed with the idea of possessing extremely slim bodies. Some become victims of anorexia nervosa and sometimes, starve themselves to death in an attempt to achieve the beauty standard portrayed in advertisements. The image of young, slim women in advertisements is portrayed as the golden standard of beauty, and this image greatly assists capitalist companies to sell their make-up, cosmetic goods,

and weight-loss products to women. Denise Winn mentions this mentality of advertisers as follows:

> It is not enough to aim at girls over fourteen but under 21; better to focus on fourteen to 21-year-olds who come from strict homes, are bothered about their weight and feel guilty about self-indulgence, and pitch the sales-talk accordingly. Just as confession may bring relief from anxiety, so may buying a particular product.[77]

The same is happening in the advertisements of tobacco products among the youth. The tobacco industry is continuously losing customers because many smokers quit smoking or die from tobacco-related diseases such as lung cancer. Muslim youth are not immune to the viral advertisements of tobacco products shown in the media in Muslim countries. Tobacco use among many young men eventually leads to the use of drugs, such as heroin, cocaine, LSD, and others. According to a recent report released by the US Surgeon General, tobacco ads target young people, and there is enough evidence to prove a relationship between advertising by tobacco companies and the instigation of the habit of smoking among young people. Dr. Maansi Bansal-Travers from the Roswell Park Cancer Institute states:

> We know that tobacco marketing works. We know that the tobacco industry spends over a million dollars an hour on marketing, which comes to over $10 billion a year. It promotes the sense that smoking makes them [young people] look cool; that it makes them more attractive, that it makes them fit in with their friends. Marketing makes smoking look normal.[78]

Another area of concern when it comes to advertisements targeting the youth lies in the marketing of alcohol. Manufacturers of wine, spirits, and beer primarily target young men and women in their ads. In 2012, the

Journal of Adolescent Health published a detailed study in which the relationship between problematic content in alcohol ads and youth exposure was measured. This study was the first of its kind to examine risky behaviours depicted in alcohol advertising in the past decade. The study comprised a content analysis of 1,261 unique alcohol advertisements for "alcopops, beer, spirits or wine," which appeared more than 2,600 times in eleven different magazines with heavy youthful readerships between 2003 and 2007.[79] The advertisements were reviewed for subject matter relevant to injury, overconsumption, addiction, and sex-related messages. The results of this study showed that those alcohol ads frequently showed alcohol being consumed near or on bodies of water to increase the appeal of the message and provided messages supportive of alcohol addiction. Furthermore, about 20 percent of alcohol advertisements had sex-related content in them.[80] This research was done by the Center on Alcohol Marketing and Youth (CAMY) at the Johns Hopkins Bloomberg School of Public Health. Commenting on the findings of this study, CAMY director and study co-author David Jernigan states:

> The bottom line here is that youth are getting hit repeatedly by ads for spirits and beer in magazines geared towards their age demographic… As at least 14 studies have found that the more young people are exposed to alcohol advertising and marketing, the more likely they are to drink, or if already drinking, to drink more, this report should serve as a wake-up call to parents and everyone else concerned about the health of young people.[81]

Alcohol use is responsible for 4,700 deaths every year among young people under the age of twenty-one. In addition, alcohol use is connected with the three main causes of death among young men and women: motor vehicle accidents, homicide, and suicide.[82]

It is clear that modern-day advertisements have the full backing of today's electronic media, and they target the youth more effectively than ever witnessed in human history. In the modern age of Dajjâl, the advertisements not only promote evil practices such as smoking, violent entertainment, alcohol use, anorexia nervosa, and beardless culture, but they also promote an artificial ego-centred lifestyle. They affect the social behaviour of youth by using psychological pressure, and they exploit the desires of young consumers by targeting their emotional weaknesses and making the products appealing to them. The marketing industry creates tastes, fashions, and desires for certain products in such a way that many youth are forced to buy things beyond their means, and others feel discontented for not having or being able to afford the same products. Interestingly, by their nature and the way they present their message to their viewers, advertisements are extremely similar to the whispers of Satan. He whispers into the hearts of human beings in very subtle ways, and they are very effective on humans. The Qur'an mentions:

{Who whispers into the hearts of humankind.} *(an-Nâs 114: 5)*

The strategy used by advertisers targeting the youth is very similar to the line of attack employed by Satan, which consists of causing the scum of the world to look attractive, as the Qur'an mentions:

{…and the Satan made fair-seeming to them what they were doing.} *(al-An'âm 6: 43)*

{And [remember] when Satan made their deeds appear fair-seeming to them…} *(al-Anfâl 8: 48)*

Satan will confess this – after being sent to hellfire – in front of all the human beings who followed him in this worldly life, as the Qur'an mentions:

{And Satan will say, when the matter is decided: Verily, Allah gave you a true promise; I also gave you promises, but I betrayed you. I had no power over you, except that I called you and you responded to me. So do not blame me; blame yourselves. I cannot help you, nor can you help me. I disavow your erstwhile association of me with Allah. Verily, for the wrongdoers there will be a painful punishment.} *(Ibrâheem 14: 22)*

The word 'seduction' means to entice away from duty, rectitude, or chastity. This is precisely what many advertisements do when they exploit the carnal desires of the youth in order to successfully market their products. Advertisements make everything look attractive to their viewers. After all, that is the whole idea of advertising: to seduce the consumers.

Muslim youth and music

Today, music has become prevalent due to recording instruments and electronic devices. Music has deep implications for the socialization and behaviour of youth. A 1999 report by the Henry J. Kaiser Family Foundation looked at the trend of youth towards audio media (music) in their study. They state:

> Rather than declining during adolescence, exposure to audio media (CDs and tapes, and radio) continues to climb throughout the first eighteen years, almost doubling between 8-13 years and 14-18 years – clear evidence of the rising importance of popular music in adolescent lives...[83]

In terms of the choice of music among school-age youth, it was noted in this report that, in general, two types of music are predominant. Rap/hip-hop is listened to by 53 percent of middle school and high school students, whereas alternative rock is listened to by 42 percent of school youth.[84]

Professor Allan Bloom was an American intellectual and professor at the University of Chicago, who also taught at Yale, University of Paris, University of Toronto, and Cornell University. Professor Bloom asserts in his book *The Closing of the American Mind* that today a great proportion of young people are addicted to music. Present-age music is their passion, "they cannot take seriously anything alien to music" and whether they are at school or with their families, "they are longing to plug themselves back into their music."[85]

Based on his observation of students all over the world, Professor Bloom contends that modern-day youth's addiction to music is a universal phenomenon. He writes:

> Picture a thirteen-year-old boy sitting in the living room of his family home doing his math assignment while wearing his Walkman headphones or watching MTV… This description may seem exaggerated, but only some would prefer to regard it as such. The continuing exposure to rock music is a reality not one confined to a particular class or type of child. One need only ask first-year university students what music they listen to, how much of it and what it means to them, in order to discover that the phenomenon is universal in America, that it begins in adolescence or a bit before and continues through the college years. It is *the* youth culture… there is now no other countervailing nourishment for the spirit.[86]

Muslim youth have become addicted to music just like non-Muslim youth in the rest of the world. There is no doubt that listening to music is forbidden, as the Qur'an mentions:

{But among people are some who resort to frivolous talk in order to mislead others from the path of Allah without knowledge and to make a

mockery of it. For such there will be a humiliating punishment.} *(Luqmân 31: 6)*

‘Abdullâh ibn Mas‘ood said about this verse, “I swear by Allah that it refers to singing; I swear by Allah that it refers to singing; I swear by Allah that it refers to singing.”[87] Ibn ‘Abbâs (may Allah be pleased with both of them) said it referred to “singing and the like,” whereas according to Jâbir ibn ‘Abdullâh, its meanings signify singing and listening to songs.[88]

Similarly, Allah said to Satan, as the Qur’an mentions:

{Entice whomever among them you can with your voice; mobilize your cavalry and infantry against them, share with them in their wealth and their children, and make promises to them. But Satan makes promises to them only in order to deceive them.} *(al-Isrâ’ 17: 64)*

Some pious predecessors such as aḍ-Ḍaḥḥâk, al-Ḥasan al-Baṣri, and Mujâhid interpreted Satan exciting humankind with his {voice} to mean through the use of music, songs, and amusement. Aḍ-Ḍaḥḥâk said it was the sound of wind instruments. However, according to Ibn ‘Abbâs (may Allah be pleased with both of them), the {voice} mentioned in the verse refers to every form of invitation to the disobedience of Allah.[89]

Another proof that establishes its prohibition is the hadith reported by Abu Mâlik al-Ash‘ari in which Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) said:

«لَيَكُونَنَّ مِنْ أُمَّتِي أَقْوَامٌ، يَسْتَحِلُّونَ الحِرَ وَالحَرِيرَ، وَالخَمْرَ وَالمَعَازِفَ.»

«There will be people in my Ummah (community or nation) who will seek to make lawful fornication, wine-drinking, and using musical instruments.» (Bukhari)[90]

It is clear from this hadith that musical instruments are prohibited, just like the prohibition of fornication, wearing of silk by men, and alcohol. In another hadith, Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) said the following about the signs of the end of times:

«لَيَشْرَبَنَّ نَاسٌ مِنْ أُمَّتِي الْخَمْرَ، يُسَمُّونَهَا بِغَيْرِ اسْمِهَا، يُعْزَفُ عَلَى رُءُوسِهِمْ بِالْمَعَازِفِ، وَالْمُغَنِّيَاتِ، يَخْسِفُ اللهُ بِهِمُ الْأَرْضَ، وَيَجْعَلُ مِنْهُمُ الْقِرَدَةَ وَالْخَنَازِيرَ.»

«Soon there will be people in my Ummah who will drink wine, calling it by (something else) other than its real name. Instruments of music and singing will be on their heads, and they will listen to female singers. Allah will cleave the earth under them and turn others into apes and swine.» (An authentic hadith recorded by Ibn Mâjah; al-Albâni graded it sound)[91]

One of the signs of the end of times is that people will carry musical instruments on their heads. Today, when we watch people walking with headphones on their heads playing the music, we see a nearly 1,400-year-old prophecy come true. Commenting on the recent invention of portable music devices, medical researchers Elizabeth F. Brown, MD and William R. Hendee, Ph.D. observe that during the early era of rock music, radios were big in size and hard to carry around, but for today's youth, "music is particularly ubiquitous" because:

> Music became portable with the advent of transistor radios. Recent innovations in miniaturization and the development of light high-quality headphones have made it possible for teenagers to envelop themselves constantly in rock music.[92]

Sex is the most common theme of most of the prevalent music as I have shown in detail in my book *The Music Made Me Do It*.[93] To make this even worse, many youth-oriented popular songs and musical videos depict women as sexual objects rather than human beings, and this degrading

portrayal of women has far-reaching consequences on the future behaviour of youth who listen to them and watch them. These songs and music videos feature young males contending with one another for females who are viewed as sexual objects or conquests, and whose value lies only in their physical appearance.[94] This depiction of men as sexually insatiable and women as sexual objects is especially widespread in music videos.[95] It is one of the worst types of exploitation to reduce women to mere sexual objects, and frequent viewing of this type of content has been strongly linked to emerging youth's growing social acceptance towards this view of women. This link was exposed by media researcher L. Monique Ward, a psychologist at the University of Michigan, in a study published in the 2002 issue of the *Journal of Youth and Adolescence*.[96]

Portrayal of women as sexual objects could affect the sexual behaviour of emerging adolescent girls and boys who internalize these messages due to repeated exposure. A social scientific study published in the medical journal *Pediatrics* supports this argument.[97] Steven Martino, Ph.D., a behavioural scientist at the Rand Corporation in Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania and his associate scientists conducted a national longitudinal telephone survey of 1,461 adolescents aged 12-17. Participants were interviewed at baseline, when they were 12-17 years old, and again one and three years later. Most participants were virgins when they were first interviewed in 2001. Follow-up interviews were conducted in the years 2002 and 2004 to see if choice of music had influenced their later behaviour. The subjects of the study also indicated how frequently each of them listened to more than a dozen singers well-liked by the youth of that time. The study found out that teenagers who listened to a lot of music with degrading sexual messages (for example, depicting women as sexual objects) were almost twice as likely to get involved in sexual activities within the next two years of the

study, as compared to the teens who listened to little or no sexually degrading music. Martino states:

> Exposure to lots of sexually degrading music 'gives them a specific message about sex.' Boys learn they should be relentless in pursuit of women and girls learn to view themselves as sex objects.[98]

Commenting on the influence of music's content on adolescents' sexual behaviour, Martino further writes:

> Musicians who incorporate this type of sexual imagery in their songs are not simply modeling an interest in healthy sexual behaviour for their listeners; they are communicating something specific about what are appropriate sexual roles for men and women… Despite the fact that degrading sexual lyrics are particularly demeaning in their treatment of women, they affect adolescent boys and girls similarly… Our research… does suggest that degrading sexual lyrics do more than "go in one ear and out the other."[99]

This is the reality of popular music and all the dirty baggage that comes with it. If we carefully analyze any song that has sex and romance as its theme, we will observe that the emphasis is always on the physical appearance of a woman, thus portraying her as a sexual commodity. Never do we find such songs praising the intelligence of a woman or her high spiritual status. Modern-day music is the biggest promoter of female slavery. Women forget the importance of chastity and modesty after they are brainwashed with musical videos and songs depicting them in a sexual way, and men compete with each other to win them. While such behaviour may be appropriate for animals, human beings must act like human beings. Muslim women must remember that they are not the sexual objects they are being portrayed as in the music industry, and Muslim men must not adopt

this view of women and of themselves as insatiable sexual beings. Modesty is the most valuable asset for both Muslim men and women.

Chapter 4: Muslim Youth and Social Media

Today, with the advent of technology, we have many comforts and conveniences. However, those comforts and conveniences have come with a price – the ability and tendency of technology to be misused and abused more easily than it is put to beneficial use. Modern media technology for youth, by its nature, is very similar to alcohol in that its harms outweigh its few benefits, as the Qur'an mentions:

{They ask you about intoxicants and gambling. Say: In them is great sin, and some benefit, for people; but the sin is greater than the benefit...} *(al-Baqarah 2: 219)*

Islam is not against technology. However, it is the Islamic principle, in the case of any new technology, to weigh its benefits against its harms. If the harms of a new invention are much more than its benefits, extreme care must be exercised in its use. The purpose of shedding light on the problems caused by uncritical acceptance of technology is not that we completely reject that technology. As Muslims, we must evaluate each technology carefully, decide if it should be adopted, ask what the possible outcomes could be of accepting it, and how we can reduce the potential harm of the technology while still benefiting from its advantages.

We must understand and forecast the societal impacts of each technology before we import them into Muslim countries. Of course, practical experience and history tells us that imperialist powers do not want Muslim countries to import defence capabilities and industrial technologies that could strengthen them and their power in the world. The West only allows technology that can be used to spread corruption and lewdness in Muslim countries and populations, such as television and the Internet.

Let us take one example from the recent past. Muhammad Ali Pasha ruled Egypt from 1805 to 1848 CE. He was bent upon the Westernization of Egypt. It was through his efforts that Muslim women began to forsake hijab, Muslim men started shaving their faces, and musical theatres opened in Egypt. His successor Khedive Ismail, who ruled Egypt from 1863 to 1879 CE, even declared, "My country is no longer in Africa, it is in Europe."[100] Despite this, when Muhammad Ali Pasha tried to strengthen Egypt's industry by importing textile and other similar beneficial technologies from the West, the European powers made a joint assault on him to halt his efforts to advance Egypt in science and technology. Muslim social critic Khalid Baig mentions this approach of the West to Muslim countries in the following words:

> There was a clear message: There is technology you can have and technology you cannot touch. Genuine defence capabilities are not allowed. Genuine industrial capability that will make you independent and contribute to real economic power is not allowed. The latest musical instruments and colour televisions? No problem.[101]

If we take a cursory look at the history of the arrival of media technology in Muslim countries, we will see that the Gramophone was invented in 1887 in Great Britain, and the British government started to introduce it in the sub-continent (present day India, Pakistan, and

Bangladesh) in 1902. For this purpose, a separate company by the name of GTL was founded. Within a few years, sounds of music and singing could be heard from every other home in the sub-continent.[102]

A similar pattern was observed for radio, which was introduced as a news and entertainment tool in the 1920s. During 1936, radio licenses were issued to the public in India at such a rate that 1,500 licenses were issued every year.[103] In Egypt, the rate of issuance of radio licenses was significantly faster than in other places. Radio was introduced in Egypt in 1934, and by 1956, there were 405,000 owners of radio in Egypt. Other Muslim countries followed the same pattern.[104]

Radio is a technology that has only audio (the visual dimension is absent, and we cannot see pictures on it), and yet the magnitude of its morally destructive effects can be estimated from Lila Abu-Lughod's commentary about a Muslim girl living in a remote village of Egypt who listens daily to radio programmes:

> All day long, as she goes about her household chores or sits idly, she listens to the radio. She knows all the Egyptian singers, she follows all the radio dramas – about movie stars whose husbands have left them, about young women who have escaped arranged marriages to wealthy old men to elope with young ones whom the old tyrants try to destroy, and… about young men who seek [to no avail] through computer matchmaking appropriate brides when their mothers will not allow them to marry the woman of their choice.[105]

Likewise, television was introduced in Muslim countries by the Western imperialist powers. Thereafter, a chain reaction started, with each succeeding media technology having a more demoralizing influence than the preceding media on the Muslim youth.

Muslim youth and electronic devices

There is no doubt that all electronic devices offer myriad benefits. However, their harms are more than their benefits, as we studied in the case of alcohol. The same is true about the use of cameras on modern cell phones. Cell phones were invented for the ease and convenience of people. However, the advent of smartphones such as iPhones, Blackberries, and other similar devices, has proven to be a disaster for many youth. Text messaging was introduced through mobile phones, and shortly afterwards, texting became popular among the youth to exchange messages of love or affection. Premarital love affairs have increased among Muslim boys and girls with the introduction of phones with texting abilities. The most prominent manifestation of this is on the occasion of Valentine's Day, when mass amounts of messages are exchanged between lovers using text-messaging technology.

Parents are often completely unaware about who their young son or daughter is talking to, or where the call or text message is coming from. Many parents are so busy with their jobs or in their business that they do not even have time to check the contact list in their child's cell phone. Forbidden love affairs can be carried out quietly using text messaging on cell phones in the comfort of one's home, sometimes while young people are sitting right next to their parents without the latter even realizing what is going on.

When it was felt that merely talking or texting on the phone was not enough to quench the emotional thirst of many consumers, cell phone cameras were introduced to further intensify the emotional thirst. Now cell phones come with high-resolution cameras, making it easier to attach your picture along with a text message.

The practice of writing an inappropriately sexual text message, attaching a crude or provocative picture, and sending it to a partner or love interest is called 'sexting'. It is the act of sending sexually explicit messages or pictures via mobile phone or instant messenger. The National Campaign to Prevent Teen and Unplanned Pregnancy and COSMOgirl.com (currently www.seventeen.com) conducted a comprehensive survey of 1,280 teenagers and young adults of both genders. Results from this survey revealed that 20 percent of teenagers (aged 13-20) and 33 percent of young adults had sent nude or semi-nude pictures of themselves electronically. In addition, 39 percent of teenage boys and girls and 59 percent of young adults had sent sexually explicit text messages. This is how the wicked journey from texting to sexting took place.[106]

A study of sexting was also conducted by scientists at the Department of Psychology, University of Utah. In this study, which was published in the June 2012 issue of the *Archives of Sexual Behavior*, the investigating psychologists Strassberg and his associates surveyed 606 teenagers (aged 14-18). About 20 percent of the students admitted that they had sent a sexually explicit image of themselves via a mobile phone, and almost twice as many students acknowledged that they had received a sexually explicit picture. Among those who had received such a picture through sexting, more than 25 percent mentioned that they had forwarded it to others. Sadly enough, the researchers also found that out of the youth who had sent a sexually explicit picture through sexting, more than a third had done so despite believing that there could be serious consequences if they got caught. The investigating psychologists Strassberg and his colleagues write:

> We anticipated that teens comfortable with sexually explicit digital communication (i.e., sexting) might also be those who are, in general, more comfortable and experienced with text messaging as a form of

> communication… Prior surveys, and the results of this study, suggest that many high school (and perhaps even younger) students are sending and/or receiving sexually explicit photos of each other...[107]

Not only is the practice of sexting completely forbidden in the light of the Islamic teachings, but significant risks and social dangers are also associated with it. Internet Watch Foundation published its findings in 2012 in which it was reported that nearly 88 percent of self-made explicit images are 'stolen' from their original upload sites (for example, social networks where the sexting images eventually end up in many cases), and then they are made available on porn sites which collect sexual images of children and young people. This report expressed concern at the risk of severe depression among 'sexters' when their images get out of their control.[108] Once their sexually explicit photos are posted online, they leave a digital footprint, and they cannot 'take it back'. Obviously, prior to the advent of cell phones with high resolution cameras and emails, it was quite difficult to send the photos even to one's acquaintances. Now, with sexting, a provocative photo can be forwarded to anyone with the click of a button, and it can quickly become viral with someone's neglect or evil intentions.

The Internet was introduced in most Muslim countries no more than two decades ago. Within a few years, the number of Internet users (mostly youth) skyrocketed. Due to the easy availability of pornographic sites, the trend to visit them is increasing, especially among teenagers. Furthermore, complete pornographic movies are placed on computer hard drives located in Internet cafés. Such public Internet cafés are more prevalent in Muslim countries in Africa and Asia where the Internet is not easily accessible in every home. Such places destroy the mentality, faith, and purity of thought of the youth who regularly visit these places.

Misuse of the Internet has only become worse with the advent of 'one-eyed' video communication over the Internet using applications like Facetime, Skype, Google Chat (Google Hangouts), WhatsApp, Zoom, and any other type of video chatting software/website. With the arrival of video communication over the Internet, intrusion into the privacy of people's homes has become increasingly easy. When girls or young women are talking to their female friends over a webcam, they often do not realize that on the other side, in addition to their female friend, her male family members can also view her video on this 'one-eyed' computer screen, or if it is not live, male family members can view the videos when their sisters are not around. This is especially a matter of concern because according to a new study from comScore (an American Internet analytics company), women in every age group spend more time than men on online photo-sharing sites. This is true not just in one country but worldwide that women surpass men in this aspect. Worldwide, 46.5 percent of women and 41.5 percent of men visit photo-sharing websites. Furthermore, it was also observed that more women than men share photos online.[109]

No doubt these programs and technologies have some useful purposes, such as using video chat to connect with family members or interview job candidates who are overseas. However, we are discussing the potential harms of these technologies. Our youth can only protect themselves if they are fully aware of the potential harms of these media technologies in this age of Dajjâl.

Muslim youth and social media (Facebook/ Twitter/Instagram/TikTok)

The Internet has many uses – some are beneficial while others are harmful. Which feature of the Internet attracts people the most? Dr. Frank Biocca defines the most popular use of the Internet as follows:

> The history of the Internet suggests that what attracts most people to it is not information: it is other people. Internet services that allow like-minded people to gather and interconnect are booming. The most social corners of the Internet are populated mostly with young users.
>
> Since the beginning of the Internet, various environments have been created to allow people to meet each other and interact.[110]

It is no wonder that one of the recent obsessions amongst the youth all over the world is the use of social media and online chatting. This social interaction among the youth may be beneficial, but it also has certain obvious harms, which will be discussed below.

An Islamic society respects the privacy of its citizens. The Qur'an mentions:

{...Do not spy on one another, and do not backbite one another...} *(al-Ḥujurât 49: 12)*

The Qur'an commands the Muslims not to search for people's secrets or weaknesses. Islam has prohibited the Muslims from spying on others, whether this is done because of suspicion or to satisfy one's curiosity. It does not befit a believer to spy on the hidden affairs of other people or peep at them from behind curtains. Also included in this realm of 'social spying' acts are:

- Listening secretly to private conversations between people;
- Reading other people's private letters;

- Peeping into neighbours' houses out of curiosity or in order to get information about their domestic life or private affairs.

This act of immorality results in disastrous consequences in the community. In one hadith, our beloved Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) discussed the habit of prying into other people's affairs:

«إِنَّكَ إِنِ اتَّبَعْتَ عَوْرَاتِ النَّاسِ أَفْسَدْتَهُمْ، أَوْ كِدْتَ أَنْ تُفْسِدَهُمْ.»

«If you start prying into people's secret affairs, you will corrupt them or, at the very least, drive them very near to corruption.» (Recorded by Abu Dâwood; graded sound by al-Albâni)[111]

Even though the old proverb states, "Curiosity killed the cat," curiosity is, nonetheless, a basic human trait. Human beings are curious by nature, and Islamic teachings keep checks and balances on this human compulsion. It is due to this weakness in human beings that websites like Facebook, Twitter, Instagram, Peekyou, Bebo, Meetme, and many others have gained popularity. Among these, Facebook is the most visited site on the Internet. Based on 2011 statistics provided by facebook.com and pingdom.com, a Facebook user spends an average of 15 hours and 33 minutes on Facebook per month and 23 minutes on each visit. Based on the global breakdown of users on Facebook, 20.6 percent are 13-17 years old, 26.4 percent are 18-25 years old and 26.6 percent are 26-34 years old.[112] This means that three-fourths or 72.5 percent of Facebook users are young men and women in the age range of 13-34 years. Muslim men and women are not behind in embracing each and every technology that is likewise embraced by non-Muslims, hence following in the footsteps of Jews and Christians as well as people of other religions just to prove the truth of our beloved Prophet Muhammad's prophecy.

The following table gives a breakdown of Facebook users among the population of some Muslim countries as of the year 2012, along with the

percent penetration of Facebook usage among the people of each country.

Table III: Statistics about Facebook Users in some Muslim Countries in 2012[113]

Countries	Population of Facebook users	Penetration rate* (percentage of Facebook users)
Turkey	30,963,100	39.3%
United Arab Emirates	3,190,660	38.6%
Jordan	2,481,940	38.1%
Lebanon	1,571,900	38.0%
Kuwait	824,880	31.2%
Bahrain	375,000	30.0%
Tunis	3,103,500	28.9%
Saudi Arabia	5,536,280	20.9%
Indonesia	47,539,220	19.1%
Morocco	4,576,280	14.2%
Egypt	11,764,880	14.1%
Libya	560,080	10.0%
Sudan	4,200,000	9.3%
Pakistan	7,227,780	3.8%
Yemen	633,060	2.6%
Bangladesh	2,987,820	1.9%

How are these websites useful, if they have any use at all? Mirza Yawar Baig answers this question in his thought-provoking article *Facebook: Social Networking or Social Engineering?*

> Of course you will hear the usual bleating saying: It is so nice to know what my sister is doing….blah, blah.

> So ask this person: Why can't you send your sister an email asking what she is doing and she can respond to you. Or even better, if you can, call your sister and talk to her. But no, I must talk to my sister in a space where it is not only the sister who is listening but almost anyone who cares to listen, even if that person is a total stranger. So is it about your concern for your sister or is it something else?
>
> So also in this space are pictures which really have no place outside the home – like the pictures showing you hugging your sister or wife or whoever![114]

Some naïve Muslims claim that there are privacy controls on social media, and we can block the access of whomever we want. Baig writes regarding those controls:

> Yes, of course there are controls. Tell me all about them. Tell me also how come almost nobody uses them... of course in the end, all control is only as good as the techies and geeks on the Facebook site allow. After all they can access all that information anyway.[115]

Youth by their nature do not like controls. For instance, in one survey conducted in 2007, it was discovered that nearly half of the teenagers who had established an online profile (47 percent out of the total) had it set as public and viewable by everyone. In addition, the majority of teens (58 percent) did not think posting photos or other personal information online was unsafe.[116] This finding in itself tells us that controls are rarely used by the youth because they are not deemed to be necessary.

What is being achieved by being 'online' on social media for hours and hours? It is the same curiosity, the desire to learn about the private affairs of other people (of course, in this case with the latter's permission), and the desire for social spying. With new social engineering in this age of Dajjâl,

our youth are conditioned and brainwashed to believe that it is alright to peek into the lives of each other, even to seek minor details. No longer are we instructed to control ourselves and mind our own business. No longer are we told to follow the hadith of our beloved Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) as narrated by Abu Hurayrah:

«إِنَّ مِنْ حُسْنِ إِسْلَامِ المَرْءِ تَرْكُهُ مَا لَا يَعْنِيهِ.»

«The perfection of a person's Islam includes his leaving what does not concern him.» (Recorded by at-Tirmidhi; graded reliable by al-Albâni)[117]

Baig elaborates further on this issue very eloquently, as he writes:

> What is achieved is what would be the equivalent of peeping in through your window... I want to know what you are doing all the time and I want you to know what I am doing all the time.[118]

In 2007, Cox Communications Inc., in partnership with the National Center for Missing & Exploited Children (NCMEC), conducted their third annual survey to help parents realize the potential dangers of the Internet. The results of this survey are summarized in the following table:

Table IV: Internet Usage by Teenagers[119]

Youth Trend and Behaviour	Percentage
Teenagers who believe that there is no danger in posting your pictures online	58.0%
Girls who post their personal photos or videos of themselves	70.0%
Boys who post their personal photos or videos of themselves	58.0%
Girls who are harassed or bullied online	21.0%
Boys who are harassed or bullied online	17.0%

Youth Trend and Behaviour	Percentage
Teenage boys and girls who had considered meeting face-to-face with someone they met only online	16.0%
Teenage boys and girls who had actually met face-to-face with someone they have met on the Internet	8.0%

This research revealed that nearly two-thirds of teenagers (64 percent) regularly post photos or videos of themselves online. To add insult to injury, the report disclosed that 58 percent of teenagers believe that there is no danger in posting their pictures online (for instance, on websites such as Facebook, Twitter, MySpace, Friendster, Instagram, Snapchat, TikTok and so on). Furthermore, the report found that females are far more likely than males to post personal photos or videos of themselves (70 percent versus 58 percent). It was also found that girls are more likely to be harassed or bullied online than boys (21 percent versus 17 percent). The research also revealed another shocking finding: 16 percent of teenage boys and girls said that they had considered meeting face-to-face with someone they had talked to online only, and 8 percent of teenage boys and girls disclosed that they actually had met face-to-face with someone they befriended on the Internet.[120]

Muslim women and the Islamic position on online chatting and Facebook

Email is an electronic technology that has more benefits than harms. However, the harms of chatting over the Internet far outweigh the benefits. The least of its harms is wastage of precious time. Internet chatting has branched into various categories due to recent advances in technology. Now

we have text chat (on-screen text displays), audio chat (voice interactions and icons), text MUDS and MOOS (on-screen text interaction within structured fantasy environments), pictorial social environments (two-dimensional visual environments and text), and so on.[121] In the virtual world of the Internet, social media is getting more complex and devoid of moral values at an increasing speed. For instance, the newest virtual social environments have the ability to support more than a thousand users simultaneously. The Internet users get involved in increasingly problematic social behaviours, such as virtual street gangs, real transactions, fights, and virtual sex with three-dimensional interaction, which has more physical involvement.[122] Hence, virtual sex happens within the 'one-eyed' screen of a computer or smartphone.

These technologies are the biggest source of temptation for our Muslim youth in this age of Dajjâl. If this is not the age of Dajjâl, then what else is it? There is no doubt that these devices are not Dajjâl himself, but they are the agents preparing the stage for his arrival by negatively influencing our youth.

Now that we have described different forms of chatting, let us discuss the issue of online chatting between men and women – no matter what kind of chat it is – from an Islamic point of view. Shaykh 'Abdullâh ibn 'Abdur-Raḥmân ibn Jibreen (d. July 13, 2009) was once asked about the ruling on correspondence between young men and women, if the correspondence was free from immorality, sin, and love. Shaykh Ibn Jibreen issued the following verdict in reply:

> It is not permissible for any man to correspond with a woman who is not his maḥram [non-marriageable close relative] because of the fitnah [temptation] involved in that. A person may think that there is no fitnah, but Satan will keep trying until he tempts him. The Prophet [bpuh]

> commanded those who heard of Dajjâl to keep away from him. He said that a man may approach him as a believer, but Dajjâl will keep trying until he leads him astray.
>
> Correspondence between young men and women involves a great deal of fitnah and danger, so we must avoid it, even though the questioner says that this correspondence is free from immorality and love.[123]

Likewise, a Muslim sister asked Shaykh Muhammad Salih al-Munajjid a question. She mentioned to him that she uses the Internet and also visits Islamic chat rooms. Sometimes she is approached by a Muslim brother in the chat room who asks her to have a private written chat with him so that they may get to know each other. He also tries to engage in some sort of chatting with her, asking her different questions about herself. The Muslim sister asked Shaykh al-Munajjid if it is really a sin to have written communication with a non-maḥram male. Shaykh al-Munajjid gave the following verdict in response to her question:

> There is nothing wrong with a Muslim woman making use of the internet… so long as that does not lead to anything that is forbidden in Islam, such as talking privately with men. That is because talking to men may turn into chat which usually leads [to] temptation. Hence it is essential to be strict and avoid that, seeking the pleasure of Allaah and fearing His punishment.
>
> How often have these conversations led to bad results, and even caused people to fall in love, and have led some to do things that are even more serious than that. The Shaytaan makes each of them imagine attractive qualities in other, which leads them to develop an attachment that [is] detrimental to their spiritual welfare and worldly affairs…

Undoubtedly correspondence via chat rooms is more dangerous than correspondence by mail, but both are bad.[124]

Such private chatting, especially with the advent of online cameras or pictures, is equivalent to an unrelated man and woman being alone together, and this involves one of the greatest causes of temptations for both men and women. The hadith of our beloved Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) is clear in this regard:

«لاَ يَخْلُوَنَّ رَجُلٌ بِامْرَأَةٍ إِلاَّ كَانَ ثَالِثَهُمَا الشَّيْطَانُ.»

«Whenever a man is alone with a woman, the devil is the third.» (Recorded by at-Tirmidhi; authenticated by al-Albâni)[125]

This hadith means that the seclusion of unrelated (non-maḥram) men and women together anywhere, whether in a physical room or in an online chat room, is a guaranteed invitation to Satan. Proximity is the most important predictor of love. Under such circumstances, when unrelated men and women are together in seclusion, temptations are greater. Soon, the carnal desire for the opposite sex overpowers the minds of unrelated men and women who are engaged in conversation. Unfortunately, it is not just single men and women who are suffering from this addiction to chatting with the opposite sex; some married men and women also become the victims of this disease. In addition, many girls in chat rooms suffer from 'cyber-bullying' and sexual innuendos from boys, thus hurting their self-esteem and endangering their sense of shame and modesty.

Muslim girls and women forget that even though they are posting their pictures on Facebook and other social media platforms for their female friends, there are non-related men in the homes of their female friends who may also view these pictures on the same computer. By committing the forbidden act of posting their personal photos on social media, Muslim

women are providing a window of opportunity for non-maḥram men to view their photos. Our respectable Muslim sisters forget the hadith of our beloved Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) when he said:

«المَرْأَةُ عَوْرَةٌ، فَإِذَا خَرَجَتْ اسْتَشْرَفَهَا الشَّيْطَانُ.»

«All of a woman is *'awrah* (the part of a person's body that must be screened from public view). When she leaves her home, Satan looks at her.» (A good hadith recorded by at-Tirmidhi; classified as sound by al-Albâni)[126]

In this hadith, the word 'awrah has been used for women, meaning that all her body is regarded as intimate or private and must be covered with appropriate clothing. When a woman's photos leave her home through social media platforms like Facebook or Instagram or TikTok, there is no doubt that 'Satan looks at her photos' by tempting Muslim and non-Muslim men alike to look at them. In this way, Satan spreads corruption in the society. Some predator men target these women and trap them in their 'web' of deception through the tentacles of the World Wide Web. Consequently, premarital love affairs happen and divorce rates go up. It is precisely for this reason that in February 2010, renowned Islamic scholar Shaykh 'Abdul-Ḥameed al-Aṭrash, former president of the Fatwa Committee at the prestigious Al-Azhar University (Cairo), issued a fatwa (Islamic legal verdict) that the use of social media by Muslims had resulted in the rise of marital infidelity. This fatwa by Shaykh al-Aṭrash came after a study earlier that week which had claimed that one in every five cases of divorces in Egypt had been the result of one of the partners starting to use social media platforms like Facebook or Twitter. Shaykh al-Aṭrash advised Muslims to stay away from such cyber platforms. While Shaykh al-Aṭrash issued this fatwa in Egypt, it is equally applicable to Muslim men and women in every single country. Shaykh al-Aṭrash explained that such sites

are mainly responsible for the growing incidents of marital discords in the country. He states in the fatwa:

> It is an instrument that destroys the family because it encourages spouses to have relations with other people which break Islamic Sharia law… While one or other of the spouses is at work, the other is chatting online with someone else, wasting their time and flouting the Sharia. This endangers the Muslim family.[127]

Muslim youth, online chatting, and the story of Barṣeeṣâ

When girls or women are chatting online with women they have never met, there is no guarantee the person on the other side is actually a female and not a man disguised as a woman. Many men in chat rooms are there to trap women and seduce them through online chatting. John Suler, American writer, researcher, photographer, and Professor of Psychology at Rider University, states that gender switching is very easy on the Internet, providing an opportunity for men to pose as women:

> The beauty, and sometimes misfortune, of the internet is that it offers the opportunity for people to experiment with their identity. One way to do that is to switch one's gender to see how the other half lives. In a text-only chat room the first step is simply to change one's online name.[128]

Suler argues that men have different reasons and motives behind gender switching. One possibility is that he could be disguised as a female, "looking for intimacy, romance, and/or cybersex."[129] A great number of men fake their gender and identities on the Internet, and most of the time,

this urge to impersonate oneself as a female is propelled by ulterior motives. One reader of John Suler's article nicely puts it as follows:

> Lets [sic] face it, the majority of users of the internet are still male, and in such an ambiguous environment as the internet, the ability to lose one's inhibitions is quite strong. With a great many horny computer nerds out there, and no counterpart women on the net, I think some men pretend to be women… because they wish to perpetuate some form of cyber experience. It is as if they are an actor, manipulating the puppet of a woman (just as they might in their own mind, during a sexual fantasy) but in this case, they are sustaining the puppet for some other stranger at the end of another modem to play with.[130]

This is why Islam does not permit illegitimate seclusion of men and women in the society, except in the case of legitimate relationships (such as a man's wife, mother, sister, daughter, or aunts). Islam nips the evil in the bud because moral disasters always have preludes. Islam seeks to eliminate the social situations in which any sort of exploitation of women by men can occur. For example, women can be exploited by men in cyber crimes; Islam tries to protect them by making it forbidden for a man and a woman to speak alone in a chat room. In fact, the scenario of men and women who get closer to each other step-by-step is very similar to the story of Barṣeeṣâ the monk, which will be narrated here. The Qur'an mentions about Satan:

{They are like the Satan when he says to a man: Disbelieve; then when he disbelieves, he says to him: I have nothing to do with you, for verily I fear Allah, the Lord of the worlds.} *(al-Ḥashr 59: 16)*

Explaining the aforementioned verse of the Qur'an, scholars narrate the story of a monk named Barṣeeṣâ who was well known for his worship and piety. Wahb ibn Munabbih narrates:

Barṣeeṣâ was from the children of Israel. He used to live in a temple where he had devoted himself to worship. During his time, three brothers and their sister from the Children of Israel used to live in a nearby town. One day, the three men wanted to go out on an expedition, but they were concerned about their sister and where they should leave her while they were away. Someone advised them that the best person to leave her with was Barṣeeṣâ, the worshipper, because he was considered to be the most righteous person around. They went to Barṣeeṣâ and told him the situation.

He said: I seek refuge in Allah from you; stay away from me.

Then Satan whispered to him: If you will not take care of this young woman, an evil person may take care of her. How can you let this good slip out of your hands?

Satan was encouraging him to do good deeds, so he called the brothers back and said: Alright, I will look after her on one condition; she will not be allowed to stay with me in my monastery. She will have to stay in the home across my temple.

It was decided that she would stay in one room in the house across the monastery, and he would leave food for her on the doorsteps of his temple. She would have to walk to his temple and pick up the food. He did not even want to see her.

Then Satan whispered to him: What are you doing? Do you not know that when she walks out from her room and comes to your temple, people can see her? You have to deliver the food to her doorstep.

Barṣeeṣâ agreed with Satan and started delivering food to the girl's doorstep.

The activity of Barșeeșâ leaving food on the sister's doorstep continued for a while, until Satan whispered into Barșeeșâ's heart: Are you going to leave her alone with nobody to talk to? Go back and chat with her from behind the door to socialize with her, just so she does not feel lonely.

This pious man would speak to her from outside her home, and she would speak from the inside behind the door, and they would scream in order to ensure they were heard.

Satan again whispered into Barșeeșâ's heart: Why do you not make it more convenient for yourself? Instead of screaming and hollering at each other from a distance, why do you not go and sit in the same room and talk to her face-to-face?

Barșeeșâ started sitting with her in the same room and spending time with her; gradually they started spending hours and hours together. The young woman and Barșeeșâ got closer and closer, until one day the great worshipper committed fornication with her. As a result, she became pregnant and delivered a child.

Now Satan whispered to Barșeeșâ: What have you done? Do you know what will happen when the brothers come back? They are going to kill you. Even if you claim he is not your son, they will say to you that you were supposed to take care of her. It was your responsibility. They will not care who the father is. The only solution to this problem is that you murder the child and bury it.

Barșeeșâ chopped off the infant's head and buried him.

Then Satan threatened him: Do you think that the mother will keep the secret after you killed her son? She will tell her brothers. You should kill her too.

Barṣeeṣâ killed her as well, and he buried them both in her room.

When the brothers came back, they asked Barṣeeṣâ: Where is our sister?

He said: She became ill and died, and she is buried in that place.

He went and showed them the fake grave. They made supplication for her and went home.

That night, one of the brothers saw a dream in which Satan came to him and told him: Did you believe Barṣeeṣâ? Did you believe him? He is lying to you. He committed fornication with your sister and then he killed her and her son; the evidence is that she is not buried in the place he showed you; she is buried in her room under the rock.

He woke up and told his brothers about the dream. The other brothers said: We saw the same dream; it must be true.

The next day, they dug the fictitious grave and found nothing. They went into her room, uncovered the earth, and found their sister buried with an infant. They grabbed Barṣeeṣâ and took him to the king to execute him. While they were dragging him to the king, Satan came to Barṣeeṣâ but this time he did not come in the form of inspiration; he appeared in a human form and told him: Barṣeeṣâ, do you know who I am? I am Satan. I am the one who caused all this trouble, and I am the only one who has a solution to save you. It is up to you whether you go and die or you listen to me so that I save you.

Barṣeeṣâ said: Please save me.

He said: Prostrate to me.

Barṣeeṣâ prostrated to Satan. As soon as he did that, Satan ran away, saying: I am free of you; I fear Allah, the Lord of the Worlds.

Barṣeeṣâ prostrated to Satan, and that was the last thing he did in his life because shortly afterwards he was executed.[131]

Barṣeeṣâ was a great worshipper on the righteous path but because he chose the wrong path – even though it appeared very insignificant in the beginning just like one click of a mouse – it ended up in him becoming a disbeliever.

What policy did Satan use with Barṣeeṣâ? If Satan had come to Barṣeeṣâ from the beginning and told him to prostrate to him, he would never have done so because at that point his faith was strong. Satan took a step-by-step approach to attack Barṣeeṣâ's faith until he was at his most vulnerable. It is precisely for this reason that Allah commands us not to follow Satan's footsteps; these footsteps destroy us slowly but surely:

{O you who believe! Enter into Islam whole-heartedly; and do not follow the footsteps of the Satan, for he is to you an avowed enemy.} *(al-Baqarah 2: 208)*

We can easily draw a parallel of online chatting with this real story and many others in the next section of this book. Our young, innocent Muslim sisters in chat rooms or who have posted their photos on Facebook or Instagram or TikTok are similar to the young woman who was left by her brothers in the home across Barṣeeṣâ's temple. All non-maḥram men in chat rooms or on Facebook are similar to Barṣeeṣâ, even if a Muslim brother says he wants to learn about or discuss Islam from a sister in a chat room. These 'pious' men are inspired by Satan to use the most powerful weapon against girls and young women – the weapon of flattery and sweet talk in order to socialize with them so that they do not feel lonely. Then Satan inspires such Muslim men and women to exchange and share photos with each other; then they start texting each other. Then Satan inspires both Muslim men and women to talk to each other on cell phones and then via

Zoom or WhatsApp so that they can see each other live. Then Satan inspires them to have a face-to-face meeting so that they can have a better understanding of each other, and finally, they fall into the same sin as Barṣeeṣâ and the young woman fell into. These Barṣeeṣâ-type men have a lot of patience to seek potential partners, and they wait patiently to cultivate a relationship with a Muslim girl – a relationship that is built on a false sense of trust and loyalty. Such men will do whatever a girl or woman needs them to do in order to gain her trust. Muslim men must also realize that they will end up in the position of Barṣeeṣâ if they are involved in online relationships, and Barṣeeṣâ's end was even worse than the young woman's in the story. She was murdered, yes, but Barṣeeṣâ lost both his life and his faith after prostrating to Satan. Hence, it is not just Muslim women who suffer from the step-by-step invitation of Satan; Muslim men may suffer even worse consequences because Allah mentions in the Qur'an:

{Indeed, the vengeance of your Lord is severe.} *(al-Burooj 85: 12)*

Muslim girls and young women must never trust non-maḥram men – anyone, anytime, anywhere. Non-maḥram men try to interact with innocent Muslim sisters online only to seduce them and rob them of their innocence, honour, and modesty. These men are the online versions of Barṣeeṣâ. Welcome to the digital age, and remember this advice: beware of Barṣeeṣâ on social media.

The dangers of Facebook and online chatting are real

Social media is the passion of modern-day youth. They cannot imagine life without them. Some of them feel it obligatory to post every single action they do in their everyday life on their Facebook page, or on whatever online networking profile they have. Their posts on social media platforms are:

> ...part diary, part photo album, with gossip, favourite music, pet peeves – sometimes even phone numbers and home addresses. Also occasionally, revealing pictures.[132]

Olivia Walker, a California high school youth who regularly logs on to MySpace.com told Pete Williams, a Justice correspondent to NBC News:

> It is a way for them to instant-message or learn something more about somebody they did not know previously. You can create relationships on MySpace or you can create friendships.[133]

Andrew Crede, a junior at Newton North High School in Boston, said about MySpace, "Pretty much most of the kids in my school use MySpace. You put pictures up, you meet girls. You meet guys."[134]

However, as Pete Williams points out, the trouble is that these popular websites are not just searched by young people. Potential sexual predators are also searching for victims on these websites. For instance, police in Connecticut (USA) arrested a twenty-one-year-old man who met a fourteen-year-old girl on MySpace and later asked her to meet in person. When she met him, he raped her.

Similarly, police in Long Island, New York arrested another man who somehow got hold of the work address of a sixteen-year-old girl on a social media platform. When she met him upon his request, he lured her to a nearby parking lot and sexually assaulted her.[135]

Concerns by law enforcement officials are echoed worldwide, and these crimes are happening globally. In the Philippines, for instance, online child sexual abuse and exploitation are common. Leonarda Kling, Jakarta-based regional representative for Terre des Hommes Netherlands, a non-profit organization working on trafficking issues, notes:

In the Philippines, this is the tip of the iceberg. It's not only Facebook and social media, but it's also through text messages ... especially young, vulnerable people are being targeted. It's all about promises. Better jobs or maybe even a nice telephone or whatever. Young people now, you see all the glamour and glitter around you and they want to have the latest BlackBerry, the latest fashion, and it's also a way to get these things.[136]

The obsession of youth with electronics, media, and social media is bearing bitter fruits everywhere, in Muslim and non-Muslim countries alike. According to websites that track social media (such as socialmediatoday.com, eBizMBA.com, and Technorati.com), as of 2012, Indonesia had about 50 million people signed up for Facebook, making it one of the world's top users after the USA. Semiocast, a social media monitoring company based in Paris, named Jakarta (Indonesia's capital) as the most active Twitter city. Muslim youth are certainly following the footsteps of non-Muslim youth, inch by inch, handspan by handspan. This phenomenon really reminds us of the following hadith narrated by Abu Sa'eed al-Khudri:

قَالَ رَسُولُ اللهِ صَلَّى اللهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ: «لَتَتَّبِعُنَّ سَنَنَ الَّذِينَ مِنْ قَبْلِكُمْ، شِبْرًا بِشِبْرٍ وَذِرَاعًا بِذِرَاعٍ، حَتَّى لَوْ دَخَلُوا فِي جُحْرِ ضَبٍّ لَاتَّبَعْتُمُوهُمْ» قُلْنَا: يَا رَسُولَ اللهِ آلْيَهُودَ وَالنَّصَارَى؟ قَالَ: «فَمَنْ».

«Allah's Messenger (bpuh) said: You will surely follow the ways of those before you, inch by inch and step by step, so much so that if they were to enter a sand lizard's hole, you would follow them.

The Companions asked: O Messenger of Allah, (do you mean) the Jews and the Christians? He replied: Who else?» (Muslim)[137]

In 2012 alone, Indonesia's National Commission for Child Protection reported that one-fourth of the 129 reported missing children and teenagers had been abducted after they met their captors on Facebook. One of those teenage girls was found dead after being raped. The group's chairman Arist Merdeka Sirait lamented on the mania of Muslim youth for electronic media and said:

> We are racing against time, and the technology frenzy over Facebook is a trend among teenagers here. Police should move faster, or many more girls will become victims.[138]

The following are just a few examples from the internationally publicized cases of crimes committed using online chatting and social media platforms like Facebook:

-1-

Ashleigh Hall was a seventeen-year-old bright and charming college student from Darlington, UK. In her spare time, she loved to go online and use Facebook. She had many friends on Facebook, and things seemed to be normal until October 25, 2009, when Ashleigh was raped and murdered by a thirty-three-year-old man she had met online. The murderer, also known as the 'Facebook killer', was Peter Chapman from UK; he posed as a teenager on his Facebook page, where Ashleigh and Chapman first met each other. In his Facebook profile picture, Chapman posed as an attractive, bare-chested, nineteen-year-old young man. Ashleigh was impressed by this picture, and she did not know that, in reality, the person behind it was a wolf in grandmother's clothing – very similar to the story of Little Red Riding Hood. Impressed by Peter Chapman's flattering text messages, Ashleigh quickly became his friend. Within a month, Chapman was able to convince Ashleigh to have a face-to-face meeting. In order to lure her into

his car, Chapman sent her a text message saying his father would pick her up. Once she was in the car, he attacked her. According to the news report the following Monday:

> Ashleigh's body was found dumped in a farmer's field near Sedgefield County, Durham, in October. Her arms were bound and tape was put over her face, suffocating her to death.[139]

According to the prosecution, when she met Chapman on October 25, 2009, he kidnapped, raped, and murdered her. Detective Inspector Mick Callan, head of Durham police's major crime team, gave the following remarks about this agonizing incident:

> The truth is he [Chapman] is a predatory sex offender who, through the tentacles of the internet, could reach out to the young and the vulnerable.
>
> He knows full well that using his real name and picture would not grab the attention of any young woman for a moment. But by using the picture of a good-looking young man as a cover he has woven a web of attraction and deceit that has sadly had a murderous ending.[140]

Peter Chapman was found guilty of teenager Ashleigh Hall's kidnapping, rape, and murder, and sentenced to thirty-five years in prison. However, the damage caused to Ashleigh's family is permanent. Ashleigh's mother Andrea was in the court with her father when the judge read Peter Chapman's sentence. It was excruciatingly painful for her to hear that her bright, bubbly daughter's murderer was not getting the death sentence and instead only life imprisonment.

While talking to UK's *Daily Mail* correspondent Frances Hardy, Andrea recollected that her daughter had never lied to her before this incident.

Andrea states, “We always knew where Ashleigh was; she was reliable… It was out of character for her to lie.”[141]

However, in this instance, Ashleigh lied to her mother and asked her if she could go to her college friend Kristy’s house for a sleepover. Ashleigh’s mother agreed on the condition that she would return by 10:30 the next morning. However, she did not return by the next morning. By that time, Chapman had already raped her, suffocated her to death, and then dumped her dead body in a ditch in a remote area.

Why did Ashleigh lie to her mother about her meeting with Chapman? Chapman used the same tactic that is used by any man trying to hunt for a girl or a woman online: the timeless art of flattery. He sweet talked Ashleigh to blind her to the truth and seduce her. Ashleigh’s mother said, “He groomed her... He told her she was lovely, funny and pretty.”[142]

It was Andrea’s dad, Ashleigh’s grandfather, who went with the police on Tuesday night to identify Ashleigh’s dead body; Andrea was so grief-stricken she could not walk. She felt as if her life had ended. It seems that visions of Ashleigh’s death will be haunting her distraught mother for the rest of her life. Often when she goes to sleep, she has nightmares about her daughter, and she wakes up:

> As soon as I shut my eyes I see Ashleigh’s body in that ditch. I hear her scream. I see her struggle. And I see Chapman, too.[143]

-2-

A fourteen-year-old girl from Depok, a city in Indonesia, was a good student in her high school. She was an avid user of Facebook, where she regularly accepted friendship requests from people of her age group. She

uploaded her photos on Facebook and enjoyed sharing them with her friends. She also conversed with her many friends through private messaging.

On October 29, 2012, this young girl met the correspondents of Associated Press and gave them an interview about her recent kidnapping and repeated rape by a sexual predator whom she had met on Facebook. When she received a Facebook friendship request from a stranger, she accepted it just to check him out. She was a high school student and was very quickly lovestruck by the man's flattery. Soon they exchanged phone numbers, which were followed by text messages. The man then requested her to meet him in a mall. The girl lied to her mother and told her that she was going to visit her sick girlfriend on her way to church choir practice. Instead, she met the man who was a twenty-year-old, handsome, charming male named Yogi. She climbed into Yogi's minivan, and he drove her an hour away to the town of Bogor, West Java and then locked her in a small room inside a house with five other girls, aged 14 to 17. This man – who was so sociable and likeable on Facebook, so friendly in text messages, and so pleasant on the phone – drugged and repeatedly raped the young girl for seven days. She was given sleeping pills and was mostly unconscious while she was there.

Finally, after a week of torture, Yogi told her that he would be selling her and sending her to the island of Batam, which is known for its prostitution clubs, visited by men coming on boats from Singapore. Fortunately, the man did not have enough money to buy a plane ticket to Batam, and he found out that the girl's parents were aggressively searching for her. He dumped her at a bus station, at which point she was able to escape.

This tall, slim girl with shoulder-length black hair was wearing a mask to hide her face as she was interviewed by Associated Press. She told the

news correspondent in the interview:

> He wanted to buy new clothes for me, and help with school payments. He was different...I have a lot of contacts through Facebook, and I've also exchanged phone numbers. However, everything has always gone fine. We were just friends…I am angry and cannot accept what he did to me…I was raped and beaten![144]

The problem is that although increasing the number of contacts on Facebook may be gratifying for the youth, it also exponentially increases their risk of becoming victims of crimes. Cyber Education Consultant Lori Getz notes:

> Our kids are enamoured with being 'famo,' or Internet-famous. The more friends they have online, the more popular they seem to think they are. But this just isn't so. The truth is, the more online friends they have, the bigger the target on their back.[145]

To this day, police have not found the man who kidnapped the young girl from Depok, and it is not clear what happened to the other five girls who were held captive along with her. She painfully recalls:

> I saw they were offered by my kidnapper to many guys. I don't know what happened. I don't want to remember it.[146]

-3-

David Russell, aged twenty, worked at McDonald's in UK. However, that was not the identity he disclosed whenever he went online. On his Facebook account, Russell portrayed himself as the famous singer Oliver Sykes, who sang "Bring Me the Horizon." Russell's attractive Facebook profile as a celebrity was enough to seduce a young woman from California

named Maricar Benedicto, aged nineteen, who met him on Facebook and immediately befriended him. After meeting on Facebook, Benedicto started video chatting with Russell using Skype.

Benedicto trusted him so much that she flew all the way from California to Great Britain. Prosecuting attorney Christopher Donnellan, QC informed the judge that:

> ...the day before Miss Benedicto arrived from California last April, Russell had searched the Internet for 'how to kill someone with bare hands,' 'how to cut skin with a knife' and 'the best knife to kill'.[147]

After Benedicto arrived at the British town's railway station, Russell gave her a warm and loving welcome. Then he took her for a walk to the nearby forest. There he asked his beloved Benedicto to sit down on a fallen tree trunk and told her he was going to blindfold her because he had a special present for her. The next thing Benedicto knew, someone was trying to slit her throat. Attorney Donnellan told the court that as Russell did this, he shouted at Benedicto, "Why won't you die? You've ruined my life. It's all your fault."[148]

At that point, the blindfold fell, and she began to run away, but he caught her and stabbed her in the back with a serrated breadknife. Russell stopped the attacks only when Benedicto told him she had given his name and address to the British immigration officers upon her arrival in UK. Upon hearing this, Russell ran home and hid himself. Russell has been sentenced to life imprisonment for the kidnapping and attempted murder of the American girl. Benedicto survived the incident with heavy wounds, but the psychological trauma of this incident may have ruined the rest of her life, and she may never recover from it. It all started with just one click of a mouse on the computer.

Twenty-seven-year-old Christian Grotheer would portray himself online as a wholesome, normal man who loved writing poetry. The same Christian Grotheer from Germany confessed in 2009 that he murdered women he met in online chat rooms. Grotheer was nicknamed "Germany's first internet murderer" by the German press and law enforcement officials. He used the screen name 'Rosenboy' in online chat rooms. Grotheer had spent years chatting online in order to trap women with whom he hoped to have casual sex. Grotheer admitted in the court that he flirted with more than 300 women online and met many of them in person, two of whom he killed and one of whom was stabbed twenty-six times with a knife. Christian Grotheer is now serving a life sentence in jail for killing women he met on online dating websites and in chat rooms.[149]

Grotheer told the prosecutors that he chatted online with one woman, a Jessica K., and afterwards, he met her in her hometown of Stade near Hamburg in early June, 2008. He related that he was planning to make love with her "in the open air". At some point during their meeting, they had a quarrel, and Grotheer killed her with a knife. Prosecutors informed the judge that forensic scientists had later found traces of Jessica's blood on Grotheer's shoes. The police found Jessica's body, partially decomposed, two weeks after her death.

Grotheer also killed his second chat room date Regina B., a thirty-nine-year-old mother of three children. Grotheer had sex with her, and a few days later, the mother of three demanded that he pay her 500 pounds. When Grotheer refused, Regina called him a rapist and threatened that she would file rape charges against him. Grotheer took her for a walk and stabbed her with a knife at least twenty-six times, after which he dumped her dead body in a secluded area.

Grotheer told the judge in a written statement that for many years he used to spend most of his free time visiting online chat rooms. He states:

> Over the years, I built up at least 300 contacts through these chat rooms. I met at least a hundred, if not a hundred and fifty, of these women personally. I spent the whole night in these forums…[150]

The charming way Grotheer portrayed himself in the online world must have been very attractive to many women who met him online. However, his real face was very different from his online chatting profile – another wolf disguised in human clothing. In reality, he was so brutal that he did not even show mercy for a thirty-nine-year-old woman who was a mother of three children, forever leaving those children without a mother.

-5-

Thomas Montgomery was a forty-six-year-old married man and the father of two daughters. He had a loving wife Cindy, and he loved his wife and his daughters very much. Life was going smoothly for them until one day Montgomery began an online relationship with an eighteen-year-old girl who called herself Jessi. Montgomery had posed as a young, handsome, Iraq-bound Marine in his online profile.

One day, in May 2005, he entered a teen chat room with this profile, where he met Jessi, who started instant-messaging him. It started with flirtation by Jessi, as Montgomery recalled later, "I kept thinking, well, we're never going to meet...I'll just play the game with her."[151] However, it soon became a romance, and it was hard for Montgomery to back off. Jessi sent Montgomery her photos which were, indeed, the photos of a teenage, blonde girl. Jessi was also curious about what Montgomery looked

like so he sent Jessi his picture that was thirty years old from a Marine boot camp he had attended. They spent a lot of time chatting online on Pogo, MySpace, and Yahoo. The truth is that both of them were deceiving each other about their ages, as will be shown later in this book. Jessi herself was a middle-aged woman, and she was using her teenage daughter's photos in her online profile.

Montgomery started spending hours and hours in the evenings in front of his computer, which frustrated his wife Cindy. Sometimes he would even push his daughters, aged twelve and fourteen, away from the computer so that he could play online all night.

One day, one of Montgomery's daughters accidentally discovered that her father was having an online relationship with a woman named Jessi. When Cindy checked Montgomery's computer, she found hundreds of online photos, love letters, and instant messages between her husband and Jessi. Cindy was enraged to learn that Jessi was about the same age as her two daughters. Later, Cindy found some mail sent by Jessi to Montgomery. There was provocative clothing in it, including underwear from this young woman. Cindy wrote a letter to Jessi and included a family picture in it. She wrote in the letter, "Let me introduce you to these people. The man in the center is Tom, my husband since 1989. ...He is 46 years old."[152]

As a mature woman, Cindy advised Jessi in a letter to her:

> From what I am pulling from your letters you are much closer to [my daughter's] age than mine let alone Tom's. Are you over the age of 18? In this alone, he can be prosecuted as a child predator.[153]

Cindy had a heated argument with her husband Montgomery when he returned home. She told him they should separate immediately. Montgomery moved to the basement of their home. He had been telling his

co-workers about his online affair ever since it started. Now he began telling his co-workers that he was going to leave his wife and move to West Virginia to be with the love of his life. In a note to himself, he penned his New Year's resolution as follows:

> On January 2, 2006 Tom Montgomery (46 years old) ceases to exist and is replaced by a [sic] 18-year old battle-scarred marine ... He is moving to West Virginia to be with the love of his life.[154]

After learning about Montgomery's deception through his wife's interception, Jessi decided to break up with him. Next, Jessi looked at Montgomery's friends list at Pogo.com to inform them about this breakup. There she found Brian Barret, a twenty-two-year-old workmate of Montgomery. Barrett had learned about Jessi because of Montgomery's frequent boasting about his online affair with her. Barrett comforted Jessi regarding what Montgomery did to her, and a new online affair started between Barrett and Jessi, with the two of them telling everyone in their chat room that Montgomery was a liar. When Montgomery learnt about this affair, he became jealous. He was so furious that he followed Barrett to the parking lot of their workplace in Buffalo, New York. It was Friday night, September 15, 2006, when Barrett finished his night shift at 10:00 p.m. As soon as Barrett sat in his car in the parking lot to drive home, Montgomery shot him in the arm and neck using a .30-caliber rifle. Barrett died immediately, but his dead body was discovered two days later by a passing co-worker. Montgomery fled the crime scene but detectives were able to find evidence at the crime scene and on Montgomery's computer, which led them to arrest him. Judge Wolfgang sentenced Montgomery to twenty years in prison, plus five years of post-release supervision. Montgomery tried committing suicide in prison after his wife divorced him, and he received letters from his daughters telling him that they no longer wanted to visit him.[155]

During the course of the investigation, it was discovered that 'Jessi' was not an eighteen-year-old blond girl, as she had shown in her online profile pictures. Detective Lieutenant Ron Kenyon found Jessi's phone number from Barrett's cell phone. He contacted her and told her that she should get ready for questioning. Of course, she sounded like an eighteen-year-old girl on the phone. However, when Kenyon drove to West Virginia to see the truth himself, he was surprised to find out that the woman with the screen name 'Jessi' was actually a "45-year-old married mother of two with short brown hair." Her real name was Mary Shieler, and she was married to her husband for twenty-three years. New York prosecutors wanted to charge her for destroying so many lives but the court concluded that "she may have tramped all over the moral and ethical line, but never crossed the legal one."[156]

Mary Shieler escaped legal punishment, but could not escape the repercussions of her crime in her personal life. When her husband found out about her cheating on him, he divorced Mary. Also, her daughter Jessi (the actual Jessi whose name and age Mary had used online) severed ties with her and moved in with her relatives in Virginia.

Facebook, online chatting, and the deception of young age

Social media platforms and online chatting sites are the passion of modern-day youth. However, by spending every spare second on online sites, many young people lose their lives, their honour, or both, at the hands of Internet predators. Cyber criminals, online wolves, paedophiles, Facebook killers, Internet killers, and chat room killers all have one thing in common – they use the agents of Dajjâl to seek out victims. These criminals and predators use various Internet forums including, but not limited to, chat rooms, social

media, online dating services, and online role-playing games for their own evil agendas. These online sites are helpless when it comes to exposing people with fake online identities. For instance, Netlog, a Belgian social networking website, which claims 56 million users across Europe, openly admitted that "there was currently no 100 percent failsafe way of confirming someone's identity online."[157]

Dr. Maurice Godwin, a forensic science expert and law enforcement consultant to families of missing and murdered persons, explains that people with the intent to exploit others online rely on the Mardi Gras effect which, according to American psychologists, means the ability to hide one's identity on the Internet. Such people use the Internet to lure, rape, and murder the victims they meet online. Dr. Godwin states:

> In the dark and secretive world of cyberspace, there are individuals seeking to experience weird adventures. Hidden in the cloak of their on-line screen names, some offer to sell their used underwear while others are looking for potential victims to stalk and murder...
>
> No one needs to use their real name if they don't want to, and most don't. Instead, participants choose one or more handles by which they are known. This handle is their mask.
>
> Chat rooms and IRC [Internet relay chat] operate in real time with messages posted and responded to instantly for all participants to see. Private chat rooms can also be arranged. Handles are used here also. This anonymity allows chat room and newsgroup visitors to take on the persona of whomever they wish. It provides the perfect venue for deceit.[158]

In all the stories and incidents discussed in the previous section, we have seen again and again this Mardi Gras effect upon online users. This is

especially true in the case of Internet chat rooms and social media, all of which allow predators and deceivers to present an illusion of youth and innocence to others. People who are in chat rooms or on social media with people they have never met are so spellbound by the medium that they almost always make an error in judgement when it comes to accurately determining the age of the person on the other side of the computer. A quick look at the stories and cases discussed in the previous section will elucidate this point:

- In the story of Ashleigh Hall, her murderer Peter Chapman was a thirty-three-year-old man who had lost most of his teeth, had personal hygiene problems, and was living in his car for the last few months before he was caught. Nevertheless, he succeeded in portraying himself as a nineteen-year-old bare-chested youth.[159] All he did was use a picture of a shirtless seventeen-year-old young man with a cool name 'DJ Pete'. This youthful picture was attractive enough to have 14,600 online visitors, 3,000 of which were females aged 13-31 who became his online 'friends'. After befriending females online, Chapman would try to redirect the girls to private chat rooms where he would persuade them to talk about intimate matters. Some girls even sent him pictures of themselves posing in underwear or pyjamas. Chapman had set up two profiles on Netlog and at least nine on other sites when he was arrested for Ashleigh's murder. According to *The Telegraph* (UK) correspondent Paul Stokes, on the social networking site Faces.com, Chapman "had 3,919 visitors and described himself as single, 5 feet 10 inches tall, with blue eyes and a 'slim, toned' body, a window maker whose interests were 'cars, girls hehe.'"[160]
- The young girl from Depok, Indonesia, used to accept friendship requests from people of her age group, or so she thought. When she befriended Yogi on Facebook, the man seemed very charming based on

his Facebook profile and his smooth talk over the phone, but in reality he was a monster who repeatedly raped her for seven days without having any mercy on her. Why did she believe the Facebook profile of Yogi and that he was a sociable and charming young man? It was because the online profile of young Yogi on Facebook was too attractive to alert the girl to his real face as a serial rapist and trafficker.

- In the case of David Russell, Benedicto eventually found out that Russell used a fake profile on Facebook, displaying himself as the famous singer Oliver Sykes. Despite that, she was so spellbound by this 'one-eyed' medium that she still decided to fly from USA to UK to meet him in person. To her disappointment, Russell was not as charming and friendly as he appeared on Facebook and Skype; he attempted to murder Benedicto after taking her into the wilderness.
- Grotheer portrayed himself on the Internet as someone who loved poetry to make others believe that he was a very gentle and sensitive person. As often happens in the digital world, he used an attention-seeking screen name 'Rosenboy' in online chat rooms. Grotheer's online profile appeared very attractive to many women, to the extent that he was able to flirt with more than 300 of them. Again, it was the online spell that caused many women to believe that Grotheer was a soft-hearted young man looking for a female companion. However, in reality, Grotheer was so brutal that he failed to feel any mercy over murdering a woman who was a mother of three children.
- Thomas Montgomery was a loving father and husband. However, one click of a mouse sucked him into the quagmire of a love affair with a girl supposedly his daughters' age. In order to win her heart, Montgomery portrayed himself as a young Iraq-bound marine. Both of them believed each other that they were young and attractive, but in reality, 'Jessi' was a forty-five-year-old mother of two, while Montgomery was a forty-five-year-old father of two. The saddest part

of the story is that twenty-two-year-old Brian Barrett became the victim of this 'bizarre love triangle'. He was killed "by a man pretending to be someone he was not, obsessed with a woman pretending to be someone she was not."[161] It seems that everyone in this online love triangle was deceiving each other.

The Internet provides people with a very easy forum to deceive others into thinking they are younger through pictures, speech and slang, and falsified profile information. It becomes incredibly difficult for the person on the other side of this deceit to see through the façade. The 'one-eyed' computer screen of the Internet facilitates the environment for evil-intentioned people who have ulterior motives to give an illusion of young age to innocent people. In online relationships and friendships, people are often either deceiving or being deceived by others. They present themselves as very young, and their online partner on the other end of the screen believes them. When their lies are exposed, it is often already too late. The word for this deception in Arabic is dajjel. These electronic agents of Dajjâl, the great deceiver, deceive people and, in turn, allow people to deceive each other. Human beings have a weak desire to stay young forever. People love young age, and Satan is well aware of this human weakness, as the Qur'an notes:

{Then Satan whispered to him, saying: O Adam, shall I show you the tree of immortality and a dominion that will never decay?} *(Ṭâ Hâ 20: 120)*

Chapter 5: Muslim Youth and Peer Pressure

Different factors contribute to the personality development of every person. The genetically inherited physical and mental capabilities that human beings possess are part of the hereditary factors that contribute to personality development. In addition, many potential environmental influences and interactions with the particular social environment in which people live also play a major role in moulding their personalities. In his book *On the Sociology of Islam* twentieth-century sociologist Dr. Ali Shariati observes that in general five major external factors shape the personality of a person:

- The first factor is the mother, who builds the structure and dimensions of her child's spiritual form.
- The second factor in shaping the personality is the father, who constructs the remaining dimensions of the spirit of the child, after the mother.
- The third factor that builds the outer and apparent dimensions of individuals is school and education.
- The fourth educative factor that moulds the personality is society and environment. If the environment is stronger and more powerful, its

instructive effect upon the individual will be greater.

- The fifth educative factor consists of the prevalent culture of the society or of the world as a whole.[162]

We can see that out of the five factors, three are located outside the home and, hence, are under the direct influence of Dajjâl's agents. The sad part is that today, with the advent of modern technology, the one-eyed agents of Dajjâl can easily penetrate any house in the guise of television, cable, satellite dish, Internet, or smartphones, and in doing so, they can corrupt our modern youth. The youth of today are going through a critical period where they are searching for meaning in their lives, but the agents of Dajjâl are deceiving them and robbing them of their innocence. Muslim youth are distracted from their actual goals in life through various tactics, some of which will be discussed in this as well as the next few chapters.

Muslim youth and the effects of coeducation

One of the major challenges faced by Muslim youth in this age of Dajjâl is coeducation. Although the methodology of coeducation is foreign to Islam, it is practiced in most Muslim countries today because it is a historical remnant of the European colonialism of Muslim lands. Before the colonization of Muslim lands, Islamic institutions separated students of the opposite sex up to the highest levels of schooling. However, when the European imperialists arrived in Muslim lands, they completely dismantled the Islamic educational system and forced their own educational system down the throats of Muslims. Later, Muslim societies became desensitized and familiar with this system, and they retained the coeducational system in their countries even after the colonialists left.

Coeducation is highly destructive to the youth for a few different reasons. Young people are frequently distracted by the presence of the opposite sex in mixed-gender schools. Adolescence is a period of great distress, and there is a surge of sex hormones in the bodies of teenage boys and girls, making it hard for them to concentrate on studies. Teenage boys suffer from aggression while girls suffer from depression under the influence of sex hormones. If adolescents going through this period of hormonal distress are sitting in the same classroom with members of the opposite sex, one can imagine the disastrous consequences, as American writer and economist George Gilder notes:

> Classrooms become an intensely sexual arena, where girls and boys perform for the attention of the other sex and where unintellectual, males quickly come to view schoolbooks as a menace to manhood.[163]

Dr. Leonard Sax, educational expert, physician, psychologist, and founder and director of the National Association for Single Sex Public Education, argues that since boys mature much later than girls, they can be easily "turned off" if they start their learning alongside female classmates. Similarly, Dr. Sax notes that girls also achieve maximum benefit from education if they are taught in single-sex schools and classrooms because they are more free to concentrate on subjects such as science and engineering, which are traditionally seen as 'male' subjects.[164]

Various studies have clearly demonstrated that girls and boys at single-sex schools do better in exams than their peers in mixed-gender schools.[165] This is so because boys and girls mature at different times during their development. Boys need strict discipline and a challenging environment in their schools and colleges, whereas girls do better in a friendly environment with minimal supervision. In addition, Cornelius Riordan, sociologist from Providence College, Rhode Island, found in his studies that when girls are

removed from the competitive environment of co-ed schools and placed in a single-sex school, they experience positive self-esteem, not only in the areas of academics and athletics but also about their self-perception.[166] Conversely, a classroom containing boys and girls will hurt both.

Worst of all, girls suffer from sexual harassment in co-ed schools, which hurts their self-esteem and self-confidence when it comes to learning. In a 1993 study conducted by the American Association of University Women (AAUW), in conjunction with Harris Interactive, 76 percent of girls reported that they had been the target of "sexual comments, jokes, gestures, or looks" from the boys at their co-ed school, and one high school girl out of every four experienced forced kissing. About 15 percent of the girls reported having their clothes pulled off by male students, and 18 percent reported that some sexual harassment was done by the adult males at their schools.[167] The findings of this huge study were also confirmed by another survey conducted on school-age girls by researchers at Wellesley College in Massachusetts. They found that about 40 percent of the girls reported that they were sexually harassed daily, and another 29 percent said they were harassed weekly. More than two-thirds said the harassment occurred in the view of other people. Almost 90 percent were the target of unwanted sexual comments or gestures.[168]

The end result of such sexual harassment faced by girls in coeducational schools is their reduced interest in continuing their school or college education. The AAUW report stated, "Nearly 1 in 4 students (23%) who have been sexually harassed say that one outcome of the experience is not wanting to attend school."[169] It must be noted here that in Islamic societies, where chastity and modesty are emphasized for both girls and boys, the impact of such sexual harassment on Muslim girls and women

would be more severe, which could result in even more school-refusers among Muslim girls.

The list of negative effects caused by coeducation does not end there. When young men and women are placed in the same classroom or in the same school, the end result is flirting, dating, love affairs, and courtships. Many youth become the victims of coeducation and engage in premarital sex because of the temptation of the opposite sex within their reach. Due to the easier accessibility to members of the opposite sex in a coeducational environment, there is a high rate of teenage pregnancies in coeducational institutions. Peer pressure regarding friendship with classmates of the opposite sex plays a major role here as Kristen Hartman, a social worker and graduate of Providence College, notes:

> Peer pressure surrounding sex is a great deal more influential in co-ed school environments because boys and girls coexist in the same social network, which gives girls less control. Once one couple in their circle of friends starts becoming sexually active, they all do because they are all intermixed and feel pressure to live up to that standard…
>
> Girls at single-sex schools have more control in their relationships and are often more confident in the fact that they are worthy with or without a boyfriend.[170]

In order to reduce the risk of temptation, Islam does not permit free intermingling of sexes past the age of puberty. Islam's basic requirement from young men and women is to maintain the purity of their sexual lives from the very beginning. Muslim youth are specifically asked to keep a safe distance from the opposite sex for their benefit. Also, Islam is acutely aware of the differences between males and females in terms of their psychological development. Due to psychobiological as well as emotional differences between the two genders, the developmental and learning

patterns are different in the two sexes throughout their lives. Single-sex education is the solution to this problem and the other problems faced through coeducation. A separate-sex educational model has been successfully used in many countries including Australia, Jamaica, Canada, USA, and Saudi Arabia as I have shown in detail in my book *The Hijab: Liberation or Oppression?*[171]

Muslim youth and the effects of secular education

Another major challenge faced by Muslim youth in this age of Dajjâl is the secular educational system, which is implemented in most, if not all, Muslim countries. The secular educational system appeared in Muslim countries during Western imperialism. Neil Postman states:

> Every age has its own special forms of imperialism. And so does each conqueror. In the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, when the British mastered the art, their method of invasion was to send their navy, then their army, then their administrators, and finally their educational system.[172]

According to Neil Postman, once the British established their educational system in the colonized countries, they gave them political freedom. After the colonization of the Muslim countries, the European imperialists completely dismantled the prevailing Islamic educational system in them. As a consequence, two opposing educational systems came into existence in Muslim countries, as Muslim psychologist Dr. Malik Badri asserts:

> This duality of 'religious' and 'secular' educational systems created a serious schism in which the sophisticated highly paid Western educated Muslims looked down upon the graduates of the traditional poorly salaried religious schools.[173]

Apologetic, modernist Muslims are blindly implementing the Western secular model of education in Muslim countries. This Western educational system imposed upon the Muslim countries has a secular worldview instead of a Qur'anic worldview at its very foundation. What is secularism? Secularism refers to the separation of religion from worldly matters. Dutch theologian Cornelis van Peursen, who was once the chair of philosophy at the University of Leiden, defined secularization as the liberation of man "first from religious and then from metaphysical control over his reason and his language." Secularization involves:

> …the loosing of the world from religious and quasi-religious understandings of itself, the dispelling of all closed world views, the breaking of all supernatural myths and sacred symbols… the discovery by man that he has been left with the world on his hands... man turning his attention away from worlds beyond and toward this world and this time.[174]

The Western educational system is based upon a secular worldview. In this worldview, the highest authority is what has reason as its foundation. Since divine revelations are not acquired by humans through reason, it is believed that they have no place in modern science. Scientific methodology regards the presence of a Creator in the physical universe as totally irrelevant and outside the sphere of science.

At the base of the secular educational system are the philosophies of Western secular and atheist scientists and thinkers. Charles Darwin (1809-1882 CE) came forward with his theory of evolution, which became the

foundation of Western science. Darwin's theory of evolution proposed that human beings evolved from apes. We enter life by chance, and we leave life by chance. Karl Marx (1818-1883 CE) came forward with his purely materialistic economic philosophy which culminated in the ideology of communism, in which moral values have no place. Marx wrote that "communism abolishes eternal truths, it abolishes all religion, and all morality, instead of constituting them on a new basis."[175]

Sigmund Freud (1856-1939 CE) further added that the focus of everyone's attention should be sexuality. Freud regarded religion as an illusion and a universal neurosis. In one of his books, he writes:

> One might venture to regard the obsessional neurosis as a pathological counterpart to the formation of a religion, to describe this neurosis as a private religious system, and religion as a universal obsessional neurosis.[176]

Many of these Western atheist thinkers died in misery. Marx died as a stateless person with only eleven people attending his funeral. Freud is regarded as the father of psychoanalysis,[177] yet he made his major discoveries under the influence of cocaine which, at the time, he believed was a cure for a wide range of mental afflictions.[178] Due to cocaine abuse for many years, Freud developed cancer of the mouth. The pain of oral cancer became severe, and Freud asked his doctor Max Schur to kill him. Freud said to him:

> Schur, you remember our 'contract' not to leave me in the lurch when the time had come. Talk it over with Anna [Freud's daughter], and if she thinks it's right, then make an end of it.[179]

High doses of morphine were administered to Freud that resulted in his death on September 23, 1939.[180] Sigmund Freud, who preached that religion was a false illusion and whose thoughts and theories were the basis of modern social sciences for over fifty years (and till today continue to be influential in a more minor capacity), committed suicide in the end.

French philosopher August Comte (1798-1857 CE) is regarded as the founder of modern sociology and positivism, the latter of which evolved into logical positivism (the foundation for atheism). Comte lived and died as a miser and an arrogant and violent person. He became insane during the last part of his life.

German philosopher and thinker Friedrich Nietzsche (1844-1900 CE) came forward with the philosophy of nihilism – that there is no meaningful purpose in life. This philosophy of nihilism had a deep impact on the secular worldview of education in Europe and America. Reflecting on the absence of God and religion from the lives and minds of people in the Western society, Nietzsche wrote in his book *Thus Spoke Zarathustra* that "God is dead."[181] (What Nietzsche meant by this statement was that the influence of God and religion are so drastically decreased in the society that God's influence was affectively 'dead' to the Western society.) However, the reality is that God is still alive, and He will always remain alive. Nietzsche died in 1900 CE after suffering from insanity for the last ten years of his life.

These 'great minds' of Western civilization and flag-bearers of secularism chose to forget their Creator and Lord and hence, Allah made them forget their own selves. In the words of the Qur'an:

{Do not be like those who forgot Allah, so He caused them to forget themselves. It is they who are the evildoers.} *(al-Ḥashr 59: 19)*

Now there is a realization among some Western intellectuals that separating religion and education leads us to a dead-end street. Carl Jung was about to become the successor of Freud in modern psychology, but he broke away from Freud because of serious differences in their philosophies. Later, Jung started his own school of thought, analytical psychology, in which religious beliefs and behaviours are treated in a positive light.

Similarly, notable American psychiatrist Scott Peck mentions in his bestselling book *People of the Lie* that the major reason for the psychological problems of the modern-day man is his complete rejection of any religious consideration in his scientific approach. He writes:

> The major reason for this strange state of affairs is that the scientific and religious models have hitherto been considered totally immiscible – like oil and water, mutually incompatible and rejecting.
>
> In the late seventeenth century, after the Galileo affair proved hurtful to both, science and religion worked out an unwritten social contract of nonrelationship. The world was quite arbitrarily divided into the 'natural' and the 'supernatural'. Religion agreed that the 'natural world' was the sole province of the scientists. And science agreed, in turn, to keep its nose out of the spiritual – or for that matter, anything to do with values. Indeed, science defined itself as 'value-free.'[182]

Likewise, American cardiologist Dr. Herbert Benson has severely criticized the split of religion and science in education as well as in everyday life in the Western world. He states:

> Even when we [as scientists] acquire new information, even when we conquer mysteries, we feel vaguely empty and unfulfilled. And faith is the only long-term solace. In part that is because faith in an Infinite Absolute is the only adequate counterforce to the ultimate facts of

disease and death... That's why I argue that our genetic blueprint has made believing in an Infinite Absolute [Allah] as part of our nature[183]

Here we can see that the understanding of Benson is very close to the Islamic concept of 'inherent nature' on which every child is born, as mentioned in the hadith of our beloved Prophet (bpuh).

Now we will shift our focus to the salient features of an Islamic educational system, which has the Qur'anic worldview as its basis. In the Islamic educational model, Allah has granted human beings the ability to reason with and control some of His creation, but the intellect of human beings has certain limits that they must accept. Only then can nature be used for the benefit of humankind. The Islamic educational model encompasses not only religious sciences, but also physical sciences (physics, chemistry, biology, geology, astronomy, and so on) as well as social sciences (psychology, sociology, anthropology, humanities, and so on) all of which are branches of knowledge for the benefit of humanity. Islam is not merely a packet of certain acts of worship and rituals as found in other religions. Islam as a religion is a complete way of life, as the Qur'an asserts:

{Verily, the true religion before Allah is Islam...} *(Âl 'Imrân 3: 19)*

Worship in Islam refers to all conscious acts of service that are done for the sake of pleasing Allah alone and that are approved by Him (based on the Qur'an and authentic Sunnah of His Messenger [bpuh]). Allah mentions in the Qur'an, in clear terms:

{I have not created the jinn and humans except to worship Me.} *(adh-Dhâriyât 51: 56)*

When Muslim men and women worship and serve Allah in every aspect of their life, they fulfil the purpose of their creation and existence. This

obviously includes seeking education and knowledge, which is an obligation for both men and women. Anas ibn Mâlik reported that Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) said:

«طَلَبُ الْعِلْمِ فَرِيضَةٌ عَلَى كُلِّ مُسْلِمٍ.»

«Seeking knowledge is mandatory for every Muslim (male and female).» (Recorded by Ibn Mâjah; classified as sound by al-Albâni)[184]

Contemporary Muslim philosopher Syed Naquib al-Attas, who chaired the Committee on Aims and Definition of Islamic Education at the First World Conference on Muslim Education held at Makkah in 1977, asserts that the major cause of the decline of Muslims in every aspect of life, including the sphere of education, is the loss of *adab*, that is, "loss of discipline – the discipline of body, mind, and soul," which results in "confusion and error in knowledge." Al-Attas writes:

> Indeed, *ibaadah* [worship] in its entirety is but another expression of adab towards God. Knowledge must be approached reverently and in humility, and it cannot be possessed simply as if it were there available to everyone irrespective of intention and purpose and capacity.[185]

According to al-Attas, the concept of adab should be ingrained in the Islamic educational model. He states:

> The fundamental element inherent in the Islamic concept of education is the inculcation of adab, for it is adab in the all-inclusive sense here meant as encompassing the spiritual and material life of man that instils the quality of goodness that is sought after… Education is the instilling and inculcation of adab in man – it is *ta'dib*.[186]

Since Western science originated as a result of science's revolt against the Church, conjecture and doubt became the basic tools of scientific

enquiry – an educational methodology where there is doubt in everything, even in the existence of a Creator. Al-Attas severely criticizes this secular worldview of education and states:

> …doubt (*shakk*), conjecture and guess (*zunn*), disputation and contention (*jadala*), inclination of the mind and soul towards natural desire (*hawa*), are all generally considered blameworthy – the more so when applied to and masquerading as knowledge.[187]

This is so because the Qur'an clearly mentions:

{Do not pursue [beliefs, rumours, slander and the like] of which you have no certain knowledge, for verily, the hearing, the sight and the heart, all of these will be asked about.} *(al-Isrâ' 17: 36)*

A Muslim scientist's perspective on science and research is completely different from a secular scientist despite the fact that both of them may be following the same steps of scientific experimentation. Dr. Malik Badri describes the thinking process of a Muslim scientist in the following words:

> The spiritually motivated Muslim scientist who strongly believes that ... through hard work, deep contemplation and prayer he will be enlightened with a solution to his problem, is definitely more of a worshipper than someone who is merely praying in a mosque. Indeed, we often forget the value of prayer (salah) and invocation (*du'ā*) in solving our intellectual problems...[188]

To elaborate his point further, Dr. Badri gives the examples of two devoted young Muslim students of physical sciences, who were studying for their M.Sc. and Ph.D. and having a hard time obtaining any positive results in their experiments. Dr. Badri writes about them:

> They would spend long hours in their laboratories working alone and praying to God for a solution. One of them, at the American University of Beirut, used to assemble his apparatus, start the experiment going, then prostrate himself in a very long *sujūd* [prostration] pleading God for a breakthrough, prostrating with his forehead on the bare floor of the lab. Then they were suddenly bestowed with the correct chemical procedures – one of them as an intuition, and the other by a vivid dream in which he received a chemical formula and was told to record it as soon as he woke up from his sleep.[189]

It is optimistic to note that at the university level, some Islamic universities like the Omdurman Islamic University (Sudan), Islamic University of Madinah, Umm Al-Qura University, and Imam Muhammad ibn Saud Islamic University (Saudi Arabia), Al-Azhar University (Egypt), International Islamic University (Pakistan), and International Islamic University (Malaysia) have taken major steps to teach Islamic studies with a more comprehensive and modernized approach. However, the teaching of Islamic studies at the primary and secondary levels in most Muslim countries still needs to be drastically reviewed. Islam is not just a 'religion' in the narrow Western definition of the term. Islam is a complete way of life that governs each and every aspect of our lives. The Qur'an and Sunnah provide us with guidelines in matters as private as our intimate relationships with our spouses and as broad and public as how to run the socio-economic affairs of an Islamic state. For any sincere Muslim willing to serve Islam, the field is open to change the face of Islamic education by Islamizing the secular sciences. This can be done by fully integrating the Islamic worldview into all the subjects of the school curricula. Dr. Badri provides the following suggestion in terms of Islamizing the school curricula, "Each teacher tackling certain areas of Islamic studies within the integrated curriculum of his subject area."[190]

Muslim youth and teenage liberation movement

Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) said the following about one of the signs of the end of times:

«...the slave-girl will give birth to her mistress.» (Muslim)

According to the Islamic scholar ‘Izz ad-Deen ibn ‘Abdus-Salâm, this means the complete inversion of the social order in a society. Daughters are usually the last ones in the home to be disrespectful to their mothers but, as we approach the age of Dajjâl, this will happen. Robert Bly, American author, poet, and activist, mentions that the rock music of the 1950s and 1960s played an important role in the teenage liberation movement. He writes:

> The popular heroes of the late 1950s, James Dean, Elvis Presley, Marilyn Monroe, and Jack Kerouac, all took part in that struggle to loosen everyone up, and were loved for it…[191]

What Robert Bly is stating is correct, but rock music was only one of the factors that contributed to the teenage liberation mentality. The media, which includes television, magazines, billboards, cinema, and Internet, all played their part in providing role models to the youth that influenced them to rebel against their parents and view their parents as stupid or inferior. This is the youth-worshipping culture in which older people have no place. Famous Islamic scholar Maryam Jameelah writes:

> The hatred of the young for everything old (including old people) not because it is bad but just because it is old, has resulted in nothing but chaos, anarchy, disintegration and decadence where not only the bonds

> between the young and old are destroyed but all kinship ties and human relationships in general have been weakened to the breaking point…
>
> In fact, freedom lacking any direction can be a more crushing burden than the most oppressive dictatorship. The absence of transcendental religion, morality and law, far from creating a healthy generation growing straight and tall, is manufacturing whole armies of teen-age delinquents and criminals.[192]

According to sociologists, what the youth call teenage liberation is only liberation from parents and moral values. Otherwise, the teenage youth are engaged in blind following and imitating people of their age or their media role models. Since the youth spend most of their time in schools or colleges, they become shackled in the bonds of peer pressure, both mentally and physically. Sociological evidence suggests that when young people spend more time with their peers than with their parents, they become peer-dependent. They learn the bad habits, manners, and values of the people of their age group. They are negatively socialized and become hostages of social and moral trends. These teenagers have too much liberty, but they have yet to learn responsibility. In the words of Viktor E. Frankl, Austrian neurologist and psychiatrist:

> I recommend that the Statue of Liberty on the East Coast be supplemented by a Statue of Responsibility on the West Coast.[193]

Furthermore, the youth lack the maturity to handle pressure from friends and hence, they are easily influenced by and change their attitudes or behaviours in order to conform to group norms (even though those norms may be deviances in reality). These youth face pressure from their peers to own the newest and most popular in-fashion clothes, shoes, hats, jewellery, or electronics. This pressure even leads some youth into evil practices such as smoking or taking drugs just because their peers are doing it. This

pressure is not limited to material things and may also include possessing or acquiring certain physical attributes in order to become ‘acceptable’ by youth cultural standards. James Coleman, American sociologist, theorist, and empirical researcher, conducted his research on American youth. He notes:

> …our society has created an adolescent subculture that favors physical attractiveness and heterosexual popularity over academic achievement, especially within the schools themselves. The adolescent subculture undermines the attainment of educational goals.[194]

What Coleman is referring to as ‘adolescent subculture’ in his book is in fact the youth culture.

Unfortunately, Muslim youth have also been, directly or indirectly, affected by this phenomenon. If we ask them who Ibn ‘Umar was, or who were the four ‘Abâdillâh[195] in Madinah during the time of the Companions, or who Muṣ‘ab ibn ‘Umayr was, or what the real name of Abu Hurayrah was, they know close to nothing. Similarly, if you ask them about our great Imams like Imam Bukhari, Imam ash-Shâfi‘i, Imam Aḥmad ibn Ḥanbal, or Imam Abu Ḥaneefah, many of them will not even know the full names of these scholars, let alone their biographies. However, when we ask our youth about the lives of celebrities, the clothes they wear, the food they eat, the car, shoes, and even socks they wear, they know all about them, because in this age of Dajjâl, celebrities are glorified in magazines, on news channels, and in movies. Our youth forget that when they purchase these magazines, movies, and other media containing the interviews or photos of media celebrities, they are destroying their hereafter and building the worldly life for the celebrities they admire; this is because celebrities get their share of royalties from every magazine or movie or advertisement for which they sell their bodies or talents.

> Imam Mâlik was once asked by his student Ibn al-Wahb: Who are the worst people?
>
> He replied: Those who sell [lose] their hereafter for the sake of making their worldly life.
>
> When Imam Mâlik was asked if anyone is a bigger loser than those people, he replied: Even bigger losers are those who sell [lose] their life hereafter for the sake of making the worldly life of other people.[196]

Muslim youth and smoking

As illustrated earlier, the tobacco industry spends a huge amount of money on tobacco advertisements targeting the youth. Unfortunately, tobacco advertising and marketing are much more active in Muslim countries due to political instability and dictatorship, leading to lack of regulations for the welfare of the citizens. As a consequence, the youth in some Muslim countries start smoking at increasingly early ages. Smoking is a serious problem facing Muslims of all ages, especially the youth.

Smoking is a major public health problem around the world. According to a report published by the Centers for Disease Control in USA, about 100,000 young people all around the world become addicted to tobacco every day. Sadly enough, the report also states that the majority of people around the world start smoking before they reach the age of 18, and about 25 percent of these smokers actually start smoking before the age of 10. The CDC report also disclosed that around 10 percent of students currently smoke cigarettes, whereas another 10 percent of students currently use tobacco products other than cigarettes (pipes, smokeless tobacco, and so on).[197] We must understand that this data includes not only non-Muslim countries, but Muslim countries as well.

Why is tobacco use and smoking so popular among the youth around the world? The answer is that it all boils down to the relentless efforts spent by tobacco companies in advertising and promoting the benefits of smoking to young people. In 1981, Myron E. Johnston, a researcher at Philip Morris, a global tobacco and cigarette company, noted:

> Today's teenager is tomorrow's potential regular customer, and the overwhelming majority of smokers first begin to smoke while in their teens… It is during the teenage years that the initial brand choice is made.[198]

Tobacco and cigarette companies use skilful marketing techniques to reach young and underage populations. For instance, they advertise "heavily at retail outlets near schools and playgrounds using large ads and signs clearly visible from outside the stores," "placing cigarette ads at children's eye-level," "sponsoring sports with a large youth fan base, such as soccer and cricket," and "advertising near schools using large billboards depicting glamorized images of tobacco use."[199] Marketing and social scientific research clearly demonstrates that tobacco advertising lures young people into the use of tobacco and ensures that they become habitual chain smokers.[200]

In addition to the marketing efforts of tobacco companies, the depiction of smoking in popular music also inspires the youth to adopt smoking. References to tobacco use are found less frequently as compared to alcohol or drugs, but the references are there nonetheless. For instance, here is an example of a song titled "What I Got" (1996) by the alternative rock group Sublime in which a reference to smoking is made:

> *Early in the morning,*
> *Rising to the street,*

Light me up that cigarette,

And strap shoes on my feet.[201]

The reason is clear. Smoking, drugs, and alcohol are part and parcel of the kind of lifestyle adopted by most pop singers and movie stars. In one of the first scientific studies that measured the frequency of tobacco references in popular music, a content analysis of 1,000 of the most popular songs from 1996 to 1997 was performed. It was revealed in this study that three percent of those 1,000 songs mentioned smoking or chewing tobacco, while 64 percent of rap/hip-hop songs contained such references.[202] Sadly enough, smoking is shown more frequently in music videos than in lyrics, and this has an effect on the behaviour of youth because in the case of music videos, they combine both audio and visual mediums, saturating the youth with both visual and audible influences. DuRant and his colleagues found that 30 percent of the characters in rap music videos were shown smoking. In country and R&B music videos, 10 percent of the singers or actors were shown smoking, while 22 percent of the characters were portrayed smoking in rock and adult contemporary music videos, as shown in the table below. The authors of this research state:

> This positive portrayal of tobacco and alcohol use in music videos is likely to have a considerable impact on adolescent's normative expectations and subsequent behaviours.[203]

Table V: References to Smoking in Music/MTV[204]

Type of Music	Prevalence (Percentage)
Rap/hip-hop songs containing references to smoking	64%
Singers in rap music videos	30%

shown smoking	
Singers in country / R&B music videos shown smoking	10%
Singers in rock and adult contemporary music videos shown smoking	22%

It must be noted here that while the practice of smoking is still prevalent in most of the Muslim countries, it has become more and more socially unacceptable to smoke in North America and Western countries in the past five to ten years. As a result, it is becoming less common to see Western musicians smoking in music videos.

The harms of smoking are numerous, and they are supported by well-established medical research today. Medical evidence clearly shows that long-term tobacco use causes different types of cancers and chronic diseases, including lung cancer, stomach cancer, stroke, and coronary heart disease.[205] The resting heart rates of young adult smokers are two to three beats per minute faster as compared to those of non-smokers, and medical studies have shown that the bodies of youth who smoke show early signs of deadly diseases, such as heart disease and stroke.[206] Now, based on the US Surgeon General's 2004 report, there is also sufficient medical evidence to support the fact that smoking causes chronic diseases such as blindness, cataracts, periodontitis, pneumonia, reduced fertility (in women), and asthma.[207]

In addition, for pregnant women, direct smoking and exposure to second-hand smoke causes spontaneous abortions (tobacco-induced miscarriages), stillborn births, ectopic pregnancies, babies with low birth weight, and other pregnancy and delivery problems. Dr. Robert L. Andres, Associate Professor of Obstetrics and Gynaecology at the University of

Utah Health Sciences Center, concludes in his research on pregnant women and their newborns:

> It has been suggested that smoking is responsible for 15% of all preterm births, 20-30% of all infants of low birth weight, and a 150% increase in overall prenatal mortality [sudden infant death syndrome].[208]

In the same vein, Dr. Kirsten Wisborg and other participating scientists conclude in their research:

> Smokers had a 40% higher risk of preterm birth compared with non-smokers. A dose response relationship was found between smoking and risk of preterm birth.[209]

The sad part is that even if a pregnant mother is not smoking, as is usually the case, she can still be the victim of second-hand smoke from her husband, and this inflicts the same amount of harm to the unborn child as if she were smoking herself. Studies show that around 20-50 percent of pregnant women either smoke or are exposed to second-hand smoke.[210] All in all, the tobacco epidemic caused the death of 100 million people in the twentieth century. Currently, 5.4 million people die every year as a result of diseases caused by tobacco use and smoking cigarettes.

The position of Islam on the issue of smoking is clear. The medical evidence against smoking is well-established and sufficient enough to prohibit Muslims from smoking and tobacco use. Islam prohibits Muslim men and women from any action that harms themselves or other people. Allah commands us:

{...And do not kill yourselves [or one another], for verily Allah is Most Merciful to you.} *(an-Nisâ' 4: 29)*

Allah (the Exalted) also commands the believers:

{…and do not contribute to your destruction with your own hands...} *(al-Baqarah 2: 195)*

Similarly, it was narrated on the authority of the Prophet's Companions Ibn 'Abbâs and 'Ubâdah ibn aṣ-Ṣâmit that Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) said:

«لاَ ضَرَرَ وَلاَ ضِرَارَ.»

«No harm may be inflicted on oneself or others.» (Recorded by Aḥmad and Ibn Mâjah; al-Albâni graded it authentic)[211]

The aforementioned hadith also establishes the prohibition of smoking on the grounds that second-hand smoke harms other people around the smoker and can make them contract diseases. It was shown earlier that second-hand smoke not only harms pregnant women, but also harms and sometimes kills the unborn children in their wombs.

Likewise, in another hadith, Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) warned the believers:

«مَنْ تَرَدَّى مِنْ جَبَلٍ فَقَتَلَ نَفْسَهُ، فَهُوَ فِي نَارِ جَهَنَّمَ يَتَرَدَّى فِيهِ خَالِدًا مُخَلَّدًا فِيهَا أَبَدًا، وَمَنْ تَحَسَّى سُمًّا فَقَتَلَ نَفْسَهُ، فَسُمُّهُ فِي يَدِهِ يَتَحَسَّاهُ فِي نَارِ جَهَنَّمَ خَالِدًا مُخَلَّدًا فِيهَا أَبَدًا، وَمَنْ قَتَلَ نَفْسَهُ بِحَدِيدَةٍ، فَحَدِيدَتُهُ فِي يَدِهِ يَجَأُ بِهَا فِي بَطْنِهِ فِي نَارِ جَهَنَّمَ خَالِدًا مُخَلَّدًا فِيهَا أَبَدًا.»

«He who throws himself from a mountain and kills himself will be thrown down in the fire of hell and remain in it for ever and ever; he who sips poison and kills himself will have his poison in his hand and sip it for ever and ever in the fire of hell; and he who kills himself with a piece of iron will have his piece of iron in his hand and will be stabbed with it in his belly in the fire of hell for ever and ever.» (Bukhari and Muslim)

Smoking not only has the potential to kill, but it also involves wasting money which is prohibited in Islam. The Qur'an commands the Muslims:

{Give kinsfolk their due, and those in need, and wayfarers; but do not squander your wealth wastefully. For squanderers are the brothers of the devils. And the Satan [the Devil] is ever ungrateful to his Lord.} *(al-Isrâ' 17: 26-27)*

Muslim governments need to enact laws enforcing a ban on the use of tobacco products. All Muslim youth also need to understand that smoking is forbidden in Islam. Muslim adults must be especially cautious of peer pressure on their children regarding smoking. In a study of 480 young Muslim Arab-Americans, researchers Sondos M. S. Islam and Carl Anderson Johnson observed that twice as many teenage Muslim males as females were "reported to have experimented with cigarettes," whereas peer effect in smoking "was the most significant risk factor associated with both susceptibility and experimentation for both genders."[212] It was also found in this study of Muslim youth that Islamic influences had some effects in diminishing the practice of smoking. Smoking prevention programmes geared towards Muslim youth can become beneficial by incorporating Islamic messages that denounce smoking.

Further evidence that supports this contention is a survey conducted by the physicians at Frontier Medical College, Abbottabad, Pakistan. This study, carried out on 1,000 subjects, explored the influence of Islam on the deterrence of smoking. The study found that 32.5 percent of participants indulged in various kinds of smoking, whereas strict, practicing Muslims tended to avoid smoking. The researchers of the study concluded, "Islam has a positive effect on smoking prevention."[213]

Muslim youth and late marriages

One of the social problems faced by Muslim youth today is the issue of late marriages. As a result of late marriages, Muslim youth sometimes end up

committing grave sins such as courtship, dating, Valentine's Day celebration, masturbation, and watching pornographic movies on television and the Internet. There are various benefits of marriage including:

1. Preserving the human race;
2. Preserving the lineage;
3. Spiritual and psychological serenity;
4. Cooperation between the spouses to build the family and raise children as true believers;
5. Keeping the society free from immorality.

Marriage is a moral safeguard and helps men and women to lower their gaze.

Marital relationship, according to Islam, is a bond of inalienable intimacy. Islam commands its followers to marry as soon as possible after reaching the age of puberty. *(an-Noor 24: 32)* The Qur'an clearly asserts that Allah created the spouses from two sexes to provide them with love, mercy, and tranquillity and this is regarded as one of the signs of Allah:

{Among His signs is this: He created for you from among yourselves spouses, so that you might find comfort in them, and He has instilled love and compassion between you. Verily, in that there are signs for people who reflect.} *(ar-Room 30: 21)*

The biggest factor contributing to this social problem is the negligence of Muslim parents when it comes to encouraging their children to marry. In the Qur'an, Allah clearly commands us:

{Arrange marriages for those among you who are single, and those who are righteous and fit for marriage among your male and female slaves. If they

are poor, Allah will suffice them from His bounty, for Allah is All-Encompassing, All-Knowing.} *(an-Noor 24: 32)*

Marriage is a religious obligation in Islam. It was the practice of all the prophets, as the Qur'an mentions:

{We sent Messengers before you [O Muhammad], and gave them wives and children...} *(ar-Ra'd 13: 38)*

The Qur'an also teaches us the supplication to be made to Allah:

{…let our spouses and children be a source of joy for us, and make us good examples for those who fear You.} *(al-Furqân 25: 74)*

In various hadiths, Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) commanded that Muslims should avoid unnecessary delays in marriages. In one hadith, he said:

«يَا مَعْشَرَ الشَّبَابِ مَنِ اسْتَطَاعَ مِنْكُمُ الْبَاءَةَ فَلْيَتَزَوَّجْ، فَإِنَّهُ أَغَضُّ لِلْبَصَرِ، وَأَحْصَنُ لِلْفَرْجِ.»

«O young people! Whoever among you can marry should marry, for it restrains the eyes (from casting evil glances) and preserves one from immorality.» (Bukhari and Muslim)[214]

Muslim parents do not realize this but they intentionally put their youth at risk by unnecessarily delaying their marriages. There is enough social scientific data to prove a link between single men and high crime rates, mental depression, and early deaths. George Gilder notes that in any society, successful and famous men are those who are married. Only after a man subjects his undefined, immense potential abilities to the creative energies and nurturing qualities of a woman does she channel his abilities in the right direction, allowing him to climb the ladder to success.[215] If men lose their procreating aim, all their potential goes down the drain. Men are

promiscuous by nature, and it is only the institution of marriage that converts their aimless lust and irresponsible sexual behaviour into constructive love and long-term commitment. Marriage creates a sense of responsibility and accountability in men towards their families. It is the love of a wife that tames the barbarian inside a man and makes him a civilized person.[216]

Islam understands that young age is a time of great distress for both males and females. Upon reaching the age of puberty, there is a surge of sex hormones in their bodies. If the marriages of young men and women are delayed, a lot of their creative energies are wasted and their concentrations are diverted to fighting their sexual urges. The best solution is to help those youth marry as this focuses their creative energies in the right direction. We must not pay heed to the modern myth that marriage prevents young men and women from attaining their highest level of education or success. Marriage actually creates a sense of responsibility in the youth and provides the married youth with the necessary concentration of mind to attain the highest education or profession in their societies.

Islam encourages binding men and women in the sacred relationship of marriage. In Islam, marriage is a social commitment. However, today, just the thought of marriage makes us think of all the hassles, stress, and expenses of the wedding ceremony. Many parents assume that if their adolescent children are not asking them directly to help them get married, this means they do not have any urge to get married yet. However, the reality is that not all young Muslims are upfront, outspoken, and frank enough with their parents to tell them that they are ready for marriage. It is not easy to beat the desires of our body, biology, and sex hormones. The youth who are not asking to get married often appear calm because they are already having an affair with someone which is why they do not feel the need to push their parents to help them get married right away. Ibrâheem

ibn Maysarah narrated from Ṭâwoos who narrated that ‘Umar ibn al-Khaṭṭâb said to a man who was unnecessarily delaying his marriage:

مَا يَمْنَعُكَ عَنِ النِّكَاحِ إِلَّا عَجْزٌ أَوْ فُجُورٌ.

Nothing can cause you to delay your marriage except impotence [erectile dysfunction] or involvement in an illicit relationship [with a woman].[217]

Muslim psychologist Dr. Malik Badri notes that Muslim marriages have become extremely expensive due to the squandering of wealth on wedding ceremonies to show off as well as follow the marriage customs taken from Hindu culture or other idol-worshipping societies.[218] One such custom is the payment of the bride’s dowry with which, contrary to the Islamic teachings, the parents of the bride are burdened. Dr. Badri suggests that the solution to this problem in Muslim countries is to set up inexpensive mass weddings on the national level with nominal bridal gifts. Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) said:

«أَعْظَمُ النِّكَاحِ بَرَكَةً أَيْسَرُهُ مَؤُنَةً.»

«The most blessed marriage is the one with the least expenses.» (Recorded by al-Bayhaqi; graded sound by al-Ḥâkim)[219]

Muslim parents should not delay the marriages of their children to such an extent that the only option that remains for their young son or daughter is to indulge in flirting, dating, courtship before marriage, and love marriages. Research has shown that marriages that are the result of flirting, dating, and courtships are temporary, and ‘testing the waters’ before marriage does not seem to increase compatibility. ‘Love at first sight’ is the slogan of Satan. The truth is this experience is ‘lust at first sight,’ not ‘love at first sight’. Muslim parents must not forget the warning given in the following hadith

narrated by Abu Ḥâtim al-Muzani in which Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) said:

« إِذَا جَاءَكُمْ مَنْ تَرْضَوْنَ دِينَهُ وَخُلُقَهُ فَأَنْكِحُوهُ، إِلاَّ تَفْعَلُوا تَكُنْ فِتْنَةٌ فِي الأَرْضِ وَفَسَادٌ.»

«If you are approached by someone whose religion and manners satisfy you, let him marry your daughter; if you do not do that, there will be dissension and great corruption on the earth.» (Recorded by at-Tirmidhi; graded acceptable by al-Albâni)[220]

Muslim youth and the confused.com phenomenon

The Internet is like a double-edged sword for the Muslim youth who are in search of Islamic knowledge. There are both harms and benefits in it. If the Muslim youth are not firmly grounded in Islamic knowledge and have not acquired authentic Islamic knowledge from classical Islamic scholars for a reasonable period of time, there is a good chance that the Islam presented on the Internet could turn them into ‘confused.com’.

Some websites have true Islamic knowledge based on the Qur’an and authentic sayings of Prophet Muhammad (bpuh). However, even more websites are set up to disseminate false information about Islam to the public. People post fabricated hadiths of the Prophet (bpuh) on Islamic websites, and there are certain self-proclaimed Islamic scholars who are fluent and sometimes very charismatic speakers. Their speeches on YouTube may appear to our Muslim youth as very impressive but, in reality, what they are presenting is a fake message. Allah mentions about such people:

{When you see them, their outward appearance pleases you; when they speak, you listen to what they say. But they are like propped-up pieces of

wood [devoid of all understanding]. They think that every cry is against them. They are the enemy, so beware of them. May Allah destroy them; how could they have gone so far astray?} *(al-Munâfiqoon 63: 4)*

The Qur'an and Sunnah are our biggest weapons against the hypocrites, innovators, and 'scholars for dollars'. Today, every deviant group of the Muslim community has its own website under the apparent banner of Islam. Websites of such deviant groups present false information about Islam in order to abuse, accuse, and confuse Muslim youth and new Muslims who happen to visit these sites. Muslim men and women may end up turning into 'hypocrites.com' or 'disbelievers.com' if they start to believe the ideas that are posted on the Internet, for the simple reason that hypocrisy is contagious by nature. This practice can be better understood by an example given in the following hadith of our beloved Prophet (bpuh), in which he said:

«Satan may come to one of you and say: Who created so-and-so? – until he says: Who created your Lord?

When he inspires such a question, one should seek refuge with Allah[221] and give up such thoughts.» (Bukhari and Muslim)

In another version, it is reported that the Prophet (bpuh) said:

«...One should then say: I believe in Allah and His Messenger (bpuh).» (Muslim)

When Muslim youth visit certain Islamic forums, discussion groups, and blogs (not run by authentic Islamic scholars), they become 'confused.com' by the amateur discussion about Islam by modernists, apologetic Muslims, and self-proclaimed scholars. To add insult to injury, there are online comments on articles and blog posts, most often by 'online Muslims', who are not firmly grounded in Islamic knowledge, and then

there is a whole chain-reaction (thread) of comments on the posted comments, followed by more replies to those amateur comments. Reading these threads of comments and replies only adds to the confusion for Muslim youth, and at the very least, it is a huge waste of time for them. There are certain matters in Islam that we read, in which we believe, and then we leave. We are not meant to discuss these issues in such detail. An example of a futile discussion about the issue of predestination mentioned in a hadith will elucidate the point. Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) prohibited his followers from discussing or arguing over the issue of predestination. Abu Hurayrah (may Allah be pleased with him) narrated:

«The Prophet (bpuh) emerged while we were arguing about predestination. He got angry, his face became red, and he said: Is this what you are commanded to do? Or, am I sent to you with this? Indeed those who were before you perished when they argued over this issue. I command you not to argue over it.» (An odd hadith recorded by at-Tirmidhi; graded reliable by al-Albâni)

Then there is another issue of 'fatwa shopping'. Certain Muslims search the Internet and ask questions from different people to get a 'relaxed fatwa' fitting their desire, even though it is a juristic maxim among Islamic scholars that, "Whoever deliberately seeks out religious allowances becomes a heretic."

Our Muslim youth must understand that a sin is something that disturbs our hearts, even if the modernist, apologetic scholars or a 'rent-a-shaykh' gives us a legal opinion that suits our desires. If an issue is disturbing the hearts of Muslim youth, then that in itself is a clear sign that something is not right.

وَعَنْ وَابِصَةَ بْنِ مَعْبَدٍ قَالَ: «أَتَيْتُ رَسُولَ اللهِ صَلَّى اللهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ فَقَالَ: جِئْتَ تَسْأَلُ عَنِ الْبِرِّ؟ قُلْتُ: نَعَمْ، قَالَ: اسْتَفْتِ قَلْبَكَ، الْبِرُّ مَا اطْمَأَنَّتْ إِلَيْهِ النَّفْسُ، وَاطْمَأَنَّ إِلَيْهِ الْقَلْبُ، وَالْإِثْمُ

مَا حَاكَ فِي النَّفْسِ، وَتَرَدَّدَ فِي الصَّدْرِ، وَإِنْ أَفْتَاكَ النَّاسُ وَأَفْتَوْكَ».

«Wâbiṣah ibn Ma‘bad said: I came to the Messenger of Allah (bpuh).

He asked: Have you come to ask about righteousness?

I responded: Yes.

He said: Consult your heart. Righteousness is something about which the soul feels tranquil and the heart feels tranquil, and wrongdoing is what wavers in the soul and moves back and forth in the breast (in your heart) even though people again and again give you their opinion in its favour.» (Recorded by Aḥmad; graded acceptable by al-Albâni)[222]

A fundamental issue with global news shown on television and the Internet is that the news networks that broadcast them have Western media as their source. The problem with Western media is that it outwardly wears a cloak of truth and objectivity, but in reality its purpose is to present falsehood as truth. Western media exercises double standards when it comes to Islam and Muslims. It demonizes Islam and true, practicing Muslims and gives them labels such as ‘fundamentalists,’ or ‘extremists’. This fact has been openly admitted and is mentioned by Samuel Huntington as follows:

> A world of clashing civilizations, however, is inevitably a world of double standards: people apply one standard to their kin-country and a different standard to others.[223]

The perceptions of many Muslim youth are formed by the information presented to them by Western news sources and the Internet. However, the Qur’an warns the believers to be very careful and verify the authenticity of the news that reaches them:

{O you who believe, if a wrongdoer comes to you with any news, investigate [and verify the facts], lest you harm people out of ignorance,

then come to regret your actions.} *(al-Ḥujurât 49: 6)*

The information highway of the Internet has truth and falsehood mixed up. One can find the truth, but one may also be misguided by the Internet. Muslim men and women must exercise extreme caution when they are trying to learn about Islam from the Internet. If they download an Islamic book or article, or they watch or listen to an Islamic speech, they should verify its authenticity from a reliable local Islamic scholar (if available).

This is the nature of knowledge – that it must be sought from human beings, not machines. Knowledge sought from a human teacher enables us to check the character, depth of knowledge, and trustworthiness of the teacher, and in essence the source of that knowledge. This cannot be done for knowledge acquired from television or the Internet. It is extremely hard for an ordinary person to check the authenticity of Islamic knowledge posted by every Tom, Dick, and Harry on the information highway of the Internet. Imam ash-Shâfi‘i advises the Muslim youth in this regard as follows:

> If you intend to seek knowledge, acquire it after verifying it and checking its authenticity so that the spirit of knowledge is not lost.[224]

It is the nature of knowledge that if its authenticity is not verified and it is not sought from a human teacher, one will acquire information, but lose the true spirit of knowledge. Internet, computers, and television may provide data and information, but they cannot teach moral values, etiquette, and humanization to the students. This is why ‘Abdullâh ibn Wahb narrated the following statement of Imam Mâlik:

> Knowledge does not refer to plenty of information; knowledge is a light that Allah puts into the heart of whomever He wills.[225]

Imam Mâlik means that even if certain individuals are ‘walking encyclopaedias’, they do not have real knowledge if they do not recognize their Creator or the purpose of their creation. The Internet gives us a wealth of Islamic information, but we must verify its authenticity by contacting sincere Islamic scholars and turning to the Qur’an and authentic Sunnah of our beloved Prophet Muhammad (bpuh).

Chapter 6: Muslim Youth and Valentine's Day

One of the pagan customs that has become very popular among today's Muslim youth is the celebration of Valentine's Day. This day is celebrated on February 14th every year. On this day, married and unmarried young men and women all over the world exchange red roses and gifts. They congratulate and send greetings to one another. Bakeries and confectioners produce special red-coloured sweets with emblems of hearts on them to accentuate the importance of this occasion, and shops sell chocolates and flowers exclusively for this event.

In the last few years, this moral disease has spread like an epidemic, and sure enough, it has affected Muslim men and women of all ages. As this 'day of love' is glamorized in television dramas, on cable, and on satellite television, it has gained popularity among Muslim youth. In addition, the secular elite in Muslim countries try to provide full media coverage to this occasion, which adds to its popularity. Moreover, due to the advent of mass communication between people – through online chatting, Facebook, and cell phones – this moral disease of celebrating Valentine's Day has spread from big cities to the suburbs and rural areas of Muslim communities. In

many Muslim countries, prices of red roses skyrocket on Valentine's Day. In Gulf countries as well as non-Arab Muslim countries, shopping centres and hotels organize special parties on Valentine's Day, and gift shops and greeting card shops vie with one another in designing tailor-made cards and gifts especially for this occasion. Many businesses, stores, and shopping malls deck themselves with red, and some of them even place a statue or picture of Cupid, the symbol of love in Roman mythology, without even realizing that as a Muslim they are committing idolatry by doing so. In the name of freedom, all boundaries of freedom are crossed. Muslim youth celebrate this 'day of love' in an imitation of Western and Christian societies, and they totally forget that they belong to the nation of Prophet Muhammad (bpuh).

History of Valentine's Day

Like most Christian festivals, the roots of Valentine's Day can be traced back to pagan Romans. Valentine's Day is believed to have been started by Romans as a pagan ritual in honour of their Greek god Lupercus. In ancient Rome, young men and women celebrated this festival, its most attractive feature being the 'Lottery of Love', in which virgin women would write love letters and put them in a large vase. Then, in a lottery drawing, a young Roman man would select a woman who had written a love letter, and they would then court one another before marriage. The modern practice of dating among youth is not modern at all. This practice is the same as the wheel of the age of ignorance having come full circle, bringing us face to face with the same ancient promiscuity.

According to *Webster's Family Encyclopedia*, instead of abolishing the custom of idol-worshippers, the Roman clergy converted the festival initially known as Lupercalia and celebrated on February 15th into Saint

Valentine's Day to be celebrated on February 14th.[226] Moreover, the life of Saint Valentine (d. 269 CE) has nothing to do with this festival or the common modern traditions associated with it. Social critic Khalid Baig writes the following about the history of this festival:

> As usual, Christianity tried, without success, to stop the evil celebration of Lupercalia. It first replaced the lottery of the names of women with a lottery of the names of the saints. The idea was that during the following year the young men would emulate the life of the saint whose name they had drawn. (The idea that you can preserve the appearance of a popular evil and yet somehow turn it to serve the purpose of virtue, has survived. Look at all those people who are still trying, helplessly, to use the formats of popular television entertainments to promote good. They might learn something from this bit of history. It failed miserably.) Christianity ended up doing in Rome, and elsewhere, as the Romans did.
>
> The only success it had was in changing the name from Lupercalia to St. Valentine's Day.[227]

Valentine's Day – Position of the Qur'an and Sunnah

Today, due to the prevalence of evil in the world, many Muslim youth think there is no problem with celebrating Valentine's Day. They forget that in doing so, they are blindly following a religious custom of Christians as well as pagans. Sure enough, this blind imitation of non-Muslims by Muslims was prophesized in an authentic hadith narrated by Abu Sa'eed al-Khudri (may Allah be pleased with him), quoted earlier in this book:

«Allah's Messenger (bpuh) said: You will surely follow the ways of those before you, inch by inch and step by step, so much so that if they were to enter a sand lizard's hole, you would follow them.

The Companions asked: O Messenger of Allah, (do you mean) the Jews and the Christians?

He replied: Who else?» (Muslim)

Islam has strictly prohibited its followers from imitating the disbelievers. Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) said in one hadith:

«مَنْ تَشَبَّهَ بِقَوْمٍ فَهُوَ مِنْهُمْ.»

«Whoever imitates a people (nation) is one of them.» (Recorded by Abu Dâwood; graded authentic by al-Albâni)[228]

The famous commentator of the Qur'an Ibn Katheer writes the following about this hadith:

> This and other similar hadiths indicate, along with their threats and warnings, that we are not allowed to imitate the disbelievers' statements, deeds, clothes, feasts, acts of worship, and whatever actions of the disbelievers that were not legislated for us.[229]

Explaining this hadith, Shaykh al-Islâm Ibn Taymiyah states:

> This hadith, at the very least, indicates that it is unlawful to imitate them, although the apparent meaning implies that the one who imitates them is a disbeliever, as Allah mentions:
>
> {...Whoever among you takes them as allies is indeed one of them...} *(al-Mâ'idah 5: 51)*[230]

Similarly, Austrian Muslim convert Mohammad Asad sheds light on the implications of this hadith in the following words:

> This well-known Hadeeth is not only a moral hint, but also an objective statement which lays down the inevitability of Muslims being assimilated by the civilization they imitate.[231]

We also know that the celebration of Valentine's Day promotes vice and corruption in the society, while the Qur'an mentions in clear terms the fate of all the people who participate in any act that spreads lewdness in the society:

{Verily, those who like to see indecency spread among the believers will have a painful punishment in this world and the hereafter; Allah knows, and you do not know.} *(an-Noor 24: 19)*

This verse of the Qur'an admonishes every person who intends to spread corruption in the Muslim society. Anyone who has an iota of common sense knows very well that the celebration of Valentine's Day does not promote an atmosphere of spirituality in the society. Instead, this festival spreads an atmosphere of free love and free intermingling of sexes in the society.

Valentine's Day – Position of Companions and Islamic scholars

Here we shall present the verdicts and rulings of Prophet Muhammad's Companions as well as some of our pious scholars on participating in the festivals of non-Muslims:

‘Umar ibn al-Khaṭṭâb (may Allah be pleased with him)

Imam al-Bayhaqi narrated the verdict of Caliph ‘Umar ibn al-Khaṭṭâb (may Allah be pleased with him) regarding the festivals of non-Muslims. Caliph ‘Umar ibn al-Khaṭṭâb said:

> Do not learn the lingo of the foreigners, and do not visit the polytheists and disbelievers in their churches on the day of their festival, for divine wrath is descending upon them.[232]

He is also reported to have said, “Avoid the enemies of Allah on their festivals.[233]

‘Abdullâh ibn ‘Amr (may Allah be pleased with both of them)

Al-Bayhaqi narrated that ‘Abdullâh ibn ‘Amr said:

> Whoever settles in the land of the non-Arabs [non-Muslims] and celebrates their New Year and festivals and imitates them until he [or she] dies in that state will be gathered with them on the Day of Resurrection.[234]

It must also be noted here that Imam Ibn Taymiyah stated that there was a consensus among Prophet Muhammad’s Companions that it is prohibited to imitate the disbelievers in their festivals. Similarly, Imam Ibn al-Qayyim noted that there was a scholarly consensus on this point.[235]

Imam Abu Ḥaneefah

It is stated in the books of Imam Abu Ḥaneefah's students that he gave the following verdict on this issue:

> Whoever gives them a present of a watermelon during their holidays, intending to honour their holiday, has committed an act of apostasy.[236]

Imam Ibn Taymiyah

The great revivalist and Islamic scholar Imam Ibn Taymiyah explains the above-mentioned verdict of Caliph 'Umar ibn al-Khaṭṭâb (may Allah be pleased with him) as follows:

> 'Umar forbade learning their lingos and even entering their churches on the day of their festival, so how about doing some of the things they do on those days, or doing things that are a part of their religion? Is not going along with their actions worse than learning their lingo? Is not doing some of the things they do on their festival worse than just visiting them? If divine wrath is descending upon them on the day of their festival because of what they do, is not the one who does what they do, or a part of it, also exposed to the same punishment? Do not the words: Avoid the enemies of Allah on their festivals mean that we should not meet them or join them on those days? So how about the one who actually celebrates their festivals?[237]

Al-Ḥâfidh Shams ad-Deen adh-Dhahabi

Imam adh-Dhahabi gives the following verdict concerning the participation of Muslims in the festivals of disbelievers:

> Jews have their own special Eid, and Christians have their special Eid. Since Muslims do not join in the Sharia and qibla of Jews and Christians, they should never participate in the festivals of Jews and Christians.[238]

Ibn al-Qayyim

Imam Ibn al-Qayyim states the following about participating in the festivals of non-Muslims:

> With regard to congratulating others with words of congratulations used by the disbelievers on such occasions, it is unlawful by scholarly consensus, such as congratulating them on the occasion of their festivals or fasts, wishing them a blessed festival, and so on. It is unlawful even if the one who says this is free of disbelief in Allah. It is like congratulating someone for prostrating to the cross. This is even worse before Allah and more hated by Him than congratulating someone for drinking alcohol or committing murder or adultery and so on. Many of those who have no respect for religion do that, and they do not realize the abhorrence of their actions. Whoever congratulates a person for sin, innovation, or disbelief exposes himself [or herself] to the hatred and wrath of Allah.[239]

Shaykh Ibn al-‘Uthaymeen

Shaykh Muhammad ibn Ṣâliḥ al-‘Uthaymeen (d. January 5, 2001) was asked about the ruling of Sharia (Islamic law) on celebrating holidays such as Valentine’s Day. He was told in the question that Valentine’s Day was celebrated by many Muslims, especially female students, who wore all-red clothes and shoes and exchanged red flowers with each other.

Shaykh Ibn al-‘Uthaymeen’s reply is as follows:

Celebrating Valentine’s Day is not permitted for several reasons:

1. It is an innovated celebration which has no basis in the Sharia.
2. It calls upon people to keep their hearts and minds busy with these foolish things that go against the guidance of the pious predecessors [may Allah be pleased with them]. On this day, one is not permitted to do any of the customs associated with this holiday, whether they are connected to food, drink, clothing, exchanging gifts, or anything else. Muslims should be proud of their religion and not be so weak of character that they follow everyone who makes a noise. I ask Allah to protect the Muslims from all temptations, visible and invisible, and to take care of us and give us strength. Allah knows best.[240]

Shaykh ‘Abdullâh ibn Jibreen

Shaykh ‘Abdullâh ibn ‘Abdur-Raḥmân ibn Jibreen (d. July 13, 2009) was once asked about the ruling in Islam regarding the exchanging of gifts and celebrating the so-called ‘love festival’ or Valentine’s Day.

Shaykh Ibn Jibreen's reply was that it is not permissible to participate in or celebrate such festivals because they are an innovation, which is unlawful. In addition, the celebration of Valentine's Day is an imitation of non-Muslims' religious practices, and the hadith is clear in this regard:

«Whoever imitates a people (nation) is one of them.» (Recorded by Abu Dâwood; graded authentic by al-Albâni)

Shaykh Ibn Jibreen also notes in his verdict that Valentine's Day results in evil and forbidden things such as:

> ...wasting time, singing, music, extravagance, unveiling, wanton display, men mixing with women, women appearing before men other than their mahrams, and other haraam things, or things that are a means that leads to immorality. That cannot be excused by the claim that this is a kind of entertainment and fun. The one who is sincere towards himself should keep away from sin and the means that lead to it.
>
> Based on this, it is not permissible to sell these gifts and roses, if it is known that the purchaser celebrates these festivals or will give these things as gifts on those days, so that the seller will not be a partner of the one who does those innovations. And Allaah knows best.[241]

Dr. Suad Ibrahim Salih

Dr. Suad Ibrahim Salih is a professor at the Women's College of Islamic Studies at Al-Azhar University in Egypt. When she was asked about the Islamic stance on Valentine's Day, she clarified that Islam is a religion of sacrifice, cooperation, and love. Some forms of love are acceptable in Islam, while others are unacceptable. For instance, love for Allah and His

Messenger, Prophet Muhammad (bpuh), is not only praiseworthy, but it also holds the highest position over all other categories of love. Dr. Salih further states:

> Islam does recognize happy occasions that bring people closer to one another, and add spice to their lives. However, Islam goes against blindly imitating the West regarding a special occasion such as Valentine's Day. Hence, commemorating that special day known as the Valentine's Day is an innovation or bid'ah that has no religious backing. Every innovation of that kind is rejected, as far as Islam is concerned. Islam requires all Muslims to love one another all over the whole year, and reducing the whole year to a single day is totally rejected.
>
> Hence, we Muslims ought not to follow in the footsteps of such innovations and superstitions that are common in what is known as the Valentine's Day. No doubt that there are many irreligious practices that occur on that day, and those practices are capable of dissuading people from the true meanings of love and altruism to the extent that the celebration is reduced to a moral decline.[242]

Standing Committee for Scholarly Research and Legal Rulings

On November 23, 1999, the Standing Committee for Scholarly Research and Legal Rulings (Saudi Arabia) received a questionnaire from a Muslim youth named Abdullah Ale-Rabeea, in which he asked them the following question:

> Every year on February 14, some people celebrate the Day of Love [Valentine's Day] on which they exchange red flowers as gifts, dress in red clothes, and congratulate each other. Some bakeries and shops sell red coloured candies and chocolates with a red heart on them, while some businessmen post special signs on their shops. What is the Islamic ruling on this?[243]

The Committee studied this matter thoroughly and gave the following ruling:

> The clear proof from the Qur'an and Sunnah – and this is in accordance with the consensus of the early Muslim generations – confirms that there are only two Eids [days of celebration] in Islam: Eid al-Fiṭr [at the end of Ramadan] and Eid al-Aḍḥâ [on the occasion of Hajj]. Every other Eid – whether related to a person, group, incident or any other occasion – is an innovated Eid. It is not permissible for Muslims to participate in it, approve of it, or display any sign of happiness on its occasion, or assist others in doing so... If, on top of all this, such innovated Eid happens to be a festival of the disbelievers, then it becomes a case of sin piled upon sin. This is because its celebration clearly means imitation of the disbelievers, and we are prohibited from doing so... Valentine's Day comes under the category of what has been mentioned here since it is a pagan holiday. Muslims are not allowed to participate in it, approve of it, or congratulate anyone on its occasion. It is also obligatory upon the Muslims to abandon it and distance oneself from it in response to the command of Allah and His Messenger [bpuh]. Additionally, it is prohibited for a Muslim to assist or provide help on this pagan festival in any way whatsoever, whether by eating or drinking, selling or buying, production, gift-giving, messages, or any other means. All these things are considered to be cooperation in sin,

transgression, and disobedience to Allah and His Messenger [bpuh]. Allah commands us in the Qur'an:

{…Help one another in righteousness and piety, but do not help one another in sin and transgression. Fear Allah, for Allah is severe in punishment.} *(al-Mâ'idah 5: 2)*[244]

As Muslims, we should not accept congratulations on Valentine's Day because it is neither a Muslim holiday nor an Eid for the Muslims. If a Muslim is congratulated on this occasion, he or she should not return the congratulations but remain polite and respectful to the people of other faiths.

Our Muslim youth should be especially reminded that it is forbidden for them to send or forward text messages or emails of congratulations or love messages on the occasion of Valentine's Day (called Eid of Love by some youth) even if it involves sending or forwarding a love message to someone in a legitimate relationship, such as a husband sending a love message to his wife or vice versa, or a daughter sending a love message to her mother. Muslim youth, boys and girls, men and women, must also remember that posting, sharing, or forwarding love messages or Valentine's Day e-cards on social media, such as Facebook, Twitter, Instagram, TikTok, or MySpace, is equivalent to participation in this festival of the disbelievers. Pressing the 'Like,' 'Follow,' 'Tweet,' 'Plus One,' or 'Pin it' buttons on one's friends' posts on Valentine's Day means one is expressing one's approval of and encouraging this sinful custom of the disbelievers.

Role of Valentine's Day in suicide

One of the names of Satan mentioned in the Qur'an is Iblees. This name is derived from the Arabic *balasa* meaning 'he despaired', which can also be

interpreted as “the one who is despaired of Allah’s mercy”. Satan, or Iblees, causes people to despair, and whoever follows the footsteps of Iblees suffers from despair and depression. As a result of this despair and loss of faith, people often kill themselves. American psychiatrist Aaron Beck and his colleagues have shown in their studies that hopelessness and despair are the most important contributing factors and key psychological states among people who commit suicide.[245] Since Valentine’s Day is a satanic festival, it is natural that people experience feelings of emptiness and despair after celebrating it. Some girls and boys actually commit suicide as a result of depression caused by Valentine’s Day. Diane Barth, a psychotherapist and psychoanalyst from New York, writes the following about the despair that comes with Valentine’s Day:

> And on the day itself, there is always surprise, sometimes pleasurable, often disagreeable. Disappointment is almost inevitable, since the holiday can hardly live up to its image. Daydreams of romantic interludes give way to the reality of crowded restaurants, routine conversation, bad hair, unwanted attention.[246]

Psychologists and sociologists have tried to investigate the reasons behind these feelings of disappointment and found a scientific basis for it. Evidence surfaced from these findings points to what experts call ‘broken-promise effect’ following highly scripted holidays, including Valentine’s Day. Gert Jessen and Borge Jensen from the Centre for Suicidological Research in Denmark investigated 32,291 suicide cases that occurred between 1970 and 1994 in Denmark. The age of people who committed suicide was fifteen years or older. Their research was published in the 1999 issue of the scientific journal *Suicide and Life-Threatening Behavior*, in which they noted a clear link between suicides and public holidays including Valentine’s Day. They concluded, based on the available data

from their study, that when expectations of people celebrating the holidays are not met, they become so depressed that they commit suicide. They state:

> Evidence was found to support the theory of the 'broken-promise effect' for major public holidays in that there appears to be a postponement of a significant number of suicides from before a holiday until after... The theory holds that a suicidal individual may be influenced by approaching events like spring, weekends, and holidays because they tend to promote hope or expectations of the person feeling better than he or she does beforehand. The forth-coming event is seen as synonymous with a new beginning in the sense that things will get better than or thereafter.[247]

From the above-mentioned research, we can understand why both the annual Islamic festivals of Eid al-Fiṭr and Eid al-Aḍḥâ (Muslim public holidays) begin with prayers and remembrance of Allah. This is so because the Qur'an mentions:

{...verily in the remembrance of Allah hearts find comfort.} *(ar-Ra'd 13: 28)*

In the sermons following the Eid prayer, Allah is glorified and the accounts of the Day of Judgement, the life hereafter, paradise, and hell are mentioned. This explains why our beloved Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) frequently used to recite Soorat Qâf and Soorat al-Qamar from the Qur'an in his sermons of Eid al-Fiṭr and Eid al-Aḍḥâ. Both these chapters contain vivid descriptions of the horrors of the Day of Judgement, rewards for the people of paradise, and punishments for the people of hell.

«Abu Wâqid al-Laythi, a Companion of Prophet Muhammad (bpuh), was asked: Which chapters of the Qur'an did Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) recite in the prayers of Eid al-Aḍḥâ and Eid al-Fiṭr?

Abu Wâqid replied: He used to recite Soorat Qâf (in the first unit) and Soorat al-Qamar (in the second unit) in the Eid prayers.» (Muslim)[248]

Muslims begin their Islamic holidays with the remembrance of Allah and the mention of the life hereafter and the rewards and blessings bestowed by Allah in paradise. They do not go through feelings of emptiness and do not experience despair caused by the 'broken-promise effect'. This is because they know that Allah's promise of paradise is a true and an unbroken promise, as the Qur'an mentions:

{...It is a true promise, given by Him in the Torah, the Gospel and the Qur'an, and who is more faithful to His promise than Allah? Rejoice, then, in the bargain you have made; that is the supreme triumph.} *(at-Tawbah 9: 111)*

The findings from the study of Dr. Jessen and Jensen – demonstrating a strong correlation between suicides and public holidays – are applicable to Valentine's Day as well.

Additional research that is even more relevant to the subject of suicides and Valentine's Day includes a study conducted by Dr. Jan Birtle (M.Sc. in Psychotherapy) and Susan M. Davenport. This study was published in the 1990 issue of the *British Medical Journal*. Dr. Birtle and Davenport observed in their research that the percentage of parasuicide victims (unsuccessful attempts to commit suicides) brought to the emergency wards of hospitals in Birmingham, England were much higher on Valentine's Day as compared to the rest of the days in the year. Dr. Birtle writes the following about these findings:

> Experience in a casualty department suggested to us that an unusually high number of patients who had taken an overdose of drugs presented on Saint Valentine's Day (14 February)... The festival of Saint Valentine's Day may induce stress due to unrequited love... Our study

> showed an association between Saint Valentine's Day and parasuicide, particularly in adolescent patients.[249]

A study by the Harvard School of Public Health provides a link between disappointments from dating and suicide. This comprehensive study comprised 1,977 high school girls who were involved in a dating relationship. The results of this study appeared in the August 1, 2001 issue of the *Journal of the American Medical Association*. It was revealed in this study that 20 percent of girls (one out of five) reported being a victim of physical or sexual violence during dating. These girls reported being "hit, slapped, shoved or forced into sexual activity" by dates. Dr. Jay Silverman, the principal investigator of this research, regarded this percentage to be "extremely high".

Another shocking finding from this study was that dating violence against adolescent girls was directly linked to risk behaviours and suicide attempts. Risk behaviours include binge drinking, cocaine use, and unhealthy weight-control behaviours, including the use of diet pills, all of which are dangerous for the health of girls. In addition, many teenage girls who were the victims of violence from dating partners seriously considered or attempted suicide after the violence happened to them. Dr. Jay Silverman writes:

> Finally, recent suicide ideation and actual suicide attempts were approximately 6 to 9 times as common among adolescent girls who reported having been sexually and physically hurt by dating partners… The pain and humiliation of those who experience IPV [Intimate Partner Violence during dating] may play a major role in predisposing teens to suicidal ideation and behaviour.[250]

Again, we see the 'broken-promise effect' here. The above research shows that dating violence results in increased attempts among girls to

commit suicide. We already know that dating activities peak during Valentine's Day. Joseph Essas, Former Chief Technology Officer at eHarmony.com (online dating site), revealed that on Valentine's Day, "our demand doubles, if not quadruples."[251] Hence, we can see a potential link between suicide and Valentine's Day from this study.

In 2012, a pair of lovers facing stiff opposition from their families committed suicide on Valentine's Day. According to the details of the news report, Soud Sheikh, aged seventeen, and Mitu Molla, aged sixteen, both from southern Bangladesh, were high school students in tenth grade. Soud had an affair with Mitu but Soud's family refused to accept it and sent Soud away from Dhaka. In the meantime, Mitu's parents married her to another man whom she had not met before. Soud came back to Dhaka on the night of Monday, February 13, 2012. On Tuesday morning, on the occasion of Valentine's Day, Soud and Mitu went to Grameen Phone Tower, and both of them jumped from the tower. The lovers tied their hands together with a red scarf, presumably symbolizing Valentine's Day and their relationship. Police officer Sarojit Biswas attested later that the two young lovers had died instantly. When their dead bodies were found, their hands were still tied together with the scarf.[252]

The above-mentioned studies bear testimony to the fact that Valentine's Day heightens feelings of despair in teenagers and young men and women who have encountered heartbreak, rejection, pain, misery, and loss in their relationships. This depressing effect, maximized on Valentine's Day, nurtures a suicidal mood in some people. When feelings of melancholy are evoked, this may cause unbearable depression, to the point that some people commit suicide. This is so because Valentine's Day is a festival of Iblees, the one who incites feelings of hopelessness in people and encourages them to commit shameful and indecent acts, as the Qur'an mentions:

{O you who believe, do not follow the footsteps of the Satan; whoever follows the footsteps of the Satan, he only enjoins indecency and wickedness...} *(an-Noor 24: 21)*

Role of Valentine's Day in breakup of marriages

Today, most of the people from single and married Muslim youth to older Muslim couples celebrate Valentine's Day. They think they are not doing anything wrong because they are married. However, they do not realize that Valentine's Day is not only an imitation of the disbelievers; it is also a satanic festival with horrible consequences. Whenever people do not obey the commands of Allah and follow the footsteps of Satan, their life becomes miserable, as the Qur'an mentions:

{But whoever turns away from My Reminder [the Qur'an] will have a miserable life…} *(Ṭâ Hâ 20: 124)*

Muslims celebrating Valentine's Day must realize that it is increasingly becoming a catalyst for divorce. According to data compiled by Avvo – a site that offers free ratings and profiles for lawyers – Valentine's Day often sees a 40 percent skyrocket-increase in divorce filings. Mark Britton, founder and CEO of Avvo, notes:

> Over the past two years we've seen an average increase of 40 percent in the number of requests for divorce lawyers around Valentine's Day, compared to the previous six months. Furthermore, the number of questions about divorce soared 36 percent during that same time [at the time of Valentine's Day].[253]

Matrimonial disputes and litigation expert Richard Segal writes the following about the dark side of Valentine's Day:

> For many, Valentine's is "D" Day – Divorce Day! Seems odd, right? Hey honey, here is a box of heart chocolates, red roses, and a summons in which you have been served with a dissolution proceeding [divorce papers]… While for most people Valentine's Day is a time to commemorate their love, for others it has become the time to pull the plug.[254]

Social scientists have tried to investigate the reasons behind this phenomenon. Katherine Morse, honours graduate of Arizona State University, and Steven Neuberg, Professor at the Department of Psychology (Social), Arizona State University, studied the relationships of couples from the years 1999 to 2000, the results of which were published in the 2004 issue of the scientific journal *Personal Relationships*. Although this study included unmarried young men and women who were in a relationship for a period of time, the results of this study can also be applied to married couples who celebrate Valentine's Day. In order to keep this study unbiased, researchers studied romantic relationships not only on February 14th, but also in the months of November, September, and April, so that a comparison could be made. Morse and Neuberg observed in their research that the number of couples who broke their relationships off in February was much higher than in the rest of the months. Morse and Neuberg state:

> Valentine's Day is a highly scripted holiday, providing a special set of expectations for appropriate behaviour: Couples have dinner together, exchange cards and gifts, and otherwise act 'romantically.' The holiday may be so scripted that it presents, for some couples, a no-win situation: If a partner acts in the expected romantic manner, it could imply that he or she is authentically loving, but it could also imply merely that he or she is dutifully adhering to the Valentine's Day script... It may be difficult, therefore, to 'win' on Valentine's Day, to surpass the ever-rising expectations. It may be quite easy to 'lose,' however.[255]

This study by Morse and Neuberg is telling us that no matter how much love a husband tries to express to his wife on Valentine's Day, she may think that he is using the occasion of Valentine's Day as a pretext to show off his otherwise insincere love.

In a separate study conducted by Neuberg in 1996, it was shown that when expectations are not met, this has a negative impact on the relationships of couples.

To add insult to injury, most couples celebrate Valentine's Day in public, which offers an opportunity to both men and women to compare at least the outward quality of their own relationship with those of other couples. Dr. Katherine Morse points out that participating in such a comparison can be very problematic, because many couples expressing their love in public may be putting on a show in the spirit of this event:

> ...creating a public state of 'pluralistic puppy love' that positively skews people's estimates of the amount of romance and love in other relationships... Unfavorable social comparisons create negative affect and dissatisfaction... and, in this case, may increase the likelihood of relationship dissolution.[256]

Likewise, Shirley Ogletree, Professor at Southwest Texas State University, revealed in her research that women tend to attach more importance to the occasion of Valentine's Day as compared to men – more women than men exchange gifts, dress in red clothing, and have high expectations during this festival. This is why women are the ones who are grieved when these expectations are not met. Dr. Ogletree also noted an interesting observation that the males who have feminine qualities are more likely than regular males to attach importance to the occasion of Valentine's Day. She writes:

> Females and feminine individuals regardless of sex were significantly more likely than males and less feminine individuals to indicate that Valentine's Day is important to them...[257]

Researchers Morse and Neuberg also investigated the likelihood of whether or not Valentine's Day actually led to the termination of relationship between couples. They discovered an increased likelihood of breakup during the two weeks around Valentine's Day, supporting their prediction that "relationships do not always come up rosy around the holiday."[258] In fact, Morse and Neuberg propose that if the society does not have holidays such as Valentine's Day to impose a social burden on people, it is highly possible that many marital relationships with declining trajectories would remain intact and not result in a breakup.

In the same vein, family counsellor and legal expert Richard Segal advises people to think twice before ending their marriages. He cautions his readers not to be persuaded by the thrill of Valentine's Day on social media such as Facebook and Twitter to find another romance:

> Do not turn to social media for romantic reprieve… Also, more and more attorneys are citing Facebook and Twitter in the court room. That one flirtatious wall post could be taken completely out of context and held against you, so think before you type![259]

Now a word of warning for married Muslim couples. Some Muslim husbands are influenced by their environment because everyone around them is celebrating Valentine's Day; they may want to give a 'surprise gift' of chocolates or red roses to their wives, or win them over by taking them to a restaurant on Valentine's Day, where they have to sit with other non-maḥram men around, staring at their beautiful face, all of which is only an imitation of the disbelievers. Such Muslim husbands must understand that

they cannot win the hearts of their wives by displeasing Allah. It is clearly mentioned in the hadith:

«لَا طَاعَةَ لِمَخْلُوقٍ فِي مَعْصِيَةِ الْخَالِقِ.»

«There is no obedience to the creation (people) in disobedience to the Creator (Allah).» (Recorded by Ibn ‘Abdul-Barr; graded sound by al-Albâni)[260]

We have the example of our beloved Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) as the most successful husband, and by studying his biography, we can learn many ways to please our wives. Celebrating the festivals of disbelievers does not strengthen our marital relationships – it only weakens them.

It is a fact that the message of ‘love’ promoted in the celebration of Valentine’s Day is, in reality, not love but lust. It is not lustful emotion but courtesy and care for each other that keeps marriages intact and helps them survive the test of time.

During the caliphate of the second Rightly-Guided Caliph ‘Umar ibn al-Khaṭṭâb, a man came to him and told him that he wanted to divorce his wife.

‘Umar ibn al-Khaṭṭâb asked him: Why do you want to divorce her?

The man replied: I do not love her [anymore].

‘Umar ibn al-Khaṭṭâb responded: Are all homes [marital relationships] founded on love? Then where are feelings of courtesy and guardianship [in marital relationships]?[261]

We should not be deceived by the powerful media messages of those who are wrong. Some people might say, “But today everybody is celebrating Valentine’s Day.” The Qur’an tells us that anything done by the

majority of people is not a justification to make it permissible. All the prophets of Allah came to this world at a time when the majority of people were disobeying Allah to such an extent that deviance appeared to be the norm in the society. Allah mentions in the Qur'an:

{Say: The bad and the good are not equal, even though the abundance of the bad may appear pleasing to you. So fear Allah…} *(al-Mâ'idah 5: 100)*

The Qur'an guides us not to follow the majority:

{If you were to obey **most** of those who are on earth, they would lead you astray from the path of Allah. They follow nothing but conjecture and they do nothing but lie.} *(al-An'âm 6: 116)*

Our criterion of truth and falsehood should not be falsely based on the question of "Everyone is doing it so why should I not?" It should be determined by the Qur'an and Sunnah. Any act or custom that meets the criterion of the Qur'an and Sunnah is the truth. Our Muslim youth (men and women, boys and girls) should be wary of festivals that are based on innovation and disbelief. They must warn others about these practices of idol-worshippers. Our Muslim youth must be proud of our religion of Islam and try their best to distinguish themselves from the deviant people.

Chapter 7: How to Save Our Muslim Youth in the Age of Dajjâl

If Muslim youth are nurtured in an Islamic way, they will have the boldness, courage, and determination to turn the tide in their favour. Muslim youth should establish regular prayers and repent to Allah during voluntary night prayers. They should learn Islamic knowledge from Islamic scholars not misguided scholars. They should study the message of the Qur'an and the authentic hadiths of our beloved Prophet Muhammad (bpuh). Imam Mâlik said:

لا يُصْلِحُ آخِرَ هَذِهِ الأُمَّةِ إلا مَا أَصْلَحَ أَوَّلَهَا.

> The latter part of the Muslim nation will only be reformed by what reformed the former part.[262]

Muslim youth must not be tempted by the majority around them; they should remember that the Qur'an, Sunnah, and the way of our pious predecessors are the criterion of truth. Imam an-Nawawi states:

The way of truth is what the pious predecessors were upon, and that is the right path. Do not be fooled by the large number of people that oppose it. Abu ‘Ali Fuḍayl ibn ‘Iyâḍ rightly said: Stick to the ways of guidance, and you will not be harmed by the minority that follows it. Beware of the ways of misguidance, and do not be fooled by the multitude of those who will be destroyed.[263]

In this age of Dajjâl, our Muslim youth can only cure the disease of ignorance with authentic knowledge of Islam. They should understand who Dajjâl is, what his system is, and who his agents are. Our Muslim youth must also understand the web of Dajjâl and its intricacies. Our Muslim brothers must lower their gazes to guard their modesty, as commanded in the Qur’an. Likewise, our Muslim sisters should beware of Barṣeeṣâ-type men and their smooth talk on social media and in chat rooms. Our Muslim sisters should understand the concept of true hijab (which means to not be seen by non-maḥram men) when they are chatting through webcams or on Skype, WhatsApp, or Zoom, or when they are posting their pictures on Facebook or Instagram.

Muslim youth must work with their elders. However, Muslim youth do not have to follow their elders if they ask them to disobey Allah and His Messenger (bpuh). While dealing with the youth, Muslim parents and teachers must also not forget the teaching methodology of our beloved Prophet (bpuh). Whenever he wanted to send some of his Companions to teach people in other places, he gave them the following advice:

«يَسِّرُوا وَلَا تُعَسِّرُوا، وَسَكِّنُوا وَلَا تُنَفِّرُوا.»

«Make things easy for the people, and do not make it difficult for them, and make them calm (with glad tidings) and do not repulse (them).» (Bukhari and Muslim)[264]

Importance of turning to the Qur'an and Sunnah

The solution to our youth's problems in this age of Dajjâl lies in following the Qur'an and Sunnah. Muslim youth and elders must return to the Qur'an and Sunnah in order to receive guidance and jumpstart their faith. Only the Qur'an and Sunnah have the power to instil new character in our Muslim youth. Allah has revealed the Qur'an so that we are guided until the Last Day. The Qur'an has guidance for every seeker of truth, anywhere, anytime. The Qur'an mentions:

{...We have neglected nothing in the Book [of Our decrees], then to their Lord they will be gathered.} *(al-An'âm 6: 38)*

{...And We have sent down to you the Book, explaining all things, and as guidance, mercy and glad tidings for the Muslims.} *(an-Naḥl 16: 89)*

Every question that concerns guidance will definitely have an answer in this Book of Allah. This is the miracle of the Qur'an that whichever page we open, there is guidance for us. British Muslim convert Charles Le Gai Eaton comments as follows about this quality of the Qur'an:

> ...the Qur'an provides a rope of salvation for people of every kind, the stupid as well as the intelligent, and limited interpretations do not diminish its efficacy, provided they satisfy the needs of particular souls. No book of human authorship can be 'for everyone', but this is precisely the function of a revealed scripture, and for this reason it cannot be read in the way that works of human origin are read...[265]

The Qur'an, unlike other books of Islamic jurisprudence, does not contain only commandments. Out of 6,236 verses of the Qur'an, only about 600 pertain to legal commandments. The remaining portion discusses

subjects such as death, afterlife, and stories of previous prophets and nations in order to admonish and provide spiritual training to the Muslims. Shaykh Amin Ahsan Islahi, renowned commentator of the Qur'an, sheds light on this aspect of the Qur'an as follows:

> In the Qur'an, commandments and rules are not presented in the way they are presented in books of Islamic jurisprudence. In the Qur'an, before and after every command and law, the attributes of Allah and the life hereafter are mentioned repeatedly, and the spiritual, social, and moral benefits of Allah's commandments are expounded in a way that touches the human heart. If you read any book of Islamic jurisprudence, your heart will remain unaffected but if you read the same commandments in the Qur'an, a part of your soul will be enlightened by its greatness, and you will be moved [inspired] to act upon those commands.[266]

In order to explain this point further, the example of a Muslim youth is presented here. This clinical case was described by renowned contemporary clinical psychologist Dr. Malik Badri in his book *The Dilemma of Muslim Psychologists*. As Dr. Badri notes in his book, this happened in 1965 when he used to work in the Neuropsychiatry Department of the University of Rabat's Teaching Hospital. During this time, a young female Moroccan patient was referred to Dr. Badri. She had a number of complaints, including depression, certain phobias, severe anxiety, and feelings of inadequacy. Prior to seeing Dr. Badri, she had been admitted to the hospital twice for almost a year, but modern psychotherapy proved to be futile for her. In addition, she was prescribed tranquilizing drugs but those did not help either.

One day, in her therapy session with Dr. Badri, he was reading a passage from the Qur'an about forgiveness for sinful behaviour as moral

support to a male patient who was leaving the hospital. The passage in the Qur'an is as follows:

{Hasten towards forgiveness from your Lord and a garden as vast as the heavens and the earth, which is prepared for the pious, those who spend [in Allah's cause] in times of both ease and hardship, who control their anger, and pardon people, for Allah loves those who do good; and those who, if they do something shameful or wrong themselves, remember Allah and ask for forgiveness for their sins – for who can forgive sins except Allah? – and do not knowingly persist in what they have done.} *(Âl 'Imrân 3: 133-135)*

To Dr. Badri's surprise, when the young female patient heard those verses, she responded with tearful emotions. Then the chief psychotherapist Dr. H. Habib asked Dr. Badri to change the course of her treatment. Dr. Badri started her treatment by reading to her passages from the Qur'an that talk about Allah's forgiveness of sins and explaining all this in simple language. Dr. Badri wrote, "That was the beginning of an emotional confession and a very quick improvement (followed it)."[267]

Amazed at the dramatic improvement of this young woman, chief psychotherapist Dr. Habib told Dr. Badri:

> I have always kept a copy of the Holy Qur'an in my office in the hospital for the last three years. It never occurred to me at any time to bring it down from the bookshelf as a therapeutic aid to my patients.[268]

Another point that should be emphasized to our Muslim youth is that the Qur'an is general and does not go into the fine details of various commandments; it directs us to follow the Sunnah of Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) for guidance in this respect. The Qur'an mentions clearly:

{...Whatever the Messenger gives you [of the gains, or of instructions], accept it, and whatever he forbids to you, refrain from it...} *(al-Ḥashr 59: 7)*

Some modern-day Muslim youth become the victims of certain deviant sects and end up accepting only the Qur'an, while rejecting the Sunnah of the Messenger of Allah (bpuh). This rejection of the Sunnah by certain modernists of today is the result of their feeling of inferiority when they are confronted by Western civilization, as Mohammad Asad has rightly asserted in his book *Islam at the Crossroads*. He writes:

> This Westernisation is the strongest reason why the Traditions of our Prophet [bpuh] and along with them, the whole structure of the Sunnah have become so unpopular today. The Sunnah is so obviously opposed to the fundamental ideas underlying Western civilization that those who are fascinated by the latter see no way out of the tangle but to describe the Sunnah as an irrelevant, and therefore not compulsory, aspect of Islam because it is "based on unreliable Traditions". After that, it becomes easier to twist the teachings of the Qur'an in such a way that they might appear to suit the spirit of Western civilization.[269]

Our beloved Prophet (bpuh) prophesized that this mentality would exist among certain people towards the end of time. In one hadith, narrated by al-Miqdâm ibn Ma'dikarib, Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) warned us:

«أَلَا إِنِّي أُوتِيتُ الْكِتَابَ، وَمِثْلَهُ مَعَهُ أَلَا يُوشِكُ رَجُلٌ شَبْعَانُ عَلَى أَرِيكَتِهِ يَقُولُ عَلَيْكُمْ بِهَذَا الْقُرْآنِ فَمَا وَجَدْتُمْ فِيهِ مِنْ حَلَالٍ فَأَحِلُّوهُ، وَمَا وَجَدْتُمْ فِيهِ مِنْ حَرَامٍ فَحَرِّمُوهُ.»

«Beware! I have been given the Qur'an and something like it yet a time is coming when a man replete on his couch will say: Adhere to the Qur'an; treat as permissible what you find in it to be permissible, and treat as prohibited what you find in it to be prohibited.» (Recorded by Abu Dâwood; al-Albâni graded it sound)[270]

The Sunnah is an essential partner of the Qur'an, and we need it to understand the Qur'an and help us learn the finer details of how to live an

Islamic lifestyle. The Sunnah together with the Qur'an is Dajjâl's biggest enemy in this modern age.

Importance of prayer and worship

Dr. Andrew J. Weaver, clinical psychologist at the Hawaii State Hospital and an affiliate faculty member in the Department of Psychology at the University of Hawaii, did various studies on the effects of religion on the youth in a society. In this research, Dr. Weaver found that in a society where the majority of young people are inclined to religion and spirituality, there are lesser crimes among the youth as compared to a society whose youth has little interest in religion. According to Dr. Weaver, such studies reveal that religion and spirituality are highly valuable to many people in times of crisis, trauma, and grief, and prayers help people in coping with trauma and crisis.[271]

Dr. Weaver also noted another study that compared 33,397 high school students in 112 mid-western communities in USA. The researchers in this study measured sixteen troublesome behaviours in seven areas: tobacco use, drug abuse, alcohol use, sexual activity, depression and suicide, anti-social behaviours, and school problems. The study revealed that the communities whose majority of teenagers attended religious services more often were twice as likely to be among the communities with the least problem behaviours among their youth. Dr. Weaver concludes:

> Nurturing forms of faith provide a buffer against hardships and losses, diminish isolation and encourage hopefulness while offering an active support system.[272]

Commenting on the findings of Dr. Weaver's research, Dr. James Garbarino, author and Professor at Loyola University Chicago, states that

one effective way of saving our young people from 'social toxicity' is to nurture love for religion and worship in them so that they develop compassion and care for other members of the society.[273]

It is true that attachment to religion and worship promotes maturity of thought and a sense of direction in an individual. However, Dr. Weaver and Dr. Garbarino have noted these experiences based on their knowledge of the influence of Christianity in a society. They may be totally unaware of the power of Islam to change the hearts of people. Islam, being a complete way of life, totally transforms the lives of those who embrace it. The people who accept Islam could have been drug addicts, indulged in heavy metal music, or living in a prison, but as soon as they convert to Islam, a complete change takes place in their lives.

We can look at the example of Afro-Americans living in USA as an example. American novelist, poet, and social critic James Baldwin brilliantly describes the agony of the Black American addict as follows:

> I remember my buddies of years ago in the hallways with their wine and their whisky, and their tears, in hallways still frozen on the needle, and my brother saying to me once, if Harlem didn't have so many churches and junkies, there'd be blood flowing in streets.[274]

However, after such drug addicts convert to Islam, embrace the concept of the oneness of Allah, and absorb the spiritual message and teachings of Islam, their lives immediately change in ways that all the governmental, educational, social, and welfare institutions fail to achieve.

Attachment to religion is a basic human necessity, but the beauty of Islam lies in the fact that once a person (whether a new Muslim or a repenting Muslim) becomes devoted, he or she begins to see a sense of purpose in life, which is a very powerful feeling. The secularism of our

modern age has deprived humans of seeing any real meaning or purpose in life, creating an 'existential vacuum' and 'existential anxiety' within people. Viktor Frankl, the most influential existential psychologist of the twentieth century, beautifully summed up this concept. While he suffered through the bitter experiences of living in concentration camps in Nazi Germany, Frankl carefully studied the psychology of prisoners for months. He concludes the following in his book *Man's Search for Meaning*:

> Man's search for meaning is a primary force in his life and not a 'secondary rationalization' of instinctual drives. This meaning is unique and specific in that it must be fulfilled by him alone; only then does it achieve a significance which will satisfy his own will to meaning.[275]

Frankl asserts that religion is one of the greatest forces in giving meaning to human beings' continued suffering. This concept of an 'existential vacuum' propounded by Viktor Frankl is not new to Islam, though. When a person does not believe in the oneness of Allah, attributes partners to Him, and does not believe in the afterlife, he or she suffers from an 'existential vacuum' which results in 'existential anxiety'. The Qur'an tells us that people who forget their Creator are like those who have lost their own identity or existence. Since they forgot the Creator and Cherisher, Allah made them forget their own selves. In the words of the Qur'an:

{Do not be like those who forgot Allah, so He caused them to forget themselves. It is they who are the evildoers.} *(al-Ḥashr 59: 19)*

When Muslim youth turn to Islam and become practicing Muslims, they not only feel a sense of direction in their life, but their whole worldview also changes with it. In this regard, the value of the prescribed five daily prayers cannot be over-emphasized, especially congregational prayers. In the Qur'an, Allah (the Exalted) mentions the following about prayer:

{…and establish prayer, for verily prayer keeps [one] away from obscenity and wickedness...} *(al-'Ankaboot 29: 45)*

The Qur'an has described this quality of prayer as something that restrains a person from committing evil deeds. There is no other form of worship better than prayer for morally training an individual. Someone performing prayer has to stand before God five times a day, every day. This refreshes in one's mind the concept of accountability before Allah the Almighty. This is why when non-practicing Muslims turn towards religion, the very first thing they begin to do is perform prayers five times a day. People who offer prayers regularly are better able to enjoin good and refrain from evil in the society. Prayer prevents Muslim youth from indulging in sins which is why Muslim parents should encourage their Muslim youth to offer prayers regularly. Muslim youth should also try to abstain from a materialistic lifestyle before and after marriage, as such a lifestyle will only instil them with anxiety and a desire to accumulate more and more things.

Importance of staying in the company of righteous people

Human beings are social creatures, and they are receptive to the effects of the company around them. Staying in the company of corrupt people corrupts a person in one way or another. On the other hand, staying in the company of pious people has positive effects on a person. Therefore, Muslim youth should strive to keep company with good, righteous, and pious people, and learn from them and their experiences. If parents want to reform their corrupted Muslim youth, they must change the environment of their children first. When one sits in the company of pious and God-fearing people, one learns good habits from them, adopts their Islamic etiquette, and becomes steadfast on the path to righteousness.

In the Qur'an, the story of the young people of the cave is mentioned in Soorat al-Kahf. The young people of the cave were pious adolescents living in a very civilized city. However, their surrounding environment and society was corrupt. The youth realized that if they stayed in the company of the sinful people of their society, they would become desensitized to immorality and compromise their own values. They decided to change their environment and went to a cave where Allah made them sleep for a very long time. Directly after mentioning this story, Allah commands us to stay in the company of pious people, as that is one of the themes of this chapter:

{Content yourself with [the company of] those who call upon their Lord every morning and afternoon, seeking [to see, in the hereafter] His Countenance, and do not turn your eyes away from them, desiring the adornment of the life of this world. And do not obey him whose heart We have made heedless of Our remembrance, who follows his own whims and desires, and is reckless in his deeds.} *(al-Kahf 18: 28)*

Similarly, Allah commands all the believers to stay in the company of those who are truthful in their words and deeds:

{O you who believe, fear Allah and be with the truthful.} *(at-Tawbah 9: 119)*

Our beloved Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) said in one hadith:

«الرَّجُلُ عَلَى دِينِ خَلِيلِهِ، فَلْيَنْظُرْ أَحَدُكُمْ مَنْ يُخَالِلُ.»

«A person is upon the religion of his close friend so beware of whom you befriend.» (Recorded by at-Tirmidhi and Abu Dâwood; al-Albâni graded it acceptable)[276]

It must be noted that it is not just the physical presence of friends that constitutes a person's company. In current times, friends on social media and in chat rooms are also included in the company that a person keeps, and

we should be conscious of their influence as well. A corrupt or bad online community of friends is as disastrous for the youth as their real-life friends. In fact, online friends could be more dangerous because they are hidden from view most of the time. Beware when others send you online invitations to become their friend; their corrupting influence could hinder your faith in Allah.

Another very interesting and thought-provoking hadith about the importance of keeping good company and staying in a pious environment is narrated by Abu Sa‘eed al-Khudri (may Allah be pleased with him). He reported that Allah’s Messenger (bpuh) said:

«There was a person before you who had killed ninety-nine people. He inquired about the learned individuals of the world (who could show him the way to salvation) and was directed to a monk. He came to him and told him that he had killed ninety-nine people. He asked him whether or not there was any scope for his repentance to be accepted.

The monk responded in the negative.

The man killed him also and completed 100 (murders). He then asked about the learned individuals of the earth and was directed to a scholar. He went to him and told him that he had killed 100 people. He asked him whether or not there was any scope for his repentance to be accepted.

The scholar said: Yes; what stands between you and repentance? You better go to such and such land; people are devoted to prayer and worship there, and you should also worship along with them. Do not come back to this land of yours since it was an evil land (for you).

The man went away, but he had hardly covered half the distance when he died.

There was a dispute between the angels of mercy and the angels of punishment.

The angels of mercy said: This man has come as a penitent, remorseful to Allah.

The angels of punishment said: He has done no good at all.

Another angel came in the form of a human being in order to decide between them.

He said: Measure the land to which he has drawn near.

They measured it and found him nearer to the land where he intended to go (the land of piety). So the angels of mercy took possession of his soul.

According to Qatâdah, al-Ḥasan told him that it was said to them that as death approached him, he crawled upon his chest (and managed) to slip in the land of mercy.» (Muslim)[277]

In the version recorded by Imam Bukhari, it is also added:

«Allah ordered the village (towards which he was going) to come closer to him (the land got reduced in size), and He ordered the village (from where he had come) to go far away. Then He ordered the angels to measure the distances between his body and the two villages. He was found to be one span closer to the village (he was going to) which is why he was forgiven.» (Bukhari)[278]

Commentators of this hadith have explained that the worshipper (to whom the man went first) lacked knowledge and did not know how to reform a sinner who wanted to repent. As a consequence, he lost his life. On the contrary, when that murderer of 100 people asked a scholar for advice, the scholar knew very well that it would be impossible for the murderer to

repent and stay steadfast on his repentance if he stayed in the company of evil people and a morally polluted environment. The scholar told the man «Do not come back to this land of yours since it was an evil land (for you)».

If he stayed in the same environment, chances were high that this person's corrupt friends would pull him back into committing the same sins he had done previously. This is why the scholar advised the man to go to the village where people were devoted to prayer and worship. Once he was there, this man would also worship along with them.

Importance of time

Youth is the time period in development when the human body is at its prime. The body has finished developing, and all the body's systems are functioning optimally. Young people are also at the height of their cognitive abilities with maximum capacity for rapid and accurate memory, thought processing, and information analysis. This is why youth is the best time for seeking knowledge. The young men and women who waste time and do not seek knowledge during this critical period in their lives can never compensate for their loss. Muslim youth must understand that when it comes to seeking knowledge, it is 'now or never'. An Arab poet rightly said:

Whatever is in the past is gone,
and the future lies hidden in the unseen,

The time for you to do any work is the present in which you exist.

Imam Abu Ḥâmid al-Ghazâli had a young student learning from him. When the student completed his education with al-Ghazâli and started getting ready to depart, he requested his teacher to give him valuable advice which would serve as a beacon for him later. Imam al-Ghazâli dictated his

famous long letter *Ayyuhal Walad* (O my beloved son!) addressed to his departing student. In this letter, Imam al-Ghazâli reminded his student that if a person engages in time-wasting, frivolous activities and amusements, this is a sign of the wrath of Allah on that person. Imam al-Ghazâli stresses on the importance of time and action in this letter as he states:

> My dear beloved son! Knowledge without actions is madness and actions without knowledge are useless. The knowledge that today, does not keep you away from sins and that does not evoke in you the desire to obey Allah, remember, will not save you tomorrow from Hellfire. If you do not perform righteous deeds today and do not make up for the time you wasted in the past then on the Day of Judgment you will be saying:
>
> Send us back [to the world, O our Lord!] so that we [can] perform the righteous deeds.
>
> Then it will be said to you:
>
> O you the mindless one! That is where you are coming from.[279]

We as Muslims should feel regretful for the time we have lost in vain pursuits and should try to make up for that lost time. We should actually shed tears over the time not spent in worshipping Allah or seeking knowledge. The Prophet (bpuh) informed us about how much we lose when we waste our time. He said:

«There are two blessings that many people squander: health and time.» (Bukhari)

Soon the time will come when, on the Day of Judgement, we will stand before Allah and be questioned about how we spent our time. Did we spend our time wisely or did we just kill it on amusements, movies, chat rooms, video games, online networking, and other vain or empty pursuits? The

priority of Muslim youth should be seeking knowledge and contributing to the Islamic society. In this regard, Imam ash-Shâfi‘i gives an excellent piece of advice to the Muslim youth in his poetry:

> *The one who did not taste the bitterness of seeking knowledge has to drink the humility of ignorance for the rest of his life,*
> *The one who did not seek knowledge in his young age should get ready to say the takbeer*[280] *for his funeral (meaning, consider the person as dead),*
> *By Allah, a youth's personality is based on knowledge and piety, and if these two qualities are not found in a youth, there is no weight in his personality.*[281]

Beware of crowd following, M&M, and pop culture

For many youth today, peer pressure is huge. They are under enormous pressure to assimilate and blend with the popular culture and the most prevalent fashions of their peers at school, in college, or in the society. Whatever the majority and the media (M&M) follow is considered to be the 'gold standard'. Muslim youth all over the world are vulnerable to this phenomenon due to globalization. Young people are far more receptive than older people. While this is a praiseworthy quality in terms of accepting the message of truth, this can also become a highly destructive quality if they do not exercise caution when dealing with peer pressure. Almost every sin that attracts the youth – media addiction, smoking, music, premarital love affairs, profanity, violence, fornication, and gangs – has peer pressure as its driving force.

As mentioned earlier in this book, peer pressure is not a new phenomenon. Young people, by their nature, are very quick to adopt the attitude and behaviour of their peers. It is not appropriate for young Muslim men and women to possess this herd mentality or to surrender to it. ‘Abdullâh ibn Mas‘ood (may Allah be pleased with him), a Companion of the Messenger of Allah (bpuh), gave some advice in this regard, which is especially applicable to every Muslim youth today.

‘Abdullâh ibn Mas‘ood (may Allah be pleased with him) was a teenager when he embraced Islam in Makkah. He was one of the youths around the Messenger of Allah (bpuh). He advises:

> Do not be a crowd follower who says: I am with the people. If they follow the right path, I will do the same. If they go astray, I will do the same. No! You should stand firm on righteousness when people do righteous deeds and stay away from evil deeds when they commit evil deeds.[282]

Islam teaches our Muslim youth that they should not be impressed by the prevalence of evil around them even if it has reached the extent that deviance appears normal in the society. This is typical of popular culture most of the time. The reason for the widespread appeal of pop culture to the public is its superficial and sensationalist nature. However, the fact that the majority of people are following a certain sinful fashion or committing an evil deed is not a justification to follow that practice. This is because the Qur’an mentions:

{If you were to obey **most** of those who are on earth, they would lead you astray from the path of Allah. They follow nothing but conjecture and they do nothing but lie.} *(al-An‘âm 6: 116)*

{...And verily many people are indeed rebellious.} *(al-Mâ’idah 5: 49)*

The touchstone and ‘gold standard’ of truth is not ‘the majority and the media’ (M&M) but it is ‘the Qur’an and Sunnah’ (Q&S). Any act or custom that passes the criteria set forth by the Qur’an and Sunnah is on the right path, even if the herd is following another path. The herd of people following certain popular fashions could be a bunch of lemmings heading towards a cliff. They could be heading towards mass destruction because they failed to use their intellect. Muslim youth must not act like a bunch of lemmings. They must act in a way that is much nobler than this.

Advantages of obeying Allah in your youth

Turning to Allah at a younger age is certainly better than doing so in old age. For this reason, Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) advised us to benefit from our youth before we grow old:

«Take advantage of five things before five things: your youth before your old age…» (A sound hadith recorded by al-Ḥâkim)[283]

In another hadith, the Messenger of Allah (bpuh) praised the pious youth in the following words:

«يَعْجَبُ رَبُّكَ مِنَ الشَّابِّ لَيْسَتْ لَهُ صَبْوَةٌ.»

«Your Lord feels delighted (in the way that suits Him) about a young person who does not incline towards his desires.» (A sound hadith recorded by Aḥmad)[284]

There is a huge difference between the Muslim who starts to practice Islam at a young age and the one who repents and turns to Islam at an older age. Youth is the time of exertion and optimum health. It is easier for a young person to stay awake at night to seek Islamic knowledge and offer

early morning prayers. It is also easier for the youth to fast during Ramadan and in other months. Young bodies can bear hardships in the path of learning and teaching Islam, and performing good works. Young people do not have as many responsibilities on their shoulders as older people do, such as the financial responsibility of taking care of a large family or other social responsibilities. When young men or women repent to Allah for their previous sins, start practicing Islam, and continue to practice it until the end of their life, the practice of Islam becomes second nature to them. Islam becomes infused in their character, and they become an inseparable part of it. To a large extent, the matters are in their hands. Young people can choose Islamic spouses. They can make it clear to their parents that they will only marry a religious person. They have their whole lives ahead of them in which they can raise their children in accordance with the Book of Allah and the Sunnah of His Prophet (bpuh). Young people devoted to Islam can choose a profession with permissible earnings and avoid any career involving forbidden wealth. Young people can choose friends who are also practicing Muslims like them and maintain ties of friendship with them for the sake of Allah for the rest of their lives because they share the same values and beliefs.

The situation is a bit different when someone becomes religious at an older age. It is true that the door of repentance is open for all Muslims until their death, and it is never too late to repent. However, for those who waste their youth in frivolous pursuits and turn to practice Islam only in their old age, there are many hardships to overcome. We all know that as the years of our life pass by, our responsibilities accumulate and we have to solve the problems of our family, children, and relatives, all of which take considerable portions of our time. In old age, our body does not have the strength of youth any more. Once we reach the age of forty, our bodily functions begin to decline, albeit slowly. Different diseases start to attack our bodies in old age. It becomes exceedingly difficult to seek Islamic

knowledge for hours and hours, to fast on hot days, and to bear the difficulties faced in the field of teaching Islam and spreading good works.

To add insult to injury, when older people turn to religion, sometimes a secular and deviant husband becomes a pain in the neck for a woman who has just started practicing the teachings of Islam, and at other times, a fashion-loving, non-modest wife becomes a thorn in the flesh of an old husband who has just repented. Sometimes both husband and wife repent to Allah at an older age and start practicing Islam, but their children refuse to follow them because they grew up in an environment where they were not exposed to their parents practicing Islam. In other instances, when an older husband and wife repent and begin to lead an Islamic life, they have to cut social ties with their materialistic, worldly-life-loving family friends. Sometimes, when an older person decides to repent and live an Islamic life, he has to sacrifice his career because his earnings are based on interest or other impermissible means of wealth, and it is not easy to look for an alternate means of income at an old age. Of course, repentance can be done any time before death, but the fact remains that repentance at an old age is an uphill task; only very few people, perhaps not even one in a thousand, have an indomitable willpower at an old age to remain steadfast in the face of all the hardships described above, if and when they decide to lead a life in complete accordance with the Islamic injunctions.

Allah will preserve the physical and mental faculties of the young men and women who spend their youth obeying and worshipping Him when they reach their old age. We know this because Allah promises in the Qur'an:

{Therefore remember Me; I will remember you. Give thanks to Me, and do not be ungrateful.} *(al-Baqarah 2: 152)*

Ibn ‘Abbâs (may Allah be pleased with both of them) was once seated behind Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) on the same mount. The Prophet (bpuh) said to him:

«يَا غُلاَمُ إِنِّي أُعَلِّمُكَ كَلِمَاتٍ، احْفَظِ اللَّهَ يَحْفَظْكَ، احْفَظِ اللَّهَ تَجِدْهُ تُجَاهَكَ...»

«O young man, I shall teach you some words (of advice). Be mindful of Allah, and He will take care of you. Be mindful of Allah, and you will find Him in front of you…» (Recorded by at-Tirmidhi; graded sound by al-Albâni)[285]

Similarly, Imam Ibn Rajab al-Ḥanbali states the following regarding the importance of obeying Allah in our youth:

> Whoever remembers Allah when he is young and strong will be taken care of by Him when he grows old and has become weak; Allah will bless him with good hearing, eyesight, strength, and intelligence. One of the scholars who lived past the age of one hundred years and enjoyed good strength and brainpower jumped up in an active manner one day and was asked about it.
>
> He replied: I kept my physical abilities away from sins and evil deeds when I was young, and Allah has preserved them for me now that I have grown old.
>
> An opposite scenario is also seen quite often. One of the righteous scholars from our past saw an old man begging from people.
>
> He said: This is a weak man who ignored Allah when he was young. Now Allah is ignoring him when he has grown old.[286]

Muslim youth and the three R’s: Read, repent, and rise

We would like our Muslim youth to achieve a balance in this troubled world. In order to do this, they must have a balanced personality. A complete Muslim personality can only be achieved when there is a balance of three attributes in the character, namely, knowledge, purification of soul (spirituality), and activism. This requirement for balance has its basis in the Qur'an itself. The first three revelations were from the three chapters titled Soorat al-'Alaq, Soorat al-Muzzammil, and Soorat al-Muddath-thir, as noted by the famous commentator of the Qur'an al-Ḥâfidh Jalâl ad-Deen as-Suyooṭi.[287] These three verses from the three chapters of the Qur'an provide a blueprint for an ideal Muslim character. The three verses are as follows:

Read

{Read in the name of your Lord Who created.} *(al-'Alaq 96: 1)*

Repent

{Stand up in prayer throughout the night, except a little.} *(al-Muzzammil 73: 2)*

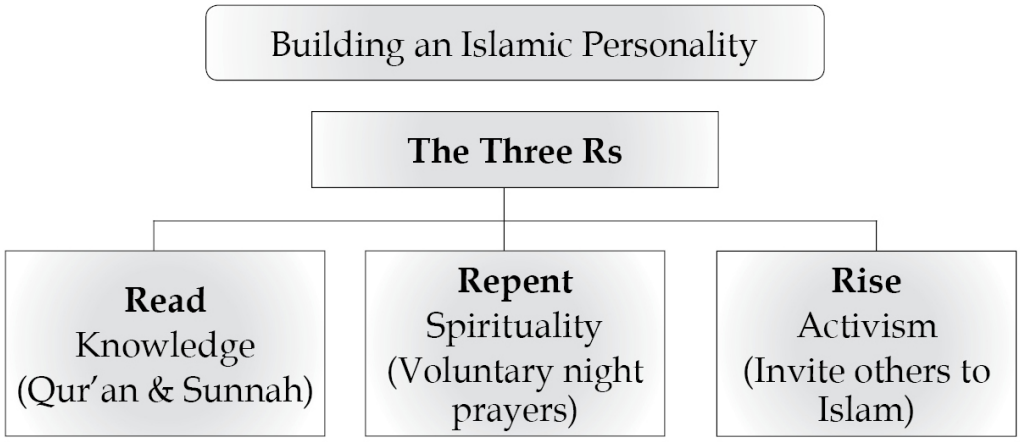
Rise

{Arise and warn, your Lord magnify.} *(al-Muddath-thir 74: 2-3)*

The Muslim youth who would like to become exemplary personalities and spread the message of Islam must follow these three R's: **read**, **repent**, and **rise**.

The first commandment 'read' means to acquire Islamic knowledge. To 'repent' means to perform voluntary late night prayers and repent in the early hours of the morning in order to purify ourselves. To 'rise' means to rise and convey the message of Islam to other people. A Muslim should be a living example of 'read, repent, and rise', which can be translated into

three concepts, namely knowledge, purification of self (spirituality), and activism. These concepts are described in the following diagram that shows how one can build an Islamic personality:[288]



The first commandment 'read' means that Muslim youth must seek the knowledge of Islam, and this knowledge must be based on the Qur'an and authentic Sunnah of Allah's Messenger (bpuh). Allah mentions:

{...For Allah has sent down to you the Book and wisdom, and has taught you what you did not know. And the grace of Allah toward you is great indeed.} *(an-Nisâ' 4: 113)*

Knowledge is the foundation of everything. Our actions are based on pure intentions and true knowledge. Nothing can become complete unless it is founded on authentic knowledge. In *Ṣaḥeeḥ al-Bukhâri*, Imam Bukhari gave the following title to a chapter: *Bâb al-'Ilm Qabl al-Qawl wal-'Amal* ("It is essential to know a thing first before saying or acting upon it"). He did so because he wanted to accentuate the point that no action is complete without knowledge at its base. Only when our Muslim youth have true Islamic knowledge will they be able to spread the message of Islam, because that is the quality of our beloved Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) that the Qur'an describes:

{Say [O Muhammad]: This is my way; I call to Allah on the basis of clear evidence – I and those who follow me. Glory be to Allah! And I am not one of those who ascribe partners to Allah.} *(Yoosuf 12: 108)*

Repentance is an act of worship that connects one's heart to Allah and enables one to overcome the temptations of life and strive against one's self, while other people are comfortably sleeping in their beds. Getting up early to perform voluntary late night prayers requires strong determination. Muslim youth who possess such determination will be able to use their knowledge and activism to reform the society in a positive way. The hours of early morning are also the best time for repentance, as the Qur'an mentions:

{Verily, the righteous will be amidst gardens and springs, receiving what their Lord will bestow upon them, because before that they had been doers of good. They used to sleep but little at night, and before dawn, they would seek forgiveness.} *(adh-Dhâriyât 51: 15-18)*

Similarly, in Soorat al-Furqân, Allah describes those praying the early morning prayers as follows:

{The true slaves of the Most Gracious are those who walk humbly and with dignity on the earth and, when the ignorant address them, they say words of peace; those who spend the night prostrating and standing before their Lord.} *(al-Furqân 25: 63-64)*

As human beings, we all make mistakes. Young age is filled with temptations; many young men and women fall into Satan's trap and commit sins. However, it is possible for our Muslim youth to achieve purity of heart through repentance. The door of repentance is wide open as long as we are not in the throes of death, as the Prophet (bpuh) said:

«Allah accepts the repentance of His servant as long as death has not reached his collar bone.» (A good hadith recorded by at-Tirmidhi)

In several places in the Qur'an, Allah encourages human beings to repent:

{Say [Allah says]: O My slaves who have transgressed against themselves [by sinning greatly], do not despair of the mercy of Allah, for verily Allah forgives all sins. Verily, it is He Who is the Oft-Forgiving, Most Merciful.} *(az-Zumar 39: 53)*

{O you who believe, turn to Allah in sincere repentance; it may be that your Lord will absolve you of your bad deeds and admit you to gardens through which rivers flow…} *(at-Taḥreem 66: 8)*

If Muslim youth commit evil but then repent sincerely and change their life for the better, Allah has certainly promised to grant them mercy and forgiveness. He loves those who repent, and He showers His blessings and favours upon those who sincerely repent after committing sins. By purifying their souls of these sins, Muslim youth will be able to achieve success in their Islamic activism.

The third commandment 'rise' refers to Islamic activism. This means inviting others to the way of Allah and to believe in His oneness. This is an invitation to follow the commandments of Islam, do good deeds, honour the rights of others, establish justice among people, and command good and forbid evil in the society. The goal of Islamic activism is to strive and work for the betterment of this world, to benefit humankind, and to save them from hellfire. Islamic activism holds a very important status in Islam. Many Qur'anic verses and hadiths make it clear that Islamic work and calling others to the way of Allah is obligatory for the Muslims. The Qur'an commands:

{Let there arise from among you a group of people inviting to all that is good, enjoining what is right, and forbidding what is wrong. They are the ones who will be successful.} *(Âl ‘Imrân 3: 104)*

Likewise, in the following verse, the Qur’an highly praises people who are doing Islamic work:

{Who is better in speech than one who calls people to Allah, does righteous deeds, and says: Verily, I am one of those who submit to Allah [in Islam]?} *(Fuṣṣilat 41: 33)*

On the day of Khaybar, the Prophet (bpuh) advised ‘Ali ibn Abi Ṭâlib to first invite people to Islam and then inform them about what is obligatory for them based on Allah’s rights in Islam. Then he said to ‘Ali:

«فَوَاللهِ لَأَنْ يَهْدِيَ اللهُ بِكَ رَجُلًا وَاحِدًا، خَيْرٌ لَكَ مِنْ أَنْ يَكُونَ لَكَ حُمْرُ النَّعَمِ.»

«By Allah, if Allah guides a single man through you, it is better for you than having red camels.» (Bukhari)[289]

Note: Red camels to the Arabs of that time were equivalent to expensive cars like Rolls-Royce and Mercedes-Benz of today.

Islamic activism also involves bringing social justice to the society by taking part in acts of righteousness and forbidding acts of disobedience to Allah – a quality that makes the Muslim nation the best of all nations. Allah mentions:

{You are the best community ever brought forth for [the benefit of] humankind; you enjoin what is right, and forbid what is wrong, and you believe in Allah...} *(Âl ‘Imrân 3: 110)*

Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) commanded us to be socially active in the following way:

«مَنْ رَأَى مِنْكُمْ مُنْكَرًا فَلْيُغَيِّرْهُ بِيَدِهِ، فَإِنْ لَمْ يَسْتَطِعْ فَبِلِسَانِهِ، فَإِنْ لَمْ يَسْتَطِعْ فَبِقَلْبِهِ، وَذَلِكَ أَضْعَفُ الْإِيمَانِ.»

«Whoever among you sees an evil action should change it with his hand; if he is unable to do so, then (he should change it) with his tongue, and if he is unable to do that, then (he should change it) with his heart, and that is the weakest (level of) faith.» (Muslim)[290]

Muslim youth must be a living example of 'read, repent, and rise', that is, knowledge, purification of self (spirituality), and activism. To act upon only one of the three commandments in the absence of the other two will result in an incomplete Islamic personality. Activism without knowledge and purification has no foundation. Knowledge without action is a means without an end. Similarly, knowledge without activism, humility, and continuous repentance to Allah is useless.[291] Muslim youth must bear in mind that they can be students of Islamic knowledge while engaging in self-purification by practicing the commands of Islam and performing Islamic activism by calling people to the way of Allah. Seeking knowledge, purifying one's self, and taking part in Islamic work are not conflicting pursuits since Islamic activism is the fruit of seeking Islamic knowledge and acting upon that knowledge.

The three men trapped in the cave – role models for young Muslim men

Youth is a period when people are easily attracted to worldly enticements. Three of the greatest human temptations are:

1. Love of the opposite sex
2. Love of children

3. Love of wealth

The Qur'an mentions these three temptations as follows:

{Fair-seeming to men is the love of pleasures, such as women and sons, heaped-up hoards of gold and silver, fine horses, and livestock and well-tilled land. These are the enjoyments of the life of this world; but with Allah is the best place to return to.} *(Âl 'Imrân 3: 14)*

The following story mentioned in an authentic hadith gives us the example of three role models for all Muslim youth. These three men faced the three most important temptations: love of the opposite sex, love of children, and love of wealth. However, they feared Allah and despite the strength of temptation, they chose the path of obedience to Allah. These youth controlled themselves for the sake of pleasing Him. They remembered Allah in good times, and so He remembered them in their time of difficulty and saved them when they got trapped in the most difficult situation.

This hadith of Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) was narrated by Ibn 'Umar. Part of this hadith stated:

«Three men from among those who were before you set out together till they reached a cave at night and entered it. A large rock rolled down the mountain and closed the mouth of the cave.

They said (to each other): Nothing can save you from this rock unless you invoke Allah by giving reference to one righteous deed you have done (for Allah's sake only).

One of them said: O Allah! I had old parents, and I never provided my family (wife, children, and so on) with milk before them. One day, by chance, I was delayed. When I came home late (at night), they had gone to sleep. I milked the sheep for them and took the milk to them, but I found

them sleeping. I disliked providing my family with milk before them. I waited for them with the bowl of milk in my hand, and I kept on waiting for them to get up till the day dawned. Then they got up and drank the milk. O Allah! If I did that for Your sake only, please relieve us from our critical situation caused by this rock.

The rock shifted a little but they could not get out.

The second man said: O Allah! I had a cousin who was the dearest to me of all the people. I wanted to have sexual relations with her but she refused. Later, she had a hard time in a year of famine. She came to me, and I gave her 120 gold coins on the condition that she would not resist my desire to which she agreed. When I was about to fulfil my desire, she said: It is illegal for you to outrage my chastity except by legitimate marriage. I thought it a sin to have sexual intercourse with her and left her though she was the dearest to me of all the people. I also left the gold I had given her. O Allah! If I did that for Your sake only, please relieve us from the present calamity.

The rock shifted a little more but still they could not get out from there.

Then the third man said: O Allah! I employed a few labourers. I paid them their wages but one man did not take his wages and went away. I invested his wages and got much property thereby. (Then after some time) he came and said: O Allah's slave! Pay me my wages.

I said to him: All the camels, cows, sheep, and slaves you see are yours.

He said: O Allah's slave! Do not mock me.

I said: I am not mocking you.

He took the entire herd, drove them away, and left nothing. O Allah! If I did that for Your sake only, please relieve us from the present suffering.

Then the rock shifted completely, and they got out and walked away.» (Bukhari)[292]

Hâjar (wife of Prophet Ibrâheem) – a role model for young Muslim women

Hâjar was the second wife of Prophet Ibrâheem. Since his first wife Sârah was unable to conceive a child, she gave her handmaiden Hâjar to Prophet Ibrâheem (pbuh) to take as his wife. Hâjar was a youth at the time, and soon after her marriage, she gave birth to Ismâ‘eel. Ibn Katheer states:

> Ibrâheem (pbuh) took Hâjar and their son, Ismâ‘eel, and travelled to a place known today as Makkah. It has been said that Ismâ‘eel was still a baby at that time.
>
> When Ibrâheem left them and started to walk back, Hâjar clung to his clothes and asked: O Ibrâheem, where are you going, leaving us here without anyone to take care of us? Ibrâheem did not answer. When she repeatedly asked him the same question and did not get any answer, she asked him: Did Allah order you to leave us here? He replied: Yes. She said: In that case, He will never leave us to perish.
>
> Imam Bukhari reported on the authority of Ibn ‘Abbâs who said: The first woman to use a girdle was the mother of Ismâ‘eel. She used it to remove her tracks to escape from Sârah. Then, Ibrâheem took her and Ismâ‘eel, while she was still breastfeeding him, and brought them to the Ka‘bah near a tree on the well of Zamzam. This is the most elevated place in the mosque today. At that point in history, there was no person and no water source in Makkah. Ibrâheem (pbuh) left them there (as per

Allah's orders) with a leather bag containing some dates and a water-skin containing some water.[293]

When Ibrâheem turned to depart, Ismâ'eel's mother followed him and asked: Where are you going, leaving us behind in this valley where there is no human or anything else? She repeated the question several times, but Ibrâheem did not turn towards her. Finally, she asked: Has Allah ordered you? He replied: Yes. She said: Then He will not let us perish. After saying this, she returned and left Ibrâheem.

Ibrâheem kept walking until he came to a narrow pass of the mountain, where he could not be seen. There, he turned his face towards the Ka'bah, raised his hands and supplicated, uttering the words mentioned in the following Qur'anic verse:

{Our Lord, I have settled some of my offspring in a valley without cultivation, by Your Sacred House, O our Lord, so that they may establish prayer. So make the hearts of some people incline towards them, and provide them with fruits, so that they may give thanks.} *(Ibrâheem 14: 37)*

Ismâ'eel's mother continued to suck Ismâ'eel, while she drank the water from the water skin. When all the water finished, she and her son both became thirsty. She started looking at him suffering in pain. Finally, she left him to search for water because she could no longer bear his cries.

She found the Mount Ṣafâ closest to her. She climbed up on it to see if there was anybody in sight for help. However, she did not see anyone. She descended from Ṣafâ until she reached the bottom of the valley. Then, she tucked up her clothes and ran into the valley like a distressed person. She ran till she passed the valley and reached Mount Marwah. There, again, she climbed it and looked around, hoping to see someone. Again, she could not see anyone. She repeated this routine seven times.

At that point, she heard a sound. This was the sound of an angel, who had struck the ground (at the place now known as Zamzam well) with his wing till water started coming out. She tried to gather the water and then when it kept gushing out, she asked it to stop.

Ibn ‘Abbâs has related that the Prophet (bpuh) said:

«May Allah have mercy upon Ismâ‘eel’s mother. Had she let the Zamzam flow or not scooped the water, it would have become a flowing stream.

He said: She drank from it and then suckled her baby. The angel said to her: Do not fear getting lost, for there will be a house of Allah right here, which this child of yours and his father will build. Verily, Allah does not neglect His people.» (Bukhari)[294]

Today, the rites and rituals of Hajj, especially the practices of walking back and forth between the hills of Ṣafâ and Marwah, throwing stones at the pillars in Minâ, and drinking Zamzam water remind us of Hâjar and her great sacrifices. She decided to stay along with her infant son Ismâ‘eel in the barren valley of Makkah because it was Allah’s command, and thus Allah accepted the sacrifice of this humble woman.

Hâjar gave birth to one of the greatest civilizations on this earth. Originally from Egypt, her name means ‘the city’ in her mother language, and Allah turned Hâjar’s name into a living reality. Scientists of history and sociology tell us that almost every great civilization originated at a place where there was water. For example, the Indus Valley Civilization of the sub-continent, the ancient Egyptian civilization, the Babylonian civilization, and many others, all had their foundations near the Indus, Nile, and Euphrates rivers, respectively. After all, every living thing has originated from water, as mentioned in the Qur’an:

{…And We have made from water every living thing. Will they not then believe?} *(al-Anbiyâ' 21: 30)*

Similarly, the actual beginning of the Arab nation at Makkah happened with the inception of the spring of Zamzam water, which was made possible by the love of Hâjar for her son Ismâ'eel and her strong trust in Allah. The first residents of the valley of Makkah were a mother Hâjar and her infant son Ismâ'eel.

When the fountain of Zamzam flourished in the valley of Makkah, the Arab nomad tribe of Jurham was directed there after seeing birds flying above the valley from afar – a sign of the presence of water in that area. They were surprised to find a woman with her infant son sitting right next to the fountain of Zamzam. They realized that she must be a blessed woman, and they sought Hâjar's permission to settle in the valley of Makkah. Later on, when Prophet Ismâ'eel grew up, he ended up marrying one of the women from the tribe of Jurham. Hâjar lived up to the age of ninety, and her blessed presence was a source of inspiration for all in the valley of Makkah. She used to teach the scriptures of Ibrâheem to the children of the Jurham tribe. In addition, she also taught the children to write because, according to some narrations, the first person to start writing in Makkah was, in fact, Hâjar, the wife of Prophet Ibrâheem.[295]

The centre of the Arab civilization was Makkah, which was founded by Hâjar. She was the one who taught the art of writing to the Arabs settled in that valley, and it is through the pen that knowledge is preserved and transferred to the succeeding generations. If we take this concept to the level of the human body, it is the mother's heartbeat that actually jump-starts the heart of the unborn child in her womb. Scientist and researcher Paul Pearsall, Ph.D., wrote that, "the mother's heart energy conveyed in primal sound waves contains the information that is the code that jump-

starts our life."[296] Similar to this phenomenon, but on a much bigger level, it was Hâjar who jump-started the Arabs of Makkah by teaching them to write, and it was these Arabs who became the Muslim community in later centuries. Hâjar is truly regarded as *Umm al-'Arab* (the mother of the Arabs) but she was more than a great mother. She was also a great teacher and from her progeny came the leader of all the prophets, Prophet Muhammad (bpuh), who himself was a great teacher.

Indeed, in the life of Hâjar is a great example for Muslim women. She gave birth to and raised a whole civilization but in spite of that her biggest goal in life was not to forsake her family in search of personal success; her biggest goal was her role as a mother.

Today, radical feminists are creating and promoting empty slogans and catchy phrases to 'liberate' Muslim women from their domestic duties. When Muslim mothers forsake their domestic duties altogether, they are not available to raise children as true believers.

Today, the success of young Muslim women lies in following the life example of Hâjar, the wife of Prophet Ibrâheem. She was one of the greatest women in history, and her only desire in the last part of her life was that when death approached her, her eyes were staring at the Kaaba, the House of Allah.[297]

Muṣ'ab ibn 'Umayr – a role model for wealthy Muslim youth

The life of Muṣ'ab ibn 'Umayr (may Allah be pleased with him) is another role model for the Muslim youth. Muṣ'ab was a very handsome, tall, blue-eyed youth of Makkah, and his father was a rich merchant. Muṣ'ab grew up in a luxurious lifestyle, enjoying the finest foods, expensive clothes, and the

best perfumes; he would wear the costliest shoes. Above all, he was the best-dressed young man of Makkah and the focal point of everyone's eyes. Whenever Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) talked about him, he said:

«Nobody is more handsome in Makkah than Muṣ'ab. No person in the city is better clothed and fed than Muṣ'ab. No child is brought up with more affection and love than him.» (Recorded by Abu Nu'aym and al-Ḥâkim; authenticated by al-Ḥâkim)

In addition to his prosperity, Muṣ'ab was blessed with an intelligent mind and eloquent tongue. When the Qur'an was revealed to Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) and he started inviting people to Islam, Muṣ'ab was one of the earliest persons to respond to the call of truth and embrace it.

Initially, Muṣ'ab managed to keep his faith a secret; however, because of his passion to learn the Qur'an and Sunnah from the Prophet (bpuh) himself and his devotional prayers to Allah, his acceptance of Islam became known to the disbelievers of Makkah. This struck his family like a lightning rod. His mother and the elders of his family, who until that moment had loved Muṣ'ab so dearly, suddenly turned against him. Muṣ'ab was tied up and imprisoned in a corner of his home so that he would not be able to visit the Prophet (bpuh).

When some of the Muslims were allowed to migrate to Abyssinia, Muṣ'ab also migrated with them. Since the first migration to Abyssinia did not last long, Muṣ'ab came back with the rest of the Muslims. Again, his mother tried to imprison him, but this time she could not do it out of her love and pity for him.

When Muṣ'ab came back from Abyssinia, he was bereft. He, who used to wear the most expensive clothing, was now wearing a dress made of a worn-out blanket. When Muṣ'ab came back in the company of Prophet Muhammad (bpuh), he only had a piece of cloth with patches here and there

to cover his body. When the Companions saw this spectacle, they lowered their heads out of respect and awe.

Now Muṣ‘ab devoted himself to seeking Islamic knowledge full-time. By staying in the company of Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) and learning the Qur’an, Hadith, and wisdom of the Prophet (bpuh), Muṣ‘ab’s personality was polished, his knowledge was enhanced, and his eloquence was sharpened. This is especially evident from the fact that when the people of Madinah asked Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) to send someone with them to teach them Islam, this young man was selected for the enormously profound task.

When Muṣ‘ab reached Madinah and began teaching, many were touched by his remarkable preaching style, and they embraced Islam. This raised some concerns among the elders and leaders of Madinah. One of the leaders Usayd ibn Ḥuḍayr came to Muṣ‘ab fuming with anger, holding a spear in his hand. He shouted. “Why have you come to us to corrupt our young and weak? Keep away from us if you want to stay alive!”

Muṣ‘ab remained calm and replied to him in a smiling, gentle manner:

> Please have a seat and listen to our point of view. You are a sensible and wise man. If you like what you hear from us, accept it. If you dislike it, we will stop and leave your neighbourhood.[298]

Finding the suggestion reasonable, Usayd stuck his spear in the ground and sat down in the study circle of Muṣ‘ab to listen to him. Muṣ‘ab told him about Islam and recited the Qur’an to him. Usayd was so impressed with the teachings and so moved by the Qur’an that he accepted Islam.

Another leader of Madinah Sa‘d ibn Mu‘âdh came to him filled with anger, but he too was softened by the sublime eloquence of Muṣ‘ab ibn ‘Umayr. Within a short period of time, other leaders also came, listened to

Muṣ‘ab, and accepted Islam. Through Muṣ‘ab’s positive attitude, calm responses, and eloquent speech, Islam spread quickly in Madinah. He organized the Muslims in Madinah, and with the Prophet’s permission, he started performing the Friday congregational prayers. When Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) finally migrated to Madinah, almost the entire city had embraced Islam thanks to the relentless efforts of the ideal Muslim youth – Muṣ‘ab ibn ‘Umayr.

In the Battle of Uḥud, Muṣ‘ab ibn ‘Umayr held the flag of the Muslim army. After the first initial victory of the Muslims in the battle, the Muslim archers stationed on Uḥud mountain dashed down the hill in celebration, giving the disbelievers of Makkah an opportunity to turn the victory of the Muslims into defeat. While the Muslims were dispersing in confusion, Muṣ‘ab ibn ‘Umayr held the flag and stood at his post like a rock. An enemy soldier came and cut off his hand with a sword so that the flag might fall down and proclaim defeat for the Muslims. However, Muṣ‘ab at once grabbed the flag in the other hand. The enemy soldier then slashed the other hand. Muṣ‘ab still stood, keeping the flag to his chest with the help of his bleeding arms. Finally, the enemy’s arrow pierced through him, and this Muslim youth’s soul left his body on the battlefield.[299]

By the time the Battle of Uḥud was over, many Companions of the Prophet (bpuh) had been killed in the battle including Ḥamzah ibn ‘Abdul-Muṭṭalib, the Prophet’s uncle. But when the Companions saw the body of Muṣ‘ab ibn ‘Umayr, tears flowed from their eyes, remembering this young man’s days in Makkah – when he used to enjoy the most expensive foods, clothes, perfumes, and shoes – and all the sacrifices he made after embracing Islam. Khabbâb ibn al-Aratt narrated in one hadith:

«We migrated in the company of Allah’s Messenger (bpuh), seeking Allah’s pleasure. Our reward became due and sure with Allah. Some of us died without enjoying anything of the rewards (here), and one of them was

Muṣ‘ab ibn ‘Umayr who was martyred on the day of the Battle of Uḥud. He did not leave anything except for a *namirah* (a sheet in which he was shrouded). If we covered his head with it, his feet became naked, and if we covered his feet with it, his head became naked.

The Prophet (bpuh) said to us: Cover his head with it and put some *idhkhir* (a kind of grass) over his feet or throw idhkhir over his feet.

However, for some of us, the fruits of labour have ripened, and we are collecting them.» (Bukhari)[300]

The Prophet (bpuh) stood beside Muṣ‘ab’s body with great emotion and recited the following verse of the Qur’an:

{Among the believers are men who have been true to their covenant with Allah...} *(al-Aḥzâb 33: 23)*

Upon seeing the battlefield on which lay the dead companions of Muṣ‘ab, the Prophet (bpuh) said:

«The Messenger of Allah (bpuh) testifies that you are martyrs in the sight of Allah.» (A sound hadith recorded by al-Ḥâkim and al-Bayhaqi)[301]

Such was the end of a youth who was brought up in luxury and comfort. Once he had tasted the sweetness of faith and the love of Allah and His Messenger (bpuh), he sacrificed all the luxuries of his life. When Muṣ‘ab embraced Islam, he faced severe hardships and torture. The beauty and charm of his person faded. He was also deprived of the financial support, affection, and care of his parents. However, his virtues and piety won him the appreciation of Allah and His Prophet Muhammad (bpuh), and that is the most supreme success. Indeed, the life of Muṣ‘ab ibn ‘Umayr (may Allah be pleased with him) is a role model for every Muslim youth.

Jâbir ibn ‘Abdullâh – a role model for poor Muslim youth

Jâbir ibn ‘Abdullâh ibn ‘Amr ibn Ḥarâm al-Anṣâri (may Allah be pleased with both of them) is another role model for today’s Muslim youth. Jâbir ibn ‘Abdullâh was born in Madinah fifteen years before the Prophet’s migration to Madinah. He died in 697 CE (78 AH) at the age of ninety-four. Jâbir was from the tribe of Khazraj and belonged to a poor family of Yathrib. He accepted Islam when he was a young boy. He loved Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) and always kept close to him.

Jâbir’s life is a prime example of sacrifice for others. Jâbir sacrificed his happiness for the welfare of his sisters. Despite his poverty, instead of spending his time gathering wealth, he always tried to stay in the company of the Prophet (bpuh) so that he could learn the Qur’an and Sunnah from him. He participated in nineteen battles, including Badr, under the command of Prophet Muhammad (bpuh), and he was also present during the conquest of Makkah. He spent a total of ten years in the close company of our beloved Prophet (bpuh) which is how he became one of the greatest scholars among the Companions of the Messenger of Allah (bpuh). Jâbir was one of the jurists in Madinah who used to issue legal verdicts, and everyone considered his verdicts to be reliable.

Jâbir ibn ‘Abdullâh had the honour of being the son of a man to whom Allah spoke directly, without any veil. His father ‘Abdullâh ibn ‘Amr ibn Ḥarâm was among the nobles of the tribe of Khazraj in Madinah. He embraced Islam at the second oath of ‘Aqabah, before the Prophet’s migration to Madinah. ‘Abdullâh ibn ‘Amr had a big family – one son Jâbir and seven daughters. Jâbir ibn ‘Abdullâh was not allowed by his father ‘Abdullâh to participate in the Battle of Uḥud. Jâbir had seven sisters (some historians say nine), and ‘Abdullâh wanted him to take care of his family.

Instead of fighting, Jâbir served the thirsty soldiers. Jâbir's father 'Abdullâh ibn 'Amr was the first Muslim to be martyred in the Battle of Uḥud. Jâbir was very heartbroken at the departure of his father. He narrated in one hadith:

«لَقِيَنِي رَسُولُ اللهِ صَلَّى اللهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ فَقَالَ: يَا جَابِرُ، مَا لِي أَرَاكَ مُنْكَسِرا؟ قُلْتُ: يَا رَسُولَ اللهِ، اسْتُشْهِدَ أَبِي، قُتِلَ يَوْمَ أُحُد، وَتَرَكَ عِيَالاً وَدَيْنا، قَالَ: أَفَلاَ أُبَشِّرُكَ بِمَا لَقِيَ اللهُ بِهِ أَبَاكَ؟ قُلْتُ: بَلَى، يَا رَسُولَ اللهِ، قَالَ: «مَا كَلَّمَ اللهُ أَحدا قَطُّ، إلاَّ منْ وَرَاءِ حِجَاب، وَأَحْيا أَبَاكَ، فَكَلَّمَهُ كِفَاحا فَقَالَ: يَا عَبْدِي، تَمَنَّ عَلَيَّ أُعْطِكَ، قَالَ: يا رَبِّ، تُحْيِينِي، فَأُقْتَلُ فِيكَ ثَانِيةً، قَالَ الرَّبُ - عَزَّ وَجَلَّ - إِنَّهُ قَدْ سَبَقَ مِنِّي أَنَّهُمْ لاَ يَرْجِعُونَ، قَالَ: وَأُنْزِلَتْ هَذِهِ الآيَةُ: {وَلَا تَحْسَبَنَّ الَّذِينَ قُتِلُوا فِي سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ أَمْوَاتًا...} (سورة آل عمران: 169)»

«The Messenger of Allah (bpuh) looked at me one day and said: O Jâbir! Why do I see you very sad?

I told him: O Messenger of Allah! My father was martyred (on the day of Uḥud), leaving behind debts and children.

Upon hearing this, the Messenger of Allah (bpuh) said: Shall I give you some news of how your father met Allah?

He responded: Of course, O Messenger of Allah!

The Prophet (bpuh) said: Allah does not speak to anyone except from behind a veil, but He brought your father to speak to Him directly.

He (Allah) said: (O My slave!) Do you wish that I give you anything?

He (Jâbir's father) said: O Lord! Give me life so that I may fight for You a second time.

Allah said: It has been decreed by Me that they shall not return.

Then Allah revealed:

{Do not think of those who are slain in Allah's cause as dead...} *(Âl 'Imrân 3: 169)*» (A reliable hadith recorded by at-Tirmidhi)[302]

The Prophet (bpuh) asked his Companions to help Jâbir pay his debts. Everyone helped Jâbir as much as they could. With the help and support of the Companions, Jâbir was able to pay off the debts of his father. Although Jâbir was very poor, he would often sacrifice the little food he had.

In the Battle of Trench, the Prophet (bpuh) tied two stones to his stomach to overcome hunger pangs. Jâbir invited the Prophet (bpuh) to his home along with the other Companions. During dinner, the Prophet (bpuh) supplicated for Jâbir's family as a result of which Jâbir's house was blessed by Allah.

After Jâbir got married, he went to visit the Prophet (bpuh). The fragrance of a perfume was emanating from his clothes. This incident is related in the following hadith:

«Allah's Messenger (bpuh) asked me: Did you get married, O Jabir?

I replied: Yes.

He asked: A virgin or a matron?

I replied: Not a virgin but a matron.

He asked: Why did you not marry a young girl who would have fondled with you?

I replied: O Allah's Messenger (bpuh)! My father was martyred on the day of Uḥud and left nine (orphan) daughters who are my nine sisters; I disliked to have another young girl of their age but (I sought) an (elderly) woman who could comb their hair and look after them. The Prophet (bpuh) said: You have done the right thing.» (Bukhari)[303]

Jâbir sacrificed his joy and happiness for the sake of his sisters who needed a mature woman to take care of them. Jâbir led a happy life with his wife and sisters. He was very keen to memorize hadiths, and he is one of the six Companions to narrate the most hadiths from the Prophet (bpuh). He narrated some 1,540 hadiths directly from the Messenger of Allah (bpuh). Jâbir's love for learning the Hadith did not end with the Prophet's death. Later, when the Islamic empire expanded and the Companions of the Prophet (bpuh) moved out of Madinah to settle in faraway lands, Jâbir would travel long distances if he found out that there was a Companion who knew a hadith of Prophet Muhammad (bpuh). For instance, Imam Bukhari mentioned that Jâbir ibn 'Abdullâh learnt from someone that 'Abdullâh ibn Unays had one hadith of Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) regarding equal retaliation. 'Abdullâh ibn Unays resided in Syria at that time. In order to receive this hadith directly from its narrator, Jâbir travelled for a whole month.

Jâbir knocked at the door and said: Jâbir has come to visit you.

Upon hearing his name, 'Abdullâh ibn Unays called from inside his house: Which Jâbir? Are you the son of 'Abdullâh ibn 'Amr?

Jâbir replied: Yes.

When Ibn Unays heard this, he rushed out of his home and hugged Jâbir.

Jâbir said to him: I have been informed that you relate a hadith that I did not hear from Allah's Messenger (bpuh). Either of us may die before I learn it; this is why I have come to you.

Jâbir learned the hadith and returned to Madinah. After hearing the hadith, Jâbir did not stay in Syria because he did not want to make his intention impure [by staying] for some other reason.[304]

The life of Jâbir ibn ‘Abdullâh (may Allah be pleased with both of them) is a great example for young Muslim men and women. He devoted all his efforts to spread the message of Islam. Our Muslim youth should follow the example of Jâbir in sacrificing their pleasures, comfort, and wealth as much as they can in order to seek Islamic knowledge, take care of orphans in their families, do Islamic work, and help the oppressed brothers and sisters of the Muslim community.

Conclusion: Islamic Revivalism Among the Muslim Youth

Despite all the modernization and secularization in Muslim countries and despite the world media's utmost efforts to tarnish the image of Islam on almost every news channel, we are seeing an upsurge in faith among many Muslims who are returning to Islam. Interestingly, this great revival is brought about not by the older generation of Muslims but by the Muslim youth. We are seeing the phenomenon of revival among young people all over the world. Today, we notice that in almost all Muslim countries (Arab and non-Arab), Islamic groups are predominantly comprised of students, workers, young lawyers, and doctors. Myriad young females, who were raised by Westernized Muslim mothers, are insisting on wearing the hijab, sometimes even against the wishes of their secular parents or elders.

The same resurgence of Muslim youth phenomenon can be seen at the gatherings of *'umrah* (minor pilgrimage) and Hajj. A few decades ago, most Muslims who would go for Hajj or 'umrah were the elderly who desired to carry out these obligations before their death. The situation has changed

now. Presently, the major populations of pilgrims going for Hajj or ‘umrah are young men and women in their thirties, even though youth is a time when people are most vulnerable to worldly temptations.[305]

This upsurge of Islamic revivalism among the Muslim youth is not limited to Hajj and ‘umrah, but can be seen in Muslim countries as well. For instance, Florence E. McCarthy, Ph.D. in Comparative Sociology from Michigan State University, notes that the practice of wearing the burqa has become widespread among young women in Bangladesh villages, even though just fifty years ago it was worn only by upper class women in the same towns.[306]

In the same vein, sociologists Slocum, Akhtar, and Sahi studied six sample villages in Punjab, Pakistan in which they noticed the prevalence of hijab among women of all social classes, primarily because observing hijab has become “a symbol of prestige and fashion in Punjabi villages.”[307]

Likewise, in the wake of contemporary Islamic awakening in Egypt, Reuters reports that the face veil has become more predominant among present-day youth in Egypt:

> Analysts say the headscarf, or hijab, was seen as a status indicator and was prevalent among lower-income classes [30 years ago]. Women from upper and middle classes rarely veiled at a young age and those who did usually followed fashionable interpretations of hijab. The niqab [face veil] was uncommon at that time.
>
> But the niqab has become more prevalent. Women in flowing black robes are a common sight strolling through Egypt’s fanciest shopping malls and five-star hotels, as well as in shanties.[308]

It is surprising for Western political scientists that this surge of religious commitment in Muslim societies is seen not among the older, more conservative people, but among young university graduates who are often seeking degrees in medicine, engineering,
or science.

For instance, Carrie Rosefsky Wickham, Professor, Department of Political Science, Emory University (Atlanta, USA), studied the trend of Islamic revivalism in Egypt. She asserts:

> ...the prototypical Islamic activist is not an illiterate peasant or laborer but a young, upwardly mobile university student or professional, often with a scientific or technical degree.[309]

In Turkey, the same pattern is seen as in Egypt of university students returning to or embracing Islam. In one study published in the 1996 issue of the *British Journal of Sociology*, Dr. Kayhan Mutlu studied religious belief and commitment among the university students in Ankara, Turkey. He conducted the surveys in 1978 and then again in 1991 at the University of Ankara. Dr. Mutlu found that Turkish students surveyed in 1991 showed evidence of far greater dedication and commitment to Islam than those in 1978. Modern-day Turkish students are more proud to express their belief in God, the existence of heaven and hell, the Day of Judgement, and the Qur'an as a revealed book. This is a remarkable drift in thought in the secular state of Turkey, and it has happened among the young, educated population of the country.[310]

A similar trend was observed by Christian G. Kiem, who conducted a sociological study of young men and women living in northern Moluccas, Indonesia. Kiem focused his study on the impact of two competing but completely different influences – Westernization and Islamic reformism – on the young people of the Muslim-majority city of Ternate. He notes that

this process of re-Islamization is not limited to Java, but has its impact on young Muslim communities on remote Indonesian islands as well. In his study, which was published in the February 1993 issue of the *Journal of Social Issues in Southeast Asia*, he argues:

> ...the recent religious revivalism in several Muslim countries is particularly widespread among youth for whom orthodox Islam has the appeal of a strictly ordered ideological framework which can serve as a defensive mechanism against runaway Western modernity.[311]

However, Kiem also clarifies that the Islamic revivalism among the Muslim youth is not a mere reaction to Western modernity; it also achieves purification of the individual:

> Islamic resurgence, however, has to be understood not only as a reaction to socio-cultural modernization but also as an intra-Islamic development aiming at the purification of religious life from pre-Islamic beliefs and practices. Thus, the emergence of young 'Muslim puritans' has contributed to a reformist-traditionalist split in North Moluccan Islam.[312]

Political scientist Mohammed K. Shadid conducted a sociological survey of Muslims living in the West Bank and Gaza in 1988. He reported that between 1978 and 1984 there was an increase in the performance of the five daily prayers, fasting during Ramadan, recitation of the Qur'an, and studying religious literature among the Muslims of this region. This increase is more significant among college-educated youth. For instance, 14.7 percent of those in the age group 25-30 reported performing daily prayers as compared to a much smaller percentage of people in the same age group in 1978. Similarly, 11 percent of college youth reported increased frequency of prayer, whereas this percentage was only 5.1 percent among illiterate respondents.[313]

This wave of Islamic awakening among the Muslim youth is observed not only in Muslim countries, but also in non-Muslim countries. In an American Muslim poll conducted by Zogby International for Muslims in the American Public Square, it was shown that more than two-thirds of Muslims living in the USA observe daily prayers. This percentage is higher among women and increases significantly among young people.[314]

In the same vein, there is evidence of increasing religiosity among young British Muslim men and women, as noted by Lewis and Gilliat-Ray in their anthropological and sociological studies of Muslims in Britain.[315]

According to the data on Muslims in France presented in a report of the conference organized by New York University's Center for Dialogues:

> …by various measures, commitment to Islam has been growing among younger generations born in France. Compared to a decade ago, more Muslims in the 20-29 age cohorts agree that religion is 'more important' in their lives, and far fewer declare the 'no religion' option. In addition, as they have aged, formerly less observant young people declare themselves to be more observant. Finally, these patterns of religious commitment have been more pronounced among young women.[316]

Western social scientists claim that the increasing trend of wearing modest dresses among young Muslim girls in the West could be indicative of either a 'religious revival' or an 'assertion of identity', especially because it is happening in public, outside the boundaries of mosques.[317]

This reawakening phenomenon has been succinctly explained by American Orientalist and historian John L. Esposito in his book *Islam: The Straight Path*. He writes:

> The history of modern Islam has challenged many presuppositions and expectations. The prevailing wisdom was that modernization required the separation of religion from public life, as modernizing societies progressively and inevitably became secularized. The very process of modernization, which includes the impact of reason, science, and technology, was seen as encouraging and enhancing this secularization process…Islamic revivalism…has countered and discredited such a uniform, evolutionary view of historical change and development. Revivalism has been most visible in countries where modernism had been strongest. Moreover technology and modern education have often been used to reinforce rather than undermine belief and practice.[318]

To sum up, all this strongly suggests that a significant number of Muslim youth are increasingly turning towards religion. This increased attachment to Islam seen among our youth is a sign of the divine promise of Allah in the Qur'an:

{They want to extinguish Allah's light with their utterances, but Allah will perfect His light, even though the disbelievers hate it.} *(aṣ-Ṣaff 61: 8)*

Also, Allah promises the believers in the Qur'an:

{So truly with hardship comes ease.} *(ash-Sharḥ 94: 5)*

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Glossary of Islamic Terms[319]

abu (or abi)	أَبُو، أَبِي	father (of)
Anṣâr	أَنْصار	"helpers": The Muslim citizens of Madinah who gave refuge to the Prophet (bpuh) and the other Muslim emigrants from Makkah
'awrah	عَوْرة	the part of a person's body that must be screened from public view; for males it is the area between the navel and the knees, and for females it is everything except the hands and the face
banu (or bani)	بَنُو، بَنِي	*lit.* 'children (of)'; *usu.* referring to a tribe that claims a common ancestor
Dajjâl	الدَّجَّال	the antichrist (anti-Christ); in Islamic teachings, he is a false Messiah who will deceive the people and cause harm to humankind until he is killed by 'Eesâ (pbuh)

Eid (‘eed)	عِيد	*lit.* ‘festival’: one of the two annual Islamic celebrations, one at the end of Ramadan and the other at the culmination of the Hajj
fatwa (fatwâ)	فَتْوَى	religious decision or decree
fitnah	فِتْنَة	*lit*. ‘trial’ or ‘temptation’; (attempting to sow) discord between Muslims
Hadith (Ḥadeeth)	حَدِيث	the collected statements and actions of Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) that with the Qur’an form the basis of Islamic law
hadith (ḥadeeth)	حَدِيث	a statement or action of Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) that was remembered and recorded by his Companions and followers
Hajj (Ḥajj)	حَجّ	the major pilgrimage to the Sacred Mosque, site of the Kaaba in Makkah, to be undertaken by every able Muslim once in his or her lifetime
hijab (ḥijâb)	حِجَاب	veil ordained by Allah for believing women
imam	إِمَام	leader; prayer leader
jinn (plural of jinni)	جِنّ	non-human, rational beings created by Allah from fire, often referred to as ‘demons’ or ‘devils’. They

have free will like humans: some are Muslims, others disbelievers; some are obedient to Allah, others disobedient. Satan is a jinni. Some disobedient jinn mislead people into thinking that they can foretell the future, near or distant, or provide people with riches or some sort of power.

Kaaba (Ka'bah) الْكَعْبَة the House of Allah in Makkah, originally built by Prophets Ibrâheem and Ismâ'eel, which Muslims face when they pray

maḥram مَحْرَم a degree of consanguinity precluding marriage; a man whom a woman may not marry due to the close blood or marriage relationship, e.g., her father, brother, son, uncle, or father-in-law

Marwah المرْوَة one of the two hills between which pilgrims must hurry back and forth during the rites of the Hajj and the *'umrah*

Quraysh قُرَيْش the dominant tribe in Makkah at the time of the Prophet's mission; their society was based on polytheism

Ramadan (Ramaḍân) رَمَضَان the ninth month in the Islamic calendar; the month of obligatory fasting and the month in which the first verses of the Qur'an were revealed

Ṣafâ الصَّفَا one of the two hills between which pilgrims must hurry back and forth during the rites of the Hajj and

		the *‘umrah*
Sharia (Sharee‘ah)	شَرِيعة	Islamic law derived from the Qur’an and the Sunnah.
shaykh	شَيْخ	teacher; mentor; scholar
soorah or soorat	سُورَة	chapter of the Qur’an
Sunnah	سُنَّة	the practice and collected sayings of Prophet Muhammad (bpuh) that together with the Qur’an forms the basis of Islamic law
Ummah	أُمَّة	community or nation: *usu*. used to refer to the entire global community of Muslims
‘umrah	عُمْرَة	a minor, non-obligatory pilgrimage to Makkah
Zamzam	زَمْزَم	the blessed spring of water that Allah caused to gush out at baby Ismâ‘eel’s feet; located near the Kaaba

Notes

1 Wherever possible, Arabic terms have been translated into English. In cases where we have chosen to retain the Arabic, the transliterated word or phrase is shown in italics the first time it appears in the text; the term is also defined in the glossary found at the end of this book. (Editor)

2 al-'Uthaymīn, *The Islamic Awakening*.

3 All hadiths in this text have been checked and verified by IIPH's researchers. It is rare, but it does happen that a hadith is not verifiable within the timeframe of researching and editing the book. In that case, a decision is made by the editorial board whether or not to include the hadith. It is IIPH's policy not to include weak hadiths or fabricated (fake) hadiths in our publications. If a weak hadith is included in any text, it is only because the author of the book discusses it as a weak hadith. (Editor)

4 Muslim, *Ṣaḥeeḥ Muslim*, The Book of Tribulations and Portents of the Last Hour, "The Rest Of The Ahadith About Ad-Dajjal"; an-Nawawi, *Sharḥ an-Nawawi*.

5 Bukhari, *Ṣaḥeeḥ al-Bukhâri*, Book of Prophets, hadith no. 3337.

6 Bukhari, *Ṣaḥeeḥ al-Bukhâri*, Book of Oneness, Uniqueness of Allah, hadith no. 7407.

7 Bukhari, *Ṣaḥeeḥ al-Bukhâri*, Book of Fighting for the Cause of Allah, hadith no. 3055.

8 The hadith was also recorded by Ibn Ḥajar in *Tahdheeb at-Tahdheeb* from the narration of Ibn as-Sakan. He gave the following verdict of Ibn as-Sakan about his hadith, "All the narrators in this hadith's chain of narration are sound." Likewise, Imam az-Zarqâni has recorded this hadith in *Sharḥ az-Zarqâni* and declared this hadith's chain of narration sound from the narration of Râshid ibn Sa'd. It was also recorded by al-Haythami in *Majma' az-Zawâ'id*, 7:335, and he also graded this hadith's chain sound.

9 Aḥmad, *Musnad Aḥmad*, 2:67, hadith no. 5353. This hadith is also recorded by aṭ-Ṭabarâni, *al-Mu'jam al-Kabeer*, 12:307, hadith no. 13197 as well as al-Haythami, *Majma' az-Zawâ'id*,

7:347. According to al-Haythami, one narrator Ibn Is-ḥâq in this hadith's chain is considered weak.

10 Muslim, *Ṣaḥeeḥ Muslim*, The Book of Tribulations and Portents of the Last Hour, "Ibn Sayyad," hadith no. 2927; an-Nawawi, *Sharḥ an-Nawawi*.

11 Muslim, *Ṣaḥeeḥ Muslim*, The Book of Tribulations and Portents of the Last Hour, "ad-Dajjâl," hadith no. 2937; an-Nawawi, *Sharḥ an-Nawawi*.

12 Roberts et al., *Kids & media*.

13 The translations of the meanings of the verses of the Qur'an in this book have been taken (with some changes to the text) from *The Majestic Qur'an* translated by Nasiruddin al-Khattab, under publication with IIPH.

14 Jumi, *Radd al-Adh-hân*.

15 Bukhari, *Ṣaḥeeḥ al-Bukhâri*, Book of Obligatory Charity Tax, "To give objects of charity with the right hand," hadith no. 1423; Muslim, *Ṣaḥeeḥ Muslim*, The Book of Zakâh, "The virtue of concealing (what is given in) charity," hadith no. 1031.

16 al-Ḥâkim, *al-Mustadrak*, hadith no. 7927. Al-Ḥâkim has graded this hadith sound according to the conditions of Bukhari and Muslim. Shaykh al-Albâni also declared this hadith sound in his annotation of *Iqtiḍâ' al-'Ilm al-'Aml*, no. 170.

17 Shaykh al-Albâni also declared this hadith sound. See, for example, *Ṣaḥeeḥ Sunan at-Tirmidhi*, no. 1969 and *as-Silsilat al-Aḥâdeeth aṣ-Ṣaḥeeḥah*, no. 946.

18 Pearce, *Evolution's End*.

19 Staley, *Between form and freedom*.

20 McCraty et al., "The effects of emotions on short term heart rate variability."

21 Umetani et al., "Heart Rate Variability and Heart Rate."

22 Bukhari, *Ṣaḥeeḥ al-Bukhâri*, Book of Funerals, hadith no. 1385; Muslim, *Ṣaḥeeḥ Muslim*, The Book of Destiny, hadith no. 2658; an-Nawawi, *Sharḥ an-Nawawi*; Mâlik, *Muwaṭṭa' Imâm Mâlik*.

23 Muslim, *Ṣaḥeeḥ Muslim*, The Book of Virtue, Enjoining Good Manners, and Joining of the Ties of Kinship, hadith no. 2628; an-Nawawi, *Sharḥ an-Nawawi*.

24 Bennabi, *On the Origins of Human Society*.

25 aṭ-Ṭabari, *Tafseer aṭ-Ṭabari*.

26 Bennabi, *On the Origins of Human Society*.

27 Huntington, *The Clash of Civilizations*, 65-66.

28 Abdal Hakim Murad, "Islam and the New Millennium," accessed August 15, 2015, http://www.sunnah.org/audio/millen.htm.

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31 Ibn Katheer, *Stories of the Prophets*.

32 Aḥmad, *Musnad Aḥmad*. Imam Aḥmad has recorded this hadith according to the conditions (authenticity criteria) set forth by Imam Bukhari. This is why this hadith is sound.

33 Bukhari, *Ṣaḥeeḥ al-Bukhâri*, Book of One-fifth of Booty to the Cause of Allah, "The statement of the Prophet صَلَّى اللهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ: Booty has been made legal for you Muslims."

34 Muslim, *Ṣaḥeeḥ Muslim*, The Book of *Zuhd* and Softening of Hearts, "The Story Of The People Of The Ditch And The Magician, The Monk And The Boy"; an-Nawawi, *Sharḥ an-Nawawi*.

35 Muslim, *Ṣaḥeeḥ Muslim*, The Book of Tribulations and Portents of the Last Hour, "ad-Dajjâl," hadith no. 2937; an-Nawawi, *Sharḥ an-Nawawi*.

36 Muslim, *Ṣaḥeeḥ Muslim*, The Book of Tribulations and Portents of the Last Hour, "Description Of Ad-Dajjal; Al-Madinah Is Forbidden To Him; He Will Kill A Believer And Bring Him Back To Life," hadith no. 2938; an-Nawawi, *Sharḥ an-Nawawi*.

37 Bukhari, *Ṣaḥeeḥ al-Bukhâri*, Book of Merits of the Helpers in Madinah, hadith no. 3919.

38 Bukhari, *Ṣaḥeeḥ al-Bukhâri*, Book of Merits of the Helpers in Madinah, hadith no. 3920.

39 Bukhari, *Ṣaḥeeḥ al-Bukhâri*, Book of Merits of the Helpers in Madinah, "Al-Qasama in the Pre-Islamic Period of Ignorance," hadith no. 3846.

40 Ibn Hishâm, *as-Seerat an-Nabawiyah*, 1.

41 Bukhari, *Ṣaḥeeḥ al-Bukhâri*, Book of Judgments, "It is desirable that a scribe should be honest and wise," hadith no. 7191.

42 Aḥmad, *Musnad Aḥmad*, vol. 1, no. 390, 432. Imam Aḥmad has recorded this hadith according to the conditions (authenticity criteria) set forth by Imams Bukhari and Muslim. Hence, this hadith is sound.

43 Bukhari, *Ṣaḥeeḥ al-Bukhâri*, Book of One-fifth of Booty to the Cause of Allah, "Khumus from the spoils of a killed infidel," hadith no. 3141. Also narrated by Muslim, *Ṣaḥeeḥ Muslim*, hadith no. 1752; al-Ḥâkim, *al-Mustadrak*, 3:425; al-Bayhaqi, *Dalâ'il an-Nubuwwah*, 3:83.

44 Aḥmad, *Musnad Aḥmad*, 3:235; this hadith was also recorded by al-Bayhaqi in *as-Sunan al-Kubrâ*, 2:199. According to the researchers of *Musnad Aḥmad*, this hadith's chain of narration is sound.

45 Bukhari, *Ṣaḥeeḥ al-Bukhâri*, Book of Call to Prayers, "If there are many travellers, Adhan and Iqama should be pronounced, (the same is to be observed) in 'Arafat and Al-Muzdalifa too," hadith no. 631; Muslim, *Ṣaḥeeḥ Muslim*, The Book of Mosques and Places of Prayer, "Who is more entitled to lead the prayer," hadith no. 674.

46 Ibn Mandhoor, *Lisân al-'Arab*, 11:237.

47 al-Qurṭubi, *at-Tadhkirah*.

48 Wheatstone, "Contributions to the Physiology of Vision."

49 Nielsen Media Research, *2000 Report on Television*.

50 Kubey and Csikszentmihalyi, *Television and the Quality of Life*.

51 Biocca, "New Media Technology and Youth."

52 Kay, "Computer Software."

53 Montgomery, *Web of Deception*.

54 Winn, *The Plug-In Drug*.

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63 Winn, *The Plug-In Drug*.

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74 "100 Leading National Advertisers."

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76 Mushtaq, *Growing a Beard*.

77 Winn, *The Manipulated Mind*, 195.

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80 Rhoades and Jernigan, "Risky Messages in Alcohol Advertising."

81 Quoted in "Alcohol Advertising Standards Violations Most Common in Magazines with Youthful Audiences."

82 "Alcohol Advertising Standards Violations."

83 Roberts et al., *Kids & media*.

84 Roberts et al., *Kids & media*.

85 Bloom, *The Closing of the American Mind*, 68.

86 Bloom, *The Closing of the American Mind*.

87 aṭ-Ṭabari, *Tafseer aṭ-Ṭabari*.

88 al-Bayhaqi, *as-Sunan al-Kubrâ*; Ibn Katheer, *Tafseer Ibn Katheer*.

89 aṭ-Ṭabari, *Tafseer aṭ-Ṭabari*.

90 Bukhari, *Ṣaḥeeḥ al-Bukhâri*, Book of Drinks, 7:232, hadith no. 5590.

91 Ibn Mâjah, *Sunan Ibn Mâjah*, Book of Tribulations, "Punishments," 3:447, hadith no. 4020. This is an authentic hadith. Ibn al-Qayyim declared it as sound. Shaykh al-Albâni also graded it sound in *as-Silsilat al-Aḥâdeeth aṣ-Ṣaḥeeḥah.*

92 Brown and Hendee, "Adolescents and their Music."

93 Mushtaq, *The Music Made Me Do It*.

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101 Baig, *Slippery Stone*.

102 Baig, *Slippery Stone*.

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112 Ken Burbary, “Facebook Demographics Revisited – 2011 Statistics,” accessed August 15, 2015, http://www.socialmediatoday.com/content/facebook-demographics-revisited-2011-statistics.

113 Summarized from Internet World Stats, “World Internet Users Statistics,” accessed August 24, 2015, www.internetworldstats.com/stats.htm.

* “Penetration rate” corresponds to the ratio of Facebook users in relation to the total number of estimated population in each world region expressed as a percentage.

114 Baig, “Facebook: Social Networking or Social Engineering?”

115 Baig, “Facebook: Social Networking or Social Engineering?”

116 “Cox Communications Teen Internet Safety Survey, Wave II – in Partnership with the National Center for Missing & Exploited Children (NCMEC) and John Walsh,” accessed August 15, 2015, http://www.cox.com/wcm/en/aboutus/datasheet/takecharge/archives/2007-teen-survey.pdf?campcode=takecharge-archive-link_2007-survey_0511.

117 at-Tirmidhi, *Sunan at-Tirmidhi*. This hadith was graded reliable by Shaykh al-Albâni in *Ṣaḥeeḥ at-Targheeb wat-Tarheeb*, hadith no. 2881. Likewise, Shaykh Abul-Is-ḥâq al-Ḥuwayni has classed this hadith as reliable in his annotation of *al-Arba‘oon aṣ-Ṣughrâ* by al-Bayhaqi.

118 Baig, “Facebook: Social Networking or Social Engineering?”

119 Summarized from “Cox Communications Teen Internet Safety Survey, Wave II.”

120 “Cox Communications Teen Internet Safety Survey.”

121 Biocca, “New Media Technology and Youth.”

122 Singhal and Zyda, *Networked Virtual Environments*; Benford et al., “User Embodiment in Collaborative Virtual Environments.”

123 Al-Musnad, *Islamic Fatawa Regarding Women*, 96.

124 Islam Q&A, “Men and women talking in chat rooms,” accessed August 15, 2015, http://islamqa.info/en/ref/34841.

125 at-Tirmidhi, *Sunan at-Tirmidhi*, hadith no. 2165. Shaykh al-Albâni authenticated it in *Ṣaḥeeḥ Sunan at-Tirmidhi*.

126 at-Tirmidhi, *Sunan at-Tirmidhi*, hadith no. 1173. This hadith’s chain of narration is reliable, and Shaykh al-Albâni has classified it as sound. This hadith is also recorded by Ibn Ḥibbân in *Ṣaḥeeḥ Ibn Ḥibbân* and in aṭ-Ṭabarâni in *al-Mu‘jam al-Kabeer*.

127 “Fatwa of al-Azhar University Scholar about Facebook.”

128 Suler, “Do Boys (and Girls) Just Wanna Have Fun?”

129 Suler, “Do Boys (and Girls) Just Wanna Have Fun?”

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